A NOVEL OF PAIN, HEALING & HOPE

BEHIND THE DARK,

THERE IS A LIGHT

Even after the darkest night, hope remains.

ESHA NADEEM

AUTHOR

Disclaimer

Behind the Dark, There Is a Light is a work of fiction written to offer comfort, hope, and a gentle reminder that even in our darkest moments, life can still hold a little light.

All characters, names, events, places, and situations in this novel are products of the author's imagination. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or deceased, or real events is purely coincidental.

This story explores themes of grief, loss, guilt, emotional pain, healing, and the courage to begin again. Although some experiences may reflect feelings that many people encounter in real life, the story is not intended to replace professional mental health advice, counseling, or support.

Grief is a deeply personal journey. There is no single timeline for healing, and moving forward does not mean forgetting those we have lost. Sometimes, healing begins with the smallest things—a conversation, a memory, a handwritten letter, or simply finding the strength to face another day.

If you see a part of yourself on these pages, please remember that you do not have to carry everything

alone. Asking for help is not a sign of weakness, and taking your time is not a failure.

This book is for anyone who has ever felt lost in the darkness, who has blamed themselves for things beyond their control, or who has quietly wondered whether happiness is still possible after loss.

May these pages remind you that even when the light seems far away, your story is not over.

And sometimes, the first step toward the light is simply choosing to stay.

A Personal Note to My Readers

Dear Reader,

Before you begin this book, I want you to know something.

This story means more to me than just words written on pages. *Behind the Dark, There Is a Light* is a reminder of the feelings we often struggle to explain, the battles we fight quietly, and the parts of ourselves we sometimes hide because we are afraid no one will understand.

I wrote this story hoping that somewhere between these pages, you might find a feeling you recognize, a thought you have never been able to put into words, or a small piece of comfort you didn't know you needed.

Ayla's journey is not just about pain. It is about everything that pain leaves behind—the questions, the silence, the fear of trusting again, and the difficult process of finding yourself after life has changed you in ways you never expected.

I believe that sometimes, the people who seem the strongest are the ones who need someone to ask them if they are truly okay. Sometimes, a person can be

surrounded by others and still feels completely alone. And sometimes, the hardest battles are the ones no one ever sees.

If you have ever experienced something like that, I hope you find a little part of yourself in Ayla.

I don't want you to read this book and believe that healing is easy, or that every wound disappears over time. Some things take longer to understand. Some memories stay with us. Some goodbyes continue to hurt even after we have learned to live without the people we lost.

But I also believe that we are more than the things that hurt us.

We are allowed to begin again. We are allowed to change. We are allowed to choose ourselves, even when doing so feels unfamiliar. And we are allowed to believe that something beautiful can still find us after the most difficult chapters of our lives.

If you are reading this while going through a difficult time, please be gentle with yourself. You don't need to have everything figured out. You don't need to be strong every single day. And you don't need to rush your healing just because the world expects you to move on.

Take your time. Breathe. Give yourself the understanding you may have spent years giving to everyone else.

I hope this book reminds you that your story is still being written.

And perhaps, when you turn to the final page, you will understand why I chose the title *Behind the Dark, There Is a Light*.

Because darkness may be a part of our story, but it does not have to be the whole story.

Thank you for giving me a little of your time, and for allowing Ayla's story to become a part of yours. I hope you find something on these pages that stays with you long after you have finished reading.

With all my heart,

Esha Nadeem

Author of Behind the Dark, There Is a Light

The story concept

Meet Ayla Rahman, a 23-year-old woman who once filled notebooks with stories about people who survived impossible things. She believed every broken character deserved a second chance.

Then life became personal.

After a devastating loss and painful betrayal, Ayla gradually withdraws from the people around her. She stops writing. She avoids old friends. The future, once full of possibilities, becomes a room she cannot bring herself to enter.

She continues living her ordinary life, but inside, she feels as if something essential has disappeared.

One rainy evening, while sorting through belongings in her late grandmother's old house, Ayla discovers a collection of handwritten letters. They are addressed to people she does not know. Each letter tells the story of someone who once stood at the edge of giving up their dreams, relationships, or sense of self—and the small, unexpected moment that helped them find their way forward.

One letter contains a line written in Urdu:

"اندھیرا ہمیشہ روشنی کی غیر موجودگی نہیں ہوتا؛ کبھی کبھی یہ روشنی تک پہنچنے کا راستہ ہوتا ہے۔"

"Darkness is not always the absence of light; sometimes, it is the road that leads us to it."

Ayla begins searching for the people behind the letters. Their stories draw her into a world she had stopped noticing: a widowed bookseller, a young man carrying the weight of a failed dream, a mother rebuilding her life, and a child who plants flowers in broken pots.

As Ayla learns about their lives, she discovers that every person has a private darkness—and that the smallest acts of human kindness can change the direction of a life.

But the letters also hide a truth about her grandmother, one that challenges everything Ayla thought she understood about love, loss, and the past.

Her journey is not about becoming the person she used to be. It is about discovering who she can become now.

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Chapter One

The Girl Who Forgot How to Feel

"Some people do not break it all at once. They disappear slowly, in pieces so small that even they fail to notice."

The morning Ayla Rahman realized she had forgotten how to feel; the sun was shining.

It was a beautiful morning; the kind people wrote poetry about it. Golden light slipped through the curtains, birds sang from the branches outside her window, and somewhere in the neighborhood, a woman was calling her child home for breakfast.

The world was awake.

The world was moving.

And Ayla wished it would stop asking her to move with it.

She lay beneath her blanket, staring at the ceiling. There was a thin crack running from one corner to the other, like a river drawn by an uncertain hand. She had been looking at it for weeks, perhaps months. She had once imagined that the crack resembled a map, a road leading somewhere she had never been.

Now it was only a crack.

Funny, she thought, how even the things we once found beautiful can become ordinary when something inside us changes.

Her phone vibrated on the bedside table.

Three messages from a friend. Two missed calls from her mother. A notification reminding her of a deadline she had already missed.

Ayla turned the phone facedown.

Not now.

Those two words had become her favorite way of avoiding life.

Not now, when someone asked how she was feeling.

Not now, when her mother suggested she go outside.

Not now, when the old version of herself occasionally appeared in her memory, carrying notebooks and ridiculous dreams, she was convinced that one day she would write a book that would make someone feel less alone.

Not now.

Perhaps later.

She had been promising herself later for so long that she had begun to wonder whether later another word for was simply never.

There was a time when Ayla loved mornings.

She loved the smell of tea drifting from the kitchen, the warmth of sunlight on open pages, and the quiet hour before the world became noisy. She would sit beside the window with a notebook on her lap and write about strangers whose lives she had invented.

A woman who waited for a letter that never arrived.

A man who visited the sea because it was the only place where his silence did not feel strange.

A little girl who believed the moon followed her home because it was worried about her.

Ayla gave all of them something she had always believed every human being deserved.

A second chance.

She did not know when she had stopped believing the same thing about herself.

Perhaps it happened gradually. Perhaps it had begun on the day she lost someone she thought would always be there. Or perhaps it had started earlier, in all the moments when she swallowed her feelings because other people had problems of their own.

Pain rarely announces the moment it arrives to stay.

Sometimes it sits quietly in the corner of your life until one day you realize it has taken your favorite chair.

Ayla closed her eyes.

She did not want to remember.

But memories never need permission.

At eleven, her mother knocked on the bedroom door.

“Ayla? Beta, are you awake?”

“Hmm.”

“Will you come downstairs? I've made breakfast.”

“I'm not hungry.”

A pause.

“You haven't been hungry for days.”

“Ammi, please. I'm fine.”

The words came too quickly.

Her mother did not answer immediately. Ayla could picture her standing outside the door, one hand resting against the wooden frame, trying to decide whether to enter or leave her daughter alone.

Finally, she heard her footsteps retreat down the hallway.

Ayla stared at the door.

There was a strange cruelty in being loved when you did not know how to explain what was wrong. The people who loved you kept reaching for you, and you kept stepping backward—not because you wanted to hurt them, but because you no longer knew how to let anyone close.

She wanted to call her mother back.

She wanted to say, *Ammi, mujhe nahi pata mere saath kya ho raha hai.*

Mother, I don't know what is happening to me.

She wanted to admit that some mornings she woke up already exhausted, as though she had spent the entire night carrying something enormous. That she could laugh at a joke and feel nothing afterward. That she missed being happy in a way that made her chest ache.

Most of all, she wanted someone to understand without requiring her to explain every broken piece.

But wanting to be understood and knowing how to speak were two entirely different things.

So, she remained silent.

And her mother continued down the stairs.

By the afternoon, the clouds had gathered over the city.

Ayla finally got out of bed and wandered into the small room she called her to study. It was not much of a study anymore. Books leaned against one another on the shelves, loose papers covered the desk, and a cup of pens stood untouched beside an old notebook.

She pulled out the chair.

For a moment, she simply looked at the notebook.

Its cover was blue, faded at the corners. On the first page, in handwriting that seemed to belong to another person, were the words:

One day, I will write something that reminds someone to stay.

Ayla traced the sentence with her finger.

Then she closed the notebook.

A bitter smile appeared on her face.

“How foolish,” she whispered.

She could write beautiful endings for imaginary people. She could invent brave characters who walked through fire and emerged carrying pieces of the sun. She could fill entire pages with promises that tomorrow would be different.

But when it came to her own life, she had no idea what to write about.

Maybe that was the cruelest part of being a writer.

You learned to give your characters words for the things you could never say yourself.

Outside, the first drops of rain struck the window.

Ayla stood and watched the sky grow darker.

She had always loved the rain. Her grandmother used to say that the earth smelled different when it was given another chance.

“Dekha, Ayla?” Her grandmother would say, opening the windows whenever the first rain arrived. “**Zameen kitni bhi sookh jaye, baarish ka intezar karna nahi chhorti**.”

Look, Ayla. No matter how dry the earth becomes, it never stops waiting for the rain.

Her grandmother had a sentence for everything.

Or so Ayla believed it.

Now, remembering her voice felt like touching a bruise.

It had been eight months since Zehra Begum died.

Eight months since the house in which Ayla had spent every summer of her childhood became a place she could no longer bear to visit.

Eight months since she had told herself she would go through her grandmother's belongings when she felt ready.

She had not felt ready.

Perhaps she never would.

Her phone rang again.

This time, it was her mother.

Ayla answered.

“Beta,” her mother said gently, “I need you to do something for me.”

“What?”

“I found the keys to Nani's house. I think we should go there this weekend. We can't leave everything untouched forever.”

Ayla looked toward the rain.

For a few seconds, she considered saying no.

Then something strange happened.

She remembered the last time she had seen her grandmother alive.

Zehra Begum had been sitting by the window, wrapped in her old shawl, holding a book she had not been reading. She had looked smaller than Ayla remembered,

but her eyes were still full of that familiar, impossible tenderness.

“Ayla,” she had said, “promise me something.”

“What, Nani?”

“When life becomes too heavy, don't make permanent decisions about your entire future based on how you feel on one terrible day.”

Ayla laughed softly.

“Nani, you make everything sound like a lecture.”

“And you make everything sound like it can wait.”

They laughed together.

Ayla had promised nothing.

Now, standing alone in her studies, she wished she could return that afternoon and give her grandmother a better answer.

“Yes,” she said on the phone. “Let's go.”

Her mother sounded relieved.

“Good. We'll go on Saturday.”

When the call ended, Ayla remained by the window.

The rain had grown heavier, blurring the buildings across the street. Somewhere beyond the clouds, the sun still existed. She knew that. She had learned it in school, read it in books, and heard it in a thousand familiar sayings.

Knowing something was true, however, was not the same as being able to feel it.

She pressed her forehead against the cool glass.

“Where are you?” She whispered.

She was not sure whether she was speaking to her grandmother, her lost happiness, or the person she used to be.

Perhaps she was speaking to all three.

No one answered.

That night, Ayla dreamed of a house she had never seen before.

It stood at the end of a narrow street, surrounded by darkness. Its windows were closed, its garden overgrown, and its walls marked by years of rain.

Yet beneath the front door, a thin line of golden light spilled onto the ground.

Ayla walked toward it.

She wanted to knock.

She wanted to run.

She wanted to know who was inside.

But before she could decide, a voice rose from somewhere beyond the door.

Not loud.

Not urgent.

Just familiar.

"Andhera chahe jitna bhi gehra ho, roshni ka ek raasta hamesha baqi rehta hai."

No matter how deep the darkness becomes, a path toward the light remains.

Ayla woke up before dawn.

For a long time, she lay perfectly still, trying to remember where she had heard those words.

Then she sat up and reached for the blue notebook on her bedside table.

She opened it to the first page.

One day, I will write something that reminds someone to stay.

She stared at the sentence.

Outside, the sky was still dark.

But somewhere beyond the rooftops, morning was coming.

For the first time in months, Ayla did not close the notebook.

She turned the page.

And I wrote one sentence.

I don't know how to find the light.

She paused, her pen hovering above the paper.

Then, beneath it, she added:

But perhaps I can begin by admitting that I am in the dark.

She put the pen down.

It was not a happy ending. It was not even the beginning of a happy day.

It was only a sentence.

A small, honest sentence written by a girl who had forgotten how to feel.

But sometimes, the first light does not enter through a window.

Sometimes, it begins with the courage to tell the truth.

And Ayla, though she did not yet know it, had just taken her first step.

CHAPTER TWO

A House Full of Silence

Some houses keep our memories. Others keep the words we were never brave enough to say.

The house looked smaller than Ayla remembered.

Perhaps it was the walls that had grown old. Perhaps it was the garden, once crowded with flowers, that had surrendered to the weeds. Or perhaps grief had changed the way she saw familiar things, making every room seem like a place she had visited in another lifetime.

She stood outside the iron gate, holding a ring of keys in her palm.

Rainwater glistened on the bars. A vine crept across the boundary wall, and fallen yellow flowers lay scattered along the narrow path to the front door.

Everything was still there.

The gate. The windows. The little porch where her grandmother used to sit in the evenings.

Everything, except the people who had made it a home.

Her mother stood beside her beneath a black umbrella.

“Open it, beta,” she said gently. “We'll get wet.”

Ayla looked down at the keys.

For eight months, she had avoided this house. She had told herself she needed more time, that she would return when the memories no longer hurt so much.

But standing outside the gate, she understood something she had been trying not to understand.

Time has passed.

The pain had not asked its permission to stay.

“Ammi?” She whispered.

Her mother turned toward her.

“What if it doesn't feel like home anymore?”

Her mother was quiet for a moment. Then she reached for Ayla's hand.

“Ghar sirf deewaron ka naam nahi hota, Ayla.”

A home is not merely a collection of walls.

“Sometimes, it is the place where we leave a part of ourselves. And sometimes, it is where we come to find it again.”

Ayla wanted to believe her.

She really did.

But beautiful sentences had begun to frighten her. They sounded like promises, and she had learned how painful promises could become when life refused to keep them.

She pushed the smallest key into the lock.

The gate opened with a long, reluctant creak.

Ayla stepped inside.

For a moment, she felt as though she were entering a memory that had been waiting for her.

And she was afraid of what it might have asked her to remember.

The first thing she noticed was the smell.

Old wood. Dust. Damp curtains. The faint fragrance of rosewater her grandmother used to sprinkle around the living room before guests arrived.

It was the smell of childhood.

Of summer afternoons and unfinished homework. Of tea served in little cups. Of a woman who always seemed to know when someone was sad, even when they insisted otherwise.

Ayla stood in the hallway.

The grandfather's clock remained frozen at 4:17. A crack ran across the mirror above the console table. Family photographs lined up the wall, their smiling faces untouched by the years that had changed everything.

There was her mother as a young woman.

Her grandparents are on their wedding day.

And Zain.

Her older brother stood in the last photograph, holding a cricket bat and grinning at the camera as if the entire world had just told him a private joke.

Ayla remembered taking that picture.

She remembered telling him to stand properly.

She remembered him laughing and pulling an even more ridiculous face.

She remembered everything except how to remember him without being hurt.

She turned away.

“Should we open the windows?” Her mother asked.

“Not yet.”

“All right, beta.”

Her mother walked toward the kitchen to make tea.

Ayla listened to her footsteps and faded down the hallway. The familiar sound made her chest tighten.

There had been a time when she believed the people she loved would always be somewhere nearby. In the next room. On the other end of a phone call. Waiting for her to finish whatever she was doing.

She had mistaken familiarity with permanence.

Now she knows better.

Love could fill a house.

And still, a house could become unbearably empty.

The living room looked almost exactly as Zehra Begum had left it.

The cream-colored sofa stood beneath the window. A crocheted blanket lay folded over its arm. On the side table, a ceramic bowl held buttons, safety pins, and small objects her grandmother had saved because she believed everything deserved another chance to be useful.

Ayla once laughed at that habit.

“Why do you keep all this old stuff, Nani?”

“Because you never know when you'll need it,” her grandmother replied.

“And what if you never need it?”

Zehra Begum smiled.

“Then perhaps someone else will.”

Ayla had not understood the answer.

Now, she looked at the bowl and wondered who would ever need those buttons.

She moved toward the window.

The garden had grown wild. Clay pots lay cracked beside the wall, and the jasmine plant had spread across

the railing. Near the far corner, a patch of soil remained bare.

She remembered planting marigolds there with Zain when they were children.

He dug the holes too deep. She had complained that he was ruining the flowers.

He had held up a tiny seed between his fingers.

“Look at this, Ayla. Itna sa hota hai, aur phir bhi poora phool ban jata hai.”

It is so small, and yet it has become an entire flower.

She had rolled her eyes.

“You talk too much.”

“And you complain too much.”

He had laughed, and she had thrown soil at him.

It was an ordinary afternoon. Nothing about it had suggested that one day she would give almost anything to return to it.

That was the cruelty of memory.

It preserved the smallest moments with perfect tenderness, then placed them just beyond our reach.

Ayla rested her forehead against the cool glass.

She missed him.

Not only during the difficult moments, when the world felt too heavy to carry. She missed him when something funny happened and she instinctively reached for her phone. She missed him when she heard a song he would have mocked. She missed him when she wanted someone to tell her that she was making a terrible decision, then laughed when she did it anyway.

She missed the ordinary future they had never thought to be grateful for.

The arguments they would never finish.

Birthdays that would never come.

The conversations that would remain forever interrupted.

Sometimes, she wondered whether grief was simply love with nowhere left to go.

And sometimes, she was afraid that if she stopped hurting, she would leave him behind.

“Ayla? The tea is ready!”

Her mother's voice came from the kitchen.

“Coming, Ammi.”

But Ayla did not move.

A small wooden door near the staircase caught her attention. It was half-hidden behind a faded curtain, just as she remembered it.

Her grandmother's studies.

As a child, Ayla had considered it the most mysterious room in the house. It smelled of old books and ink, and it was filled with notebooks whose contents her grandmother never explained.

Ayla had been allowed inside on one condition: she must not rearrange anything.

Naturally, she had rearranged everything.

Zehra Begum pretended to be furious.

“Tumhare haath lagte hi har cheez apni jagah bhool jati hai.”

The moment something comes into your hands, everything forgets where it belongs.

Ayla smiled at the memory.

The smile disappeared almost immediately.

She stood before the door and turned the handle.

Locked.

She tried again, pressing her shoulder against the wood.

Nothing.

A small brass keyhole glinted beneath the handle.

“Of course,” she whispered.

Even now, her grandmother has managed to keep something from her.

The thought was almost funny.

Almost.

Ayla searched the console table, the little drawers beneath it, and the ceramic bowl filled with buttons. She found old receipts, a broken hair clip, and a photograph of her grandfather wearing a ridiculous hat.

But no key.

Then she remembered the bookshelf.

Behind a row of novels, she found a small brass key tied to a faded blue thread.

She held it in her palm.

She could not remember seeing it before.

For a moment, she considered calling her mother.

Instead, she slipped the key into her pocket.

She did not know why she had decided to keep the discovery to herself. Perhaps some part of her understood that opening the door would mean more than entering an old room.

It would mean allowing the past to speak.

And Ayla had spent months trying not to hear it.

The key turned with a soft click.

The study door opened.

Dust drifted through a thin beam of afternoon light. Shelves lined up the walls, crowded with books, notebooks, and diaries. A green-shaded lamp stood on the writing desk, beside a framed photograph of her grandfather.

Ayla stepped inside.

For several seconds, she simply looked around.

This was where Zehra Begum had spent her mornings reading and her evenings writing letters. This was where she had sat on the floor as a child, listening to stories about people whose lives were nothing like her own.

This was where Zain used to borrow books and return them with folded corners.

Her grandmother always noticed.

“You've ruined the page,” she would tell him.

“It's only a page, Nani.”

“And this is only a book. Shall we burn the whole library while we're at it?”

He would laugh.

She would pretend to be angry.

Ayla could almost hear them.

The room seemed to hold their voices on its walls, waiting for someone to remember them.

She sat at the desk.

There was a shallow drawer on the right-hand side. Inside lay a pair of reading glasses, a dried rose, a fountain pen, and a bundle of envelopes tied with a faded red ribbon.

Ayla lifted them carefully.

The paper had yellowed with age. Some envelopes carried dates. Others bore names written in their grandmother's familiar handwriting.

A few were addressed simply to *My dear friend.*

She untied the ribbon.

The first letter began:

My dear friend,

There are things we carry for so long that we begin to believe they are part of our bodies.

Regret settles in our chests. Fear catches in our throats. Words we never spoke remain somewhere between our hearts and our mouths.

And sometimes, we forget that we are allowed to put something down.

Ayla read the words twice.

Then she continued.

I once believed that being strong meant never allowing anyone to see me fall apart. I thought that if I kept my sadness quiet enough, it would eventually become small enough to disappear.

I was wrong.

Sadness does not always disappear when we refuse to speak of it. Sometimes, it simply learns to live in silence.

Ayla's fingers tightened around the paper.

She thought of the conversations she had avoided. The questions she had refused to answer. The way she told everyone she was fine because explaining the truth felt more exhausting than hiding it.

She thought of her mother standing outside her bedroom door.

And then, as it always did, her mind returned that evening.

The evening of the unanswered call.

It was an ordinary day.

That was what made it so difficult to forgive.

There had been no warning that the world was about to divide itself before and after. No final conversation in which either of them understood that time was running out.

Only disagreement.

Ayla had been working on a story when Zain called. She was tired and frustrated. They had argued earlier, and she had decided that she needed a little time before speaking to him again.

His name appeared on her screen.

She watched it ring.

She did not answer.

When he called again, she turned the phone facedown.

I'll call him later," she thought.

Later she arrived in the form of her mother's trembling voice.

Later, he arrived in a hospital corridor beneath lights that were far too bright.

Later arrived in words Ayla could not understand, although she heard every one of them.

Zain was gone.

And the world, impossibly, continued.

For eighteen months, Ayla had returned to that evening as if it were a door she might unlock by thinking about it long enough.

She knew that answering the phone would not necessarily have changed anything. She knew she had not caused the accident.

But grief was not a courtroom, and her heart had never been a fair judge.

It kept asking the same questions.

What if I had answered?

What if I had said something kinder?

What if he needed to hear my voice one last time?

She lowered the letter into her lap.

“Main ne uski aakhri call Nahi uthai thi,” she whispered.

I didn't answer his last call.

The confession sounded small in the quiet room.

Almost ordinary.

How could something so small become so enormous inside a person?

Ayla pressed her hands against her eyes.

For months, she had tried to stop herself from crying whenever Zain's name appeared in a conversation. She had swallowed her tears at family gatherings, smiled when people told her to be strong, and avoided mentioning him because she could not bear the careful silence that followed.

Now, alone in her grandmother's studies, she stopped trying to hold everything together.

She cried.

Not loud. Not dramatic.

She cried the way rain fell after a long, heavy cloud had finally found somewhere to empty itself.

When the tears slowed, she looked down at the letter.

At the bottom of the page was a date.

And beneath it, one word.

Zehra.

She turned the page over.

A sentence had been written on the back.

For the day you finally understand that love and guilt are not the same thing.

Ayla stared at it.

She did not know whom her grandmother had written to. She did not know what grief Zehra had carried, or why she had hidden these letters.

But for the first time, Ayla wondered whether her grandmother had understood more about sorrow than she had ever admitted.

There were seventeen envelopes in the drawer.

Some were addressed to strangers. One bore the name Sana. Another was addressed to Hamza.

Ayla laid them across the desk.

The dates stretched across several years. Some letters were written in blue ink, others in black. One had a corner torn away. Another had been folded so many times that its creases were nearly white.

These were not letters written on a single afternoon.

They belonged to life.

A collection of moments that someone had considered important enough to preserve.

At the bottom of the drawer lay a cream-colored envelope.

There was no stamp or address.

Only one sentence on the front:

For the person who believes it is too late to begin again.

Ayla held it beneath the green-shaded lamp.

Her grandmother's handwriting curved across the paper with familiar patience.

She opened the envelope.

Inside was a single folded page.

My dear child,

If you are reading this, perhaps you have reached a place in your life where you can no longer recognize the person you used to be.

Perhaps you have lost someone.

Perhaps you have lost yourself.

Or perhaps you have simply grown tired of pretending that you are not hurting.

Ayla stopped reading.

Her throat tightened.

She looked toward the window, where the afternoon light had begun to gather in a pale strip across the floor.

Then she continued.

Whatever brought you here, I want you to know something I learned much later than I should have.

You do not have to finish grieving before you begin living again.

You do not have to forget someone to allow yourself happiness.

And you do not have to understand the whole road before taking the next step.

Sometimes, my child, all we can do is take the next step.

Then another.

And another.

Until one day, without realizing when it happened, we find ourselves standing somewhere the darkness cannot reach us in quite the same way.

Ayla's eyes filled with tears again.

At the bottom of the page, her grandmother had written:

There is a light, Ayla. Even when you cannot see it.

Her name.

The letter was meant to her.

Ayla turned the page over, searching for a date, a clue, something that might explain how her grandmother had known she would one day need these words.

There was nothing.

Only one final line.

When you are ready, begin with the first letter.

Ayla looked at the seventeen envelopes scattered across the desk.

Who were these people?

Why did Zehra help them?

And what had happened in her grandmother's life that had taught her to write such words?

She had spent months believing there was nothing left to discover in the life she had known.

Now, the door has opened.

Not the locked wooden door behind her, but something inside her that she had kept shut for far too long.

The rain had stopped by the time Ayla rose from the desk.

She walked through the window.

The garden was wet and disordered. Fallen leaves cling to the path. Water was collected in the cracked clay pots.

Near the wall, a tiny green shoot emerged from the soil.

She could not remember planting anything there.

Perhaps it had been there for weeks, growing so slowly that no one had noticed.

Ayla watched it for a long time.

It was only a small green thing in a neglected garden. It could not bring Zain back. It could not explain the letters or undo the past.

It could not promise her that tomorrow would be easier.

But it was alive.

And somehow, that mattered.

“Nani,” she whispered, “main koshish karungi.”

Grandmother, I'll try.

She did not know whether she was promising to read the letters, to begin writing again, or simply to stop running from the life she still had.

Perhaps she promised all three.

From the kitchen, her mother called her name.

“Ayla? Beta, chai thandi ho rahi hai!”

The tea is getting cold, dear.

Ayla wiped her cheeks.

“Bas, Ammi. Aa rahi hoon.”

Just a moment, Mother. I'm coming.

She returned the letters to the drawer, keeping the first one beside her notebook.

Before leaving the study, she looked once more at the desk where her grandmother had spent so many quiet hours.

For months, Ayla had thought that grief was the only thing left to her.

Now there was a question she wanted to answer.

A letter she wanted to understand.

A story she had not finished.

The darkness had not disappeared. Zain was still gone. Her guilt had not suddenly loosened its grip.

But for the first time in a long while, Ayla had found a reason to return tomorrow.

And sometimes, that is where a story truly begins.

Not when the pain ends.

Not when every question finds an answer.

But when, despite everything that has been lost, a person discovers one small reason to keep looking.

Chapter Three

Letters That Were Never Sent

The first letter remained beneath Ayla's pillow that night.

She had placed it there without knowing why. Perhaps she wanted to keep it close, as though the words written in her grandmother's familiar handwriting could protect her from the memories waiting in the dark. Or perhaps she was afraid that if she put it away, the fragile courage it had awakened in her would disappear by morning.

Sleep came into fragments.

She dreamed of Zain standing at the end of a long road; his hands tucked into the pockets of his old grey hoodie. He was smiling, the way he used to when he knew she was upset but was waiting for her to admit it herself.

"Ayla," he called.

She tried to reach him, but the road stretched farther with every step.

Then she heard a telephone ringing.

She woke up before she could answer it.

For several seconds, she lay perfectly still, staring at the ceiling. The familiar weight settled over her chest, heavy and unquestioning.

Eighteen months.

And still, some mornings, her heart behaved as though the world had ended only yesterday.

Ayla reached beneath her pillow and unfolded the letter.

You do not have to finish grieving before you begin living again.

She read the sentence once.

Then again.

Outside her window, dawn was slowly gathering over the rooftops. Somewhere in the neighborhood, a woman called her child inside. A motorbike passed. A bird landed on the windowsill and flew away.

The world continued its ordinary business.

Ayla wondered how it could be.

She folded the letter carefully and sat up.

Today, she will open another one.

Not because she was ready.

Because, for the first time in a long while, she wanted to know what happened next.

The seventeen letters lay across Nani's study table, still tied together with their faded red ribbon.

In the morning light, the room seemed less frightening than it had the previous day. Dust floated in narrow beams of sunlight, and the old wooden shelves smelled faintly of paper, cedar, and time.

Ayla sat in her grandmother's chair.

It creaked beneath her weight.

She almost smiled.

"Nani," she murmured, "you could have left me something easier. Jeweler, perhaps. A bank account. A recipe for that awful bitter tea you insisted cured everything."

Her voice faltered at the last words.

For one brief moment, she could almost hear her grandmother laughing.

The silence that followed was not kind, exactly. But it was no longer entirely empty.

Ayla untied the ribbon.

She selected the first letter addressed to someone else.

The envelope was yellowed at the edges. On its front, in her grandmother's elegant handwriting, were four words:

For the one who stayed.

There was no name.

Only an address written on the back.

House No. 12, Lane Four, Gulmohar Colony.

Below it, in smaller letters, her grandmother had added:

If she is still there, please tell her what I remembered.

Ayla stared at the sentence.

Who was *she*?

And what did Nani remember?

She turned the envelope over, searching for another clue. There was none.

The letter inside began without a greeting.

Some people leave our lives without ever leaving our hearts. Others remain beside us for years, and we fail to notice the quiet ways in which they are disappearing.

Ayla read on.

I once knew a woman who believed that being strong meant never asking anyone to stay. She smiled when she was breaking, served tea when she was exhausted, and said she was fine so often that people eventually stopped asking.

I was one of those people.

I thought she needed space. In truth, she needed someone who would sit beside her without demanding an explanation.

By the time I understood the difference, too many words had already gone unsaid.

Ayla paused.

The handwriting remained steady, but a faint ink stain blurred the last line.

She pictured her grandmother at this very table, writing these words while the rest of the house was asleep.

Did Nani cry?

Had she ever sat in this room feeling as helpless as Ayla did?

The thought seemed almost impossible.

Grandmothers belonged to a different category of human beings in a child's imagination. They knew how to mend torn clothes, soothe fevers, prepare food for unexpected guests, and find missing objects that everyone else had given up searching for.

They were not supposed to have unfinished grief.

They were not supposed to have people they could not save.

Yet here was the evidence folded into an envelope.

Ayla reached the end of the page.

If you are reading this, perhaps you have begun to believe that your presence would make no difference to anyone.

Please do not mistake someone's silence for proof that they no longer need you.

And if you are the one who has been silent, remember that an apology does not have to be perfect to be offered. Sometimes, the smallest, honest sentence is the beginning of a bridge.

I am sorry I did not ask you to stay.

I am sorry I thought time would give us another chance.

— Zehra

Ayla lowered the page.

For a long time, she heard nothing but the ticking clock on the wall.

Another chance.

The words entered her slowly, finding the place she had spent eighteen months trying to keep closed.

Zain’s final phone call.

His name is glowing on her screen.

Her irritation. Her stubbornness. The unfinished argument.

The call she had watched ring because she had decided that he could wait until she was ready to speak to him.

She had imagined the conversation afterward a thousand times.

In some versions, she answered. In others, she called him back five minutes later. Sometimes she apologized. Sometimes he teased her for being dramatic, and they both laughed.

But in every version, there was another chance.

Ayla pressed the heel of her hand against her mouth.

“I thought there would be time,” she whispered.

The words sounded small in the study.

They had always sounded small.

She folded the letter along its original creases and placed it back inside the envelope.

Then she picked up her notebook.

For months, it had remained closed, its pages empty except for a few unfinished lines written in the weeks after Zain’s death. She had abandoned it because every sentence seemed betrayal. If she wrote about the sky, she felt guilty for noticing its beauty. If she wrote about sadness, she felt trapped inside it. If she wrote about

Zain, she feared that words would make his absence too real.

Today, she opened a blank page.

Her pen hovered above it.

Then she wrote:

There are things we cannot change, and things we cannot forgive ourselves for changing.

She stopped.

Crossed out, *changing*.

Wrote *is not changing*.

Then she crossed the entire sentence.

"No," she muttered. "That sounds like something Nani would say."

For the first time in months, a faint, almost unwilling smile touched her face.

She tried again.

I keep thinking that if I hurt enough, I can somehow pay for the last conversation I never had.

Her hand trembled.

She wanted to tear the page out.

Instead, she closed the notebook gently.

It was not a beautiful sentence.

It was not a finished thought.

But it was honest.

And perhaps honesty was where writing had to begin.

By noon, Ayla had made up her mind.

She would visit the Gulmohar Colony.

Her mother was in the kitchen when Ayla came downstairs, struggling with the stubborn clasp of an old handbag.

“Ammi?”

Her mother looked up. “Yes?”

“Do you know anyone who lives in Gulmohar Colony? House Number Twelve, Lane Four?”

Her mother’s hands stopped moving.

It was a small thing, barely a pause, but Ayla noticed.

“Why are you asking?”

“I found a letter in Nani’s study. It was addressed to someone who might still live there.”

Her mother turned off the stove.

“Who was the letter for?”

“I don’t know. Nani didn’t write a name.”

A long silence settled between them.

Then her mother said, “Gulmohar Colony is an old neighborhood. Your grandmother knew many people there.”

“Did she ever mention a woman who lived at Number Twelve?”

“I don't remember.”

It was an answer that sounded rehearsed, although Ayla could not explain why.

She looked at her mother more carefully.

“Ammi, is there something you know?”

Her mother turned back toward the stove, though the flame had already been extinguished.

“Not everything from the past needs to be opened again, Ayla.”

The sentence was spoken softly.

That made it worse.

Ayla felt something inside her stiffness. She knew that tone. It was the same tone of adults used when they believed silence was a form of protection.

But she had spent too long living inside silence.

“I’m not trying to hurt anyone,” she said. “I just want to understand.”

Her mother’s shoulders dropped.

For a moment, she looked older than Ayla remembered. There were silver strands at her temples now, and faint lines around her eyes that had not been there before Zain died.

Perhaps grief had been changing them both in ways neither knew how to discuss.

“Take a rickshaw,” her mother finally said. “And call me when you get there.”

“Do you know the address?”

“Yes.”

Ayla waited.

Her mother did not explain.

She only reached for a clean plate and began arranging the food.

Ayla stood there for another moment, hoping for something more. A warning. My name. A reason to turn back.

When no one came, she slipped the letter into her bag and left.

Gulmohar Colony looked as though it had been built for another version of the city.

The streets were narrow, shaded by old trees whose branches leaned toward one another like tired friends. The houses stood close together, their balconies crowded with flowerpots and drying clothes. Children played

cricket in a small clearing, arguing passionately over whether a ball had touched the wall.

Ayla gave the driver the address and stepped out beside a faded green gate.

House Number Twelve.

The paint had peeled around the edges. A bougainvillea climbed one side of the wall, its pink flowers bright against the weathered bricks.

She stood outside for nearly five minutes.

What was she supposed to say?

Hello. You don't know me, but my dead grandmother wrote you a letter.

It sounded absurd.

She could leave. No one would know she had come.

The thought was comforting until she remembered how many things in her life; she had left unfinished simply because returning felt harder than staying away.

Ayla took a breath and pressed the bell.

Footsteps sounded inside.

The door opened a few inches.

An elderly woman stood behind it, dressed in a pale cotton shawl. Her silver hair was pinned loosely at the back of her head, and she held a pair of reading glasses in one hand.

“Yes?”

Ayla forgot every word she had rehearsed.

The woman studied her face.

“Can I help you, child?”

“My name is Ayla,” she managed. “I’m Zehra Begum’s granddaughter.”

The woman went completely still.

The reading glasses slipped from her fingers and struck the floor.

For a moment, neither of them moved.

Then the woman reached for the doorframe.

“Zehra’s granddaughter?”

“Yes.”

The woman looked at her as though a face from a dream had appeared in the daylight.

“Oh,” she whispered.

It was not a greeting.

It was a sound full of years.

“Please,” the woman said, stepping aside. “Come in.”

The sitting room smelled of cardamom tea and old books.

Ayla sat on the edge of a sofa while the woman disappeared into the kitchen. She returned with two cups and placed one before her guest, though her own hands trembled so much that tea spilled onto the saucer.

“I’m sorry,” she said.

“You don’t have to apologize.”

The woman gave a small, sad smile.

“That is something Zehra used to say.”

Ayla’s fingers tightened around the envelope in her bag.

“You knew my grandmother well?”

The woman looked toward the window.

“Once, I thought I knew her better than anyone.”

“What happened?”

“Life happened.” She paused. “And pride. Sometimes pride disguises itself as dignity so convincingly that you don't realize it is ruining everything until it is too late.”

Ayla thought of her last argument with Zain.

She looked down at her tea.

“What’s your name?” She asked.

“Farah.”

The name meant joy.

Ayla wondered whether names sometimes became cruel jokes when life took a different direction.

She drew the envelope from her bag and placed it on the table.

“I found this in Nani’s study. It was addressed to ‘the one who stayed.’ There was no name, only this address.”

Farah stared at the handwriting.

Her hand rose to her mouth.

“Oh, Zehra.”

She touched the envelope with the tips of her fingers, almost reverently.

“She kept it.”

“You know what it means?”

Farah did not answer immediately.

Instead, she rose, walked to a cabinet, and returned with a small wooden box. Its surface was scratched, and one corner had been repaired with a strip of dark tape.

She set it between them.

“I have something I never knew what to do with,” she said.

Inside the box lay a photograph.

Two young women stood beneath a Gul mohar tree, their heads tilted together, laughing at something beyond the frame. One was unmistakably Zehra Begum, though her face was softer, and her hair fell in a dark braid over one shoulder.

The other woman was Farah.

Ayla stared.

She had never seen her grandmother look so young. Not merely younger, but unguarded. The woman in the photograph seemed to belong to a world before responsibilities had settled over her shoulders.

Behind the photograph, in blue ink, were the words:

For Farah, who taught me that a home can be built wherever someone chooses to stay.

Ayla read the sentence twice.

“What happened between you?”

Farah sat down slowly.

“We were best friends,” she said. “The kind of friends who believe their lives will always run beside each other. We shared books, secrets, and dreams. Your grandmother wanted to become a teacher. I wanted to leave this city and see the sea in every place where it met the land.”

“Did you?”

Farah laughed softly, but there was no joy in it.

“I saw the sea once. At seventeen. Your grandmother came with me, and we promised each other we would return every year.”

“What happened?”

“Your grandmother’s father arranged a marriage for her. She was frightened, and I was angry. I told her she was abandoning everything we had planned. She told me I had no idea what it meant to disappoint a family that had sacrificed everything for you.”

Farah rubbed her thumb over the photograph’s edge.

“We said terrible things. I told her that if she chose her family’s wishes over her own life, she should never come looking for me.”

Ayla’s throat tightened.

“And she didn’t?”

“Not for a long time.”

Farah looked at the envelope again.

“Years passed. I got married, moved away for a while, and came back. My life did not turn out the way I had imagined, but whose does it? I heard about Zehra now and then. I told myself I no longer cared.”

“Did you?”

“No.”

The answer came without hesitation.

“I was angry with her for years. And then I was angry with myself for wasting those years being angry.”

Ayla looked at the photograph.

“Why didn’t you find each other?”

“We did. Eventually.”

Farah’s eyes grew distant.

“Your grandmother came here one rainy evening, perhaps fifteen years ago. She stood at that gate with a box of sweets and an apology she had rehearsed so many times that she could barely speak it.”

“What did you say?”

“I let her in.”

Farah’s mouth trembled into a smile.

“We talked until dawn. We cried. We laughed at how foolish we were. I thought that would be the end of our regrets.”

She glanced toward the photograph.

“But reconciliation does not give you back the years you lost. It only gives you the chance to stop losing more.”

Ayla felt those words settle somewhere deep within her.

“Then why did Nani write this letter?”

Farah looked down at the envelope.

“Because I think she was afraid of something.”

“What?”

“That we would become strangers again. That one day, one of us would be gone, and the other would be left with words that had nowhere to go.”

Farah lifted her eyes.

“Your grandmother was very good at helping other people say what they were afraid to say. She was not always so good at saying those things herself.”

Ayla thought of the seventeen letters.

“Why did she keep letters for so many people?”

Farah looked surprised.

“How many did you find?”

“Seventeen.”

For the first time since Ayla had arrived, Farah seemed genuinely unsettled.

“Seventeen?”

She rose and went to a writing desk beside the window. From its lowest drawer, she removed a small, cream-colored envelope.

“I have kept this for years,” she said. “Zehra gave it to me when we made peace. She told me not to open it unless I needed to remember something important.”

She placed it in Ayla’s hands.

The front was blank.

Inside was a single sheet of paper.

Dear Farah,

I used to believe that the worst thing in life was losing someone.

I was wrong.

Sometimes, the worst thing is allowing fear, pride, or shame to make a stranger to someone who is still standing in front of you.

Death does not ask permission before it takes a person away. But while someone is still here, there may be a hundred small opportunities to reach them.

We do not always recognize those opportunities. We grow tired. We become angry. We imagine tomorrow will be generous enough to return what we neglect today.

Please remember this: an unfinished conversation is not proof that love was unfinished.

And if there comes a day when you cannot say the words to the person who needs them, say them to someone who can still hear you.

Perhaps that is how we keep love moving through the world.

— Zehra

Ayla stopped reading.

The room seemed to be tilted.

An unfinished conversation is not proof that love was unfinished.

She pressed the paper against her knees.

Farah watched her quietly.

“Are you all, right?”

Ayla wanted to say yes.

She wanted to be the sort of person who could hear a painful truth and remain composed, who could fold grief neatly into a handbag and carry it without spilling.

Instead, her eyes filled.

“I had a brother,” she said.

Farah’s expression softened.

“Had?”

“He died in a road accident. Eighteen months ago.”

“I’m so sorry.”

Ayla swallowed me.

“We argued. It was something stupid. I don't even remember all the words now; only how angry I was. He called me that evening, and I didn’t answer.”

The confession came out quickly, as though the words had been waiting behind a locked door.

“I thought I could call him later. I thought there would be time. And now I keep thinking that if I had answered, if I had been kinder, if I had just—”

Her voice broke.

Farah moved closer, but she did not reach for her. She waited until Ayla looked up.

“Did you cause the accident?”

“No.”

“Could you have known what would happen?”

Ayla shook her head.

“Then why are you asking yourself to carry the responsibility for something you could not have known?”

“Because I was his sister.”

The words came out almost angrily.

“Because he loved me. Because I should have answered.”

Farah nodded slowly.

“Yes,” she said. “You wish you had answered. You wish you had one more chance to hear his voice. Those wishes are real, and they will hurt for a long time.”

Ayla looked at her, tears slipping down her cheeks.

“But wishing you had done something differently is not the same as being responsible for what happened.”

Farah paused.

“And you do not have to punish yourself for the rest of your life to prove that you loved him.”

Ayla covered her face.

She cried then, not quietly, not elegantly, but with the helplessness of someone who had spent too long trying to make sorrow behave.

Farah stayed beside her.

She did not tell her that everything happened for a reason. She did not say that time healed all wounds or that Zain would want her to be happy.

She simply remained.

And for that afternoon, remaining was enough.

When Ayla finally stood to leave, the light outside had begun to soften.

Farah walked her to the gate.

“Will you come again?” She asked.

Ayla looked back at the house, at the old photograph visible through the sitting-room window, at the Gul mohar branches moving gently above the wall.

“Yes,” she said.

This time, the promise did not feel like something she had to force herself to believe.

Farah took her hand.

“Your grandmother used to say that people sometimes arrive in our lives carrying questions we have spent years trying to answer.”

Ayla smiled faintly.

“She sounds like she had an answer for everything.”

“No,” Farah said. “She simply understood that most people don't need answers as much as they need someone who will sit with them while they search.”

Ayla held the envelope close to her chest.

“Thank you.”

Farah squeezed her hand.

“Tell your mother I still have her recipe for almond biscuits. Zehra gave it to me years ago, and I have never managed to make them taste the way hers did.”

“I will.”

“And Ayla?”

She turned.

“Do not wait until you have found all the answers to begin living.”

The sentence followed Ayla down the street.

She walked past the children playing cricket, past the flowerpots and the open windows, past strangers who had no idea that a small part of her world had shifted.

For the first time, she wondered whether grief had made her mistake suffering from loyalty.

Perhaps she had been trying to keep Zain alive by refusing to let herself move forward.

Perhaps she had believed that happiness would erase the pain, and that the pain was the last place she could still find him.

But Farah had loved her grandmother through years of anger and silence. Their reconciliation had not restored the lost years. It had not made them young again.

It had simply allowed them to love each other with the time that remained.

Ayla stopped beneath a tree.

She took out her notebook.

On the blank page beneath her unfinished sentence, she wrote:

I cannot answer the call that has already ended.

Her pen paused.

Then she added:

But perhaps I can learn how to answer the people who are still here.

She read the words.

They did not absolve her.

They did not bring Zain back.

They did not make the ache disappear.

But they gave the ache somewhere to go.

Ayla closed the notebook and continued walking.

That evening, she returned to her grandmother's house carrying two envelopes: the letter she had taken to Farah and the one Farah had entrusted to her.

Her mother was waiting in the sitting room.

"You went to Gulmohar Colony," she said.

It was not a question.

Ayla placed her bag on the sofa.

"Yes."

"Did you meet Farah?"

Ayla stared at her.

"You know her?"

Her mother looked away.

“I knew of her.”

“Ammi, why didn’t you tell me?”

“Because some stories belong to the people who lived them.”

“And now?”

Her mother was silent for a moment.

“Now I think your grandmother wanted you to find them.”

Ayla sat next to her.

“Did Nani ever tell you why she kept those letters?”

“No. But before she died, she asked me to promise something.”

“What?”

Her mother’s eyes filled, though she seemed determined not to let the tears fall.

“She told me that one day you might begin believing that your life ended when Zain’s did. She asked me not to

force you to move on. She asked me not to let you disappear inside your grief, either."

Ayla looked down at her hands.

"I don't know how to do that."

"Neither do I," her mother admitted.

Honesty surprised her more than any explanation could have.

Her mother reached for her hand.

"We are both learning how to live in a world without him."

Ayla leaned against her shoulder.

For a while, neither spoke.

Then her mother whispered, "I miss him every day."

"So do I."

"I know."

The words were simple.

They were also the first time in months that Ayla felt she and her mother were standing on the same side of their sorrow, rather than hiding from each other behind it.

Later, Ayla returned to studying.

She placed Farah's letter beside the others and untied the faded red ribbon once more.

Seventeen names. Seventeen stories. Seventeen doors her grandmother had left unopened—or perhaps had opened only a little, waiting for someone else to decide whether to step through.

Ayla selected another envelope.

This one bore a name in blue ink.

Hamza.

Beneath it, her grandmother had written a single line:

For the man who learned to survive by forgetting what he once wanted.

Ayla sat very still.

She turned the envelope over.

There was an address.

And, beside it, a small handwritten note:

He will tell you that he is doing well. Do not believe him too quickly.

Ayla almost smiled.

“Nani,” she whispered, “you really did leave me a mess.”

She opened her notebook and wrote Hamza’s name on the next page.

Underneath it, she wrote:

Tomorrow.

The word frightened her.

It also felt, in a small and unfamiliar way, like a beginning.

Outside, the evening sky darkened over the garden. Near the old stone path, the tiny green shoot she had noticed the day before stood almost hidden among the weeds.

It was still fragile.

Still small.

But it had not stopped growing simply because the world around it was broken.

Ayla watched it for a long time.

Then she switched off the study lamp and left the door open behind her.

For once, the darkness did not feel like a room she had been locked inside.

It felt like a night she might be able to walk through.

Chapter Four

The Stranger in the First Letter

The next morning, Ayla woke up before her alarm.

For a few seconds, she did not remember why.

The room was pale with early sunlight. A bird was making an unreasonable amount of noise outside her window. Somewhere downstairs, a cupboard door closed, followed by the familiar clatter of a spoon against a teacup.

Ordinary sounds.

The world had resumed its ordinary business without asking whether she was ready.

Then she remembered the letter.

Farah's trembling hands. The photograph is beneath the Gul Mohar tree. Her grandmother's handwriting, steady even when the words were not.

An unfinished conversation is not proof that love was unfinished.

Ayla repeated the sentence silently.

It did not make the guilt disappear. Nothing so small could undo eighteen months of carrying it. But the words had found a place inside her where the guilt had grown comfortable, and for the first time, something else was sitting beside it.

She reached for her notebook.

Beneath yesterday's sentence, she wrote:

Maybe I have been trying to punish myself for something I can never change.

She stared at the words.

Then, almost reluctantly, she added:

I don't know how to stop.

That was the truth. Not a beautiful truth. Not the kind people wrote on inspirational posters or tucked inside greeting cards.

Just the truth.

And for now, it would have to be enough.

At breakfast, her mother was standing beside the stove, stirring tea that had already boiled twice.

“You’re awake early,” she said.

“So are you.”

“I have things to do.”

Ayla glanced at the untouched plate beside the sink. “You always have things to do.”

Her mother stopped stirring.

It was a small sentence. Ordinarily, almost careless. Yet something about it seemed to settle between them with the weight of all the things they had spent months avoiding.

Her mother turned off the stove.

“Your grandmother used to say the same thing.”

Ayla looked up.

“She said I could find work even in an empty room,” her mother continued, pouring tea into two cups. “If I was upset, I cleaned. If I were frightened, I would cook. If I missed someone, I found something to organize.”

A faint smile appeared on her face and disappeared just as quickly.

“Your Nani thought I was impossible.”

“No,” Ayla said softly. “She thought you were her daughter.”

Her mother looked at her.

For one fragile moment, there were not two people living under the same roof while grieving in separate rooms. They were simply a daughter and her mother, remembering the same woman.

Then her mother placed a cup in front of her.

“Did you sleep?”

“A little.”

“Any dreams?”

Ayla wrapped both hands around the warm cup.

“Zain.”

Her mother’s fingers tightened around the handle of her own cup.

“What happened?”

“Nothing. I just saw him.”

“In the dream?”

Ayla nodded.

She wanted to tell her mother about the ringing phone, about how she had awakened with her heart racing and her hands searching the bedsheets as if she might find the past hidden among them.

Instead, she asked, “Do you dream about him?”

Her mother did not answer immediately.

“Sometimes,” she said. “Sometimes I hear him laughing from the other room, and for a second, I forget.”

Ayla swallowed me.

“What happens after that?”

“I remember.”

Her mother looked down at her tea.

“And then I make breakfast.”

The simplicity of it hurt more than any dramatic confession could have.

Ayla reached across the table and touched her mother’s hand.

Neither of them said anything.

For once, the silence did not feel like a wall.

It felt like somewhere they could sit together.

Later that morning, Ayla returned to Zehra Begum's house.

She had told her mother she wanted to look through the remaining letters. This was true, although not the whole truth.

She also wanted to understand the woman who had somehow managed to leave pieces of herself scattered across other people's lives.

How had Nani carried so many stories?

How had she known which words someone needed to hear?

And why had Ayla, who had lived under the same roof for so many years, never thought of asking?

The old house greeted her with its familiar smell of dust, rosewater, and books that had been closed for too long.

In the garden, the little green shoot stood a fraction taller than it had yesterday.

Ayla crouched beside it.

“Acha,” she murmured. “You’re still here.”

The words made her smile.

It was not much of a smile, but it belonged to her.

Inside the study, sunlight lay across the writing desk. The letters remained where she had left them, tied in their faded ribbons. She had counted them twice before, but now she noticed something she had missed.

The letter addressed to Hamza was not the only one with a note attached.

Beneath the red ribbon lay a narrow envelope marked with a name she did not recognize.

For the stranger who never knew he was loved.

Ayla frowned.

There was no address. No date. Only a small line in her grandmother’s handwriting at the bottom.

Some people become strangers because life keeps them apart. Others become strangers because neither knows how to ask the other to stay.

Ayla sat down.

She turned the envelope over.

It had been opened and carefully resealed. The paper was yellowed at the edges, but the handwriting looked no older than the other letters.

For a moment, she considered putting it back.

Perhaps some stories were not hers to uncover.

Then she remembered Farah's photograph, and the years that had passed because two young women had believed that pride was stronger than friendship.

Not everything from the past needs to be opened again.

Her mother had said those words.

But perhaps the past did not always return to hurting you. Perhaps sometimes it returned because something had been left unfinished.

Ayla slid her finger beneath the flap.

Inside was a single sheet of paper.

And a photograph.

The photograph showed a young man standing beside a railway platform, one hand gripping the handle of a battered suitcase. He wore a white shirt with its sleeves

rolled up and looked somewhere to the left of the camera.

He was smiling.

Not broad. Not confident.

It was the hesitant smile of someone who had been told to stand still for a photograph and was trying to decide whether he belonged to it.

On the back, Nani had written:

He was nineteen when he left. I wonder how old he was when he stopped waiting.

Ayla turned the photograph over again.

The young man had kind eyes.

There was something familiar with them, although she could not say why.

She unfolded the letter.

My dear stranger,

I have forgotten the exact sound of your voice.

I remember that you spoke quickly when you were excited and slowly when you were trying to hide something. I remember the way you laughed at your own jokes before anyone else understood them. I remember how you would stand at the gate every evening, pretending you had come outside for fresh air when, in truth, you were waiting for someone.

I remember many things.

And yet, if I passed you on the street today, I am not certain I would recognize the man you have become.

Perhaps that is the cruelest thing about time. It does not simply take people away from us. Sometimes it leaves them alive somewhere beyond our reach, changing quietly, growing older in rooms we have never entered.

You were young when I first met you. You believed the world was a place that could be persuaded. If you worked hard enough, loved honestly enough, and waited patiently enough, surely life would eventually give you what you deserved.

I wish I had not laughed when you told me that.

You were not foolish for believing in goodness.

You were only young.

I wonder whether you still write.

You once told me that words were the only place where you could be completely honest. You said that people frightened you because they expected you to be someone, while a blank page asked you for nothing.

I wonder whether you still keep a notebook beneath your pillow.

I wonder whether you ever wrote the things you could not say to me.

I have thought about searching for you. More times than I care to admit. I have stood outside the post office with your name in my mind, wondering whether a letter could cross the years without arriving too late.

But I was afraid.

Afraid you would have forgotten me.

Afraid you would remember me.

Afraid that I would discover the person I had been waiting for no longer existed, and that the years I had spent carrying you would have nowhere to go.

So, I did what frightened people often do.

I called my silent patience.

I called my fear of acceptance.

And I told myself that some doors were meant to remain closed.

Perhaps I was wrong.

If you are still somewhere in this world, I hope you have found a reason to wake up in the morning. I hope someone knows what makes you laugh. I hope you have forgiven the boy you were for not knowing how to become the man you needed to be.

And if you have forgotten me, then I hope forgetting has been kind to you.

I do not need you to remember me in order for the years we shared to have mattered.

I only need to know that somewhere, beyond the reach of this old house and its old regrets, you are still learning how to live.

That would be enough.

With a tenderness I should have expressed sooner,

Zehra.

Ayla lowered the letter.

For a long time, she sat without moving.

This was different from the letter for Farah. There was no address, no clear path to follow. No one waiting behind a gate might open the door and tell her what had happened.

Only a photograph of a young man and a woman who had spent years wondering about him.

Who was he?

Why did he leave?

And why did Nani sound as though she had been waiting for him for a lifetime?

Ayla searched for the envelope again.

There was nothing else inside except a small scrap of paper folded into quarters.

She opened it.

Three words had been written in blue ink.

Ask the bookseller.

Below is the address.

Not in Gulmohar Colony, but in the old part of the city, near a market, Ayla remembered visiting as a child.

She read it twice.

Then she took out her notebook and copied it down.

For a moment, she considered calling her mother.

But her mother had already told her that there were parts of Nani's past she did not know. And Ayla had begun to understand that asking her mother to explain every mystery would only give them another reason to retreat into silence.

This time, she would go by herself.

The old book market was narrower than Ayla remembered.

Shops leaned toward one another across the lane; their faded signs hanging above piles of second-hand novels, old newspapers, and books whose covers had been softened by years of handling.

A man pushed a cart of oranges past a tea stall. Somewhere, a radio player played an old song. The air smelled of dust, cardamom, and rain that had not yet fallen.

Ayla walked slowly, checking the shop numbers.

She had not been here for years.

Once, Zain had brought her to a market much like this one, insisting that she could find a better book for half the price if she stopped looking at the shiny new editions.

“You judge books by their covers,” he had teased.

“You judge people by their shoes,” she replied.

“Shoes tell you everything.”

“They tell you whether someone owns shoes.”

He had laughed so hard that the bookseller had asked them to leave if they were not going to buy anything.

The memory arrived with such warmth that Ayla almost turned around, expecting to see her brother standing behind her.

For one brief second, she could hear his laughter clearly.

Then the sound faded.

Her chest tightened.

Bas, she told herself gently. *One breath at a time.*

She kept walking.

The address led her to a narrow shop squeezing between a tailor and a store selling old radios. A wooden sign above the entrance read:

RAHMAN BOOK DEPOT

The paint had peeled from the letters. A stack of books sat outside beneath a plastic sheet.

Inside, a ceiling fan turned with a tired clicking sound.

An elderly man sat behind the counter, reading through a pair of thick glasses. His white hair was combed neatly to one side, and a small cup of tea rested beside his elbow.

“Assalam-o-alaikum,” Ayla said.

“Wa-alaikum-assalam.”

He looked up.

“Can I help you?”

“I hope so.” She took the photograph from her backpack. “I’m looking for someone who may have known my grandmother. Her name was Zehra Begum.”

The old man did not take the photograph immediately.

Instead, he looked at Ayla’s face.

“Zehra Begum?”

“Yes.”

He removed his glasses.

For several seconds, he simply stared at her.

Then he stood.

“Allah,” he whispered. “You have her eyes.”

Ayla felt a strange chill move through her.

“You knew her?”

He took the photograph from her hand and studied it.

“I knew many people who knew her. And I knew the young man in this picture.”

Ayla leaned forward.

“Who is he?”

The bookseller looked toward the open doorway, where the afternoon light fell across the pavement.

“His name was Imran.”

“Was?”

The man’s expression softened.

“Forgive me. I speak as old people do. We put the past in the wrong tense.”

He returned his gaze to the photograph.

“Imran was a regular visitor here when I was younger. He loved books, although he rarely had enough money to buy them. He would stand in this very shop and read until I threatened to charge him rent for the space he occupied.”

Ayla smiled despite herself.

“That sounds familiar.”

“Does it?”

“My brother used to do that.”

The bookseller's smile lingered for a moment, then faded.

"He was a good boy," he said, as though the words belonged to a memory rather than the person in front of him.

Ayla wondered whether he had mistaken her for someone else.

"Did my grandmother know him?"

"Oh, yes." The bookseller returned to his chair. "Your grandmother knew him very well."

"How?"

He looked at her carefully.

"That is a longer story than I can tell before my tea gets cold."

Ayla glanced at the clock on the wall.

"I have time."

The bookseller laughed softly.

"Then you are already more patient than your grandmother was."

He motioned for her to sit on the wooden chair across from him.

“Tell me, "He said, “what has Zehra Begum been writing about these days?”

Ayla hesitated.

“She died last year.”

The man’s expression changed.

The fan clicked overhead.

Outside, a motorbike passed through the lane.

“I see,” he said quietly.

He lowered his eyes to the photograph.

“I wondered why she had not come.”

Ayla’s fingers curled around the edge of her chair.

“You were expecting her?”

“Not exactly. But some people become part of your life so completely that you keep a place for them, even after you stop expecting them to arrive.”

He set the photograph on the counter.

“Your grandmother came here about six months ago. She asked whether I still had a particular book. A collection of short stories was published a long time ago. The cover was green, and the pages smelled of damp paper.”

Ayla thought of the books in Nani’s study.

“Did you find it?”

“I did. But she did not come to collect it.”

“Why not?”

The bookseller rubbed his thumb against the rim of his teacup.

“She told me she was preparing some letters. She said there were people she had not been able to help when she was younger, and others she had helped without ever telling them. She wanted to make certain that, if she could no longer visit them herself, someone would carry a few words in her place.”

Ayla looked down at the photograph.

“Did she mention Imran?”

The bookseller was quiet for so long that Ayla began to wonder whether he had heard of her.

Then he nodded.

“She asked me a question.”

“What question?”

“Whether a person could begin again after wasting half a lifetime.”

Ayla felt the words settle somewhere deep inside her.

“What did you say?”

He smiled without happiness.

“I told her that I had wasted more than half of mine, so I was hardly the right person to ask.”

“And what did she say?”

“She said, ‘Then perhaps you know better than anyone that it is not too late.’”

Ayla looked away.

For the first time, she understood that her grandmother had not spent her life teaching people how to be brave.

Perhaps she had simply kept finding people who were frightened, sitting beside them, and reminding them that fear did not have to make every decision.

“Do you know where Imran is now?” She asked.

The bookseller sighed.

“I wish I did.”

“Has no one heard from him?”

“Not for many years. He left the city when he was young. He wanted to become a writer, but his family needed money, and dreams are often the first things people put away when the bills arrive.”

He paused.

“Your grandmother believed he was still writing. She said that once, a person has learned to speak through words, silence never quite fits them again.”

Ayla thought of the notebook beneath her pillow.

Of the pages she had filled with sentences she could not say aloud.

“Did he know she was looking for him?”

“I don't know.”

The answer was simple and devastating.

Ayla had hoped for a name, a location, a door she could knock on. Instead, she had found another absence.

She looked at the photograph again.

“What am I supposed to do with this?”

The bookseller leaned back.

“That depends. Are you looking for him because your grandmother wanted you to, or because you want to know what happened?”

Ayla opened her mouth, then closed it.

She had not considered that there might be a difference.

“I think,” she said slowly, “I want to understand her.”

The bookseller nodded.

“Then you should know something about Zehra Begum.”

He reached beneath the counter and pulled out a thin, green-covered book.

The corners were worn, and a faded paper label had been pasted across the spine. He placed it in front of Ayla with the care one might use when setting down something fragile.

“Your grandmother gave this to me many years ago. She said it belonged to someone who had forgotten why he had wanted to write in the first place.”

Ayla opened the cover.

On the first page, written in dark blue ink, were the words:

For Imran, who once believed that every human heart deserved a story.

Beneath them was a date from nearly forty years earlier.

And the second line.

If you cannot find your way home, begin by writing down where you have been.

Ayla ran her fingers over the ink.

It was unmistakably Nani’s handwriting.

“Can I borrow it?”

The bookseller shook his head.

“You may have it.”

“But it's yours.”

“It was never mine to keep.”

He closed the book gently and pushed it toward her.

“Perhaps your grandmother knew you would come.”

Ayla looked up.

“Why would she think I would come here?”

The bookseller gave her a sad, knowing smile.

“Because she knew what grief does to a person who is afraid of forgetting. It makes them search for everything that has ever mattered.”

Ayla could not speak.

He continued, more softly, “But Beti, remember this: searching for the past is not the same as living in it.”

The words did not sound like a warning.

They sounded like something he had learned the difficult way.

Ayla slipped the photograph between the pages of the book.

“Thank you.”

“Wait.”

He reached for a small scrap of paper and wrote something on it.

“Take this, too.”

She glanced down.

It was an address, written in a shaky hand.

“What's this?”

“The last place I heard Imran might have gone. It is an old address, and I cannot promise you will find anything there. But your grandmother asked me to keep it.”

Ayla stared at the paper.

“Why didn't you give it to her?”

His eyes filled with quiet regret.

“I thought there would be more time.”

The sentence passed between them like a familiar shadow.

Ayla's throat tightened.

“So did I,” she whispered.

The bookseller looked at her then—not at the granddaughter of Zehra Begum, not at a stranger carrying an old photograph, but at someone who understood exactly what those words meant.

He reached across the counter and rested his hand over hers.

“May Allah make the road gentle for you.”

“Ameen,” Ayla replied.

And when she stepped back into the afternoon, the book held tightly against her chest; she felt something she had not expected to feel.

Not certainty.

Not relief.

Possibility.

By the time Ayla reached home, the sky had turned the pale grey that came before rain.

Her mother was in the sitting room, folding clothes that were already folded.

She looked up when Ayla entered.

“Where have you been?”

“Looking for someone.”

Her mother set the clothes aside.

“Someone?”

Ayla placed the green book on the table.

“Nani knew a man named Imran. I found a photograph of him in one of her letters. The bookseller said she had been trying to find him.”

Her mother stared at the book.

“Imran?”

“You know him?”

For a moment, something unreadable crossed her face.

Then she shook her head.

“No. I knew of him.”

Ayla sat down opposite her.

“What does that mean?”

Her mother looked out the window.

“Your grandmother used to tell stories about people she had known when she was young. She never told the same story twice. I stopped trying to keep track.”

“Was he important to her?”

Her mother rubbed her palms against the fabric of her trousers.

“I think he was important to the person she used to be.”

Ayla waited.

“She was very young when she met him,” her mother continued. “And she had so many plans. Before she became your Nani, before she became the woman who remembered everyone's birthdays and sent food to people who were ill, she was a girl who wanted to see the world.”

Ayla smiled faintly.

“I can't imagine Nani as a girl.”

“Neither could I, for a long time.”

Her mother looked at her.

“Perhaps that is what happens when someone spends their life caring for others. We begin to believe they were born knowing how.”

Ayla thought of Farah and the photograph beneath the Gul Mohar tree.

“She wanted to be a teacher,” Ayla said. “Farah told me.”

Her mother nodded.

“She taught children in the neighborhood whenever she could. She never forgot that dream.”

“Did she ever regret not becoming one?”

“Of course.”

The answer surprised her.

Her mother continued, “But regret doesn't always mean a person hates the life they lived. Sometimes it simply means they remember the other lives they might have had.”

Ayla looked down at her hands.

She had spent so long believing that loving Zain meant wishing for nothing beyond the life in which he was still alive.

As if every future without him were betrayal.

“What if you regret something forever?” She asked.

Her mother was quiet.

“Then perhaps you learn to carry the regret without letting it carry you.”

Ayla looked up.

“Did Nani tell you that?”

“No.”

Her mother gave a small, tired smile.

“I think I'm learning it now.”

Rain began to tap against the windows.

Ayla wanted to tell her about the phone call again. She wanted to say Zain's name without watching her mother's face tighten, wanted to describe the memory that returned every night, wanted to confess that sometimes she was angry with him for leaving and then hated herself for being angry.

Instead, she reached for the green book and opened it.

A folded piece of paper slipped from between the pages.

It landed on the table.

Ayla picked it up.

The handwriting was her grandmother's.

But this time, the letter was not addressed to a stranger.

It was addressed to her.

For Ayla, when she is ready to understand.

Her fingers began to tremble.

Her mother noticed.

“What is it?”

Ayla unfolded the paper.

The letter was short.

My dearest Ayla,

If this letter has reached you, then you have begun looking beyond your own sorrow.

I do not say this because your sorrow is small. It is not. I know what it means to lose someone whose absence changes the shape of every room.

But there are stories in this world that will find you only when you have learned to sit beside your own pain without believing it is the only pain that matters.

You have always had a tender heart, my child. After Zain died, I watched you turn that tenderness against yourself.

I wanted to reach for you. I wanted to tell you that grief was not a punishment, and that love did not demand that you suffer every day in order to remain true.

But I was afraid of saying the wrong thing.

So, I waited for the right moment.

And then I grew ill, and the right moment never came.

I am sorry for that.

There is something else I want you to know.

You may spend years wondering why I kept these letters. You may even be angry with me for leaving you so many unfinished stories.

Do not feel obliged to complete them all.

You are not responsible for every life that has been broken. You are not required to rescue every person who has lost their way.

Sometimes, all you can do is listen.

Sometimes, you can offer a cup of tea, a quiet room, or a few honest words.

And sometimes, you must let another person walk on their own road.

Please remember this, Ayla: kindness is not measured by how much of yourself you are willing to destroy for someone else.

You are allowed to live, too.

You are allowed to laugh without apologizing.

You are allowed to discover a future that does not look like the one you imagined.

And if you ever find yourself standing before a closed door, wondering whether you have the courage to knock, I hope you will remember that the door may open.

It may not be.

But you will never know while you remain outside.

With all the love I did not always know how to express,

Your Nani.

Ayla read the letter once.

Then again.

By the third time, her vision had blurred.

She lowered the page and pressed it against her chest.

“I miss her,” she whispered.

Her mother moved from the other side of the table and sat beside her.

“I know.”

“No, Ammi. I mean…” Ayla struggled to find the words. “I miss her in ways I didn't even know I could miss someone. I thought I knew her. I thought I knew everything about her.”

Her mother wrapped an arm around her shoulders.

“We never know everything about the people we love.”

Ayla let out a broken laugh.

“Why didn't we ask more questions?”

“Because we thought we had time.”

The answer settled between them.

Ayla leaned into her mother's shoulder.

For a while, neither spoke. The rain grew heavier, drumming against the windows and filling the pauses that once would have frightened them.

Then Ayla said, “I think Nani wanted me to find these letters.”

Her mother kissed the top of her head.

“I think she hoped you would.”

“What if I can't help anyone?”

“Then you don't have to.”

Ayla lifted her head.

Her mother wiped a tear from her cheek.

“Your grandmother did not leave you duty, Ayla. She left you a choice.”

Ayla looked at the letter in her hands.

For so long, she had believed that the only way to honor the people she loved was to remain exactly where they had left her.

Perhaps love could ask something different.

Perhaps it could ask her to keep going.

Not because the people she had lost mattered less.

But because they had mattered so much.

That night, Ayla sat at her desk with the green book open beside her notebook.

The rain had stopped. Water dripped from the branches outside, and the garden smelled of wet earth.

She took out the photograph of Imran.

A young man at a railway station.

A woman who had spent years remembering him.

A grandmother who had grown old carrying questions she had never found the courage to ask.

Ayla wondered how many people were walking around with their entire lives hidden behind their ordinary faces.

How many had once dreamed of becoming artists, teachers, writers, travelers?

How many had learned to call their loneliness independence because it sounded less frightening?

How many had convinced themselves they were fine simply because no one had asked them to be anything else?

She thought of the note about Hamza.

He will tell you that he is doing well. Do not believe him too quickly.

She turned to the page where she had written his name.

Beneath it, she added:

Tomorrow, I will find out who Hamza is.

Then she looked at the address the bookseller had given her.

The place where Imran might have gone.

She copied it into the notebook, but she did not write *Tomorrow* beside it.

Not every mystery needed to be solved immediately.

Not every road needed to be taken at once.

Outside, a drop of rain slid from the end of a leaf and fell into the soil. The little green shoot in the garden stood upright, its fragile stem shining beneath the porch light.

Ayla watched it for a long time.

She still missed Zain.

She still wished she had answered his call.

She still woke some mornings with the terrible, impossible hope that the world might have changed its mind.

None of that had disappeared.

But tonight, alongside the ache, there was something else.

A question.

My name.

A book that had once belonged to a stranger.

And a small, uncertain desire to discover what came next.

Ayla opened her notebook to a clean page.

At the top, she wrote:

I don't know how to begin again.

She paused.

Then she added:

But perhaps beginning again does not mean returning to the person I was before.

Perhaps it means becoming someone who can carry what happened without allowing it to decide everything that happens next.

She set down her pen.

“Dekhte hain,” she whispered.

Let's see.

For the first time in a long while, tomorrow did not feel like a punishment she had to endure.

It felt like a door.

And somewhere beyond it, another story was waiting to be heard.

Chapter Five

The Man Who Shelved His Dreams

Some people give up on their dreams all at once.

Others do it so quietly that even they fail to notice when it happens.

They stop talking about the things they once wanted. They learn to laugh when someone asks about their ambitions. They find sensible reasons to postpone their happiness until postponement becomes a way of life.

And one day, they wake up in a life that looks perfectly acceptable from the outside and wonder why it feels so unfamiliar from within.

Hamza has become very good at being acceptable.

He woke up at six every morning, drank his tea without sugar, and left his apartment at precisely seven fifteen. He worked at a small accounting firm where his colleagues described him as dependable. His landlord described him as quiet. His younger sister described him as impossible to understand.

No one described him as happy.

Perhaps they had stopped expecting it.

Hamza rarely used the word.

Happiness, he believed, was an expensive thing. It required time, money, and the sort of courage that ordinary people could not always afford.

He had bills to pay.

A mother who needed medication is correct.

A younger sister whose university fees arrived with unfailing regularity, regardless of whether his salary did.

Dreams he had decided years ago were luxuries.

And Hamza had responsibilities.

It was a reasonable explanation.

He had repeated it so often that it had begun to sound like the truth.

The bookshop was the one place in the city where Hamza still allowed himself to linger.

It stood in a narrow lane in the old market, squeezed between a tailor and a shop that repaired radios. The wooden sign above the entrance had faded, and the ceiling fan inside made a clicking sound every few seconds.

Hamza had been visiting the shop since he was nineteen.

Back then, he had spent entire afternoons reading novels while the bookseller pretended not to notice. He had carried a notebook everywhere and filled it with stories about people he had never met, places he had never visited, and lives he imagined he might one day live.

He wanted to become a writer.

Not a famous one, necessarily.

He wanted to write the kind of stories that made a person feel less alone at two in the morning. Stories that could sit beside someone in their darkest hour without demanding that they become hopeful too quickly.

He wanted his words to mean something.

Then his father had died.

And the world has become a list of expenses.

The notebook disappeared into a drawer. The novels gathered dust. The future he had imagined became something he mentioned only in the past tense.

I wanted to be a writer.

I *don't want to be one.*

There was a difference.

He visited the bookshop less often after that, but he never stopped completely. Sometimes, during his lunch break, he would wander through the market and stand outside the familiar doorway.

He told himself he was looking for a particular book.

He almost never bought one.

That afternoon, he entered the shop to escape the heat.

“Ah, Hamza,” the bookseller said, looking up from his newspaper. “I was beginning to think you had forgotten the way here.”

Hamza smiled faintly.

“I've been busy.”

“You are always busy.”

“Someone has to be.”

The bookseller folded his newspaper.

“And when you finish being busy?”

Hamza reached for a book on the nearest shelf.

“I'll let you know.”

The old man sighed, but he did not argue.

Hamza preferred him that way.

People who asked too many questions were dangerous. They made you examine things you had spent years learning to ignore.

He wandered toward the back of the shop, where the older books were kept. He ran his fingers over a row of worn spines and stopped at a collection of short stories.

He knew the book.

He had read it so many times as a young man that he could remember several passages by heart.

He pulled it from the shelf.

A small piece of paper slipped from between its pages and landed near his shoe.

Hamza bent to pick it up.

It was an old receipt.

On the back, someone had written a sentence in blue ink.

If you cannot find your way home, begin by writing down where you have been.

His fingers went still.

For a moment, the market disappeared.

He was nineteen again, standing in this same shop with a notebook beneath his arm and a future that seemed wide enough to contain every possibility.

He remembered the woman who had written those words.

He remembered her smile, her stubbornness, the way she tilted her head when she was about to disagree with him.

Most of all, he remembered the day he had left without saying goodbye.

Hamza turned the paper over.

There was no name.

Only the sentence.

He placed it carefully inside the book and carried it both to the counter.

“How much?”

The bookseller studied with him.

“For you? Nothing.”

“I'm not asking for charity.”

“And I am not offering it. That book has been waiting for the right person to take it.”

Hamza frowned.

“Books don't wait for people.”

“No?” The bookseller leaned back in his chair. “Then why have you been coming here for twenty years?”

Hamza had no answer.

He placed a few notes on the counter and left before the old man could say anything else.

Outside, the afternoon sun burned against the pavement.

He walked back to work with the book tucked beneath his arm, telling himself that the sentence meant nothing.

It was just a sentence.

People write sentences every day.

But all afternoon, while numbers moved across his computer screen and his colleague discussed deadlines, the words remained in his mind.

Begin by writing down where you have been.

At six thirty, Hamza went home.

At seven, he called his mother to ask whether she had taken her medication.

At seven fifteen, he helped his sister with a university form.

At eight, he had dinner.

At eight thirty, he opened the book.

At nine, he found himself staring at the blank page of an old notebook he had taken from the bottom drawer of his wardrobe.

He had not written in it for eleven years.

The first page contained a story about a boy who wanted to see the sea.

Hamza read the opening paragraph.

Then he closed the notebook.

“Bas,” he muttered. “Enough.”

He took the notebook away.

But that night, he dreamed of the sea.

Ayla found Hamza's name in the following letter.

She had returned to her grandmother's house early the next morning, carrying a notebook, a bottle of water, and the green book she had borrowed from the past.

She was beginning to recognize the study's small sounds: the wooden floorboard that creaked near the desk, the window latch that resisted her fingers, the clock that lost several minutes every day.

The house was becoming familiar again.

Or perhaps she was becoming familiar with the version of herself who could enter it without immediately wanting to leave.

She sat at the desk and untied the remaining red ribbon.

There are fewer letters now.

She had already read the one for Farah. She had found a photograph of Imran and the green book. And the letter to Hamza had been waiting for her since the first day she entered the study.

She lifted it carefully.

The envelope had no address, only his name.

Hamza.

Beneath it, Nani had written:

For the man who learned to survive by forgetting what he once wanted.

Ayla unfolded the paper.

My dear Hamza,

I wonder whether you still write.

I wonder whether you have convinced yourself that you never really wanted to.

You were always good at making sacrifices that sound like decisions. When your father died, you told everyone you were choosing responsibility over ambition. When you stopped writing, you said you had outgrown the

dream. When people asked whether you were happy, you smiled and told them that happiness was not a practical goal.

You had an explanation for everything.

I admire your strengths. I did.

But I was young enough to mistake silence for peace and endurance for healing.

I wish I had asked you a different question.

Not whether you were managing.

Not whether the bills were paid.

Not whether you were strong for your family.

I wish I had asked whether there was still something in your life that made you feel alive.

Because a person can fulfil every responsibility and still slowly disappear from their own life.

Hamza, I do not know what you have become. I do not know whether you still remember the boy who wrote stories on the backs of receipts, or whether you have buried him so deeply that even his name feels unfamiliar.

But I remember him.

I remember the way you looked when you spoke about the sea. You had never seen it, yet you described it as though you had spent your whole life listening to its waves.

I remember the story you once wrote about a man who spent forty years repairing clocks because he was afraid to admit that he wanted to paint.

You said the man was foolish.

I asked you whether you thought he was happy.

You did not answer.

I wonder if you understand the question now.

I am not asking you to abandon your responsibilities. The world is not so kind that I can tell you to leave everything behind and follow your dreams. I know what it means to be needed. I know how love can become a hundred small tasks that must be completed before the day is over.

But please, my child, do not confuse being needed to be alive.

Your family needs you.

That is true.

But they do not need a version of you that has forgotten how to feel joy.

They need you here, not merely functioning.

And you deserve a life that contains something besides survival.

I am sorry I did not tell you this when you were younger.

I am sorry that I allowed the years to pass, believing you would find your way back to yourself.

Perhaps you will.

Perhaps you already have.

If you are still telling yourself that it is too late, remember this: the years you have lost are not waiting to be returned. But the years you have left are still yours to live.

Start small.

Write one sentence.

Read one page.

Take one afternoon to remember what you loved before the world told you what you were allowed to want.

You do not have to become the person you imagined in the nineteenth century.

You only have to stop treating that young man as someone you must apologize for.

With love, and with a hope I should have offered you sooner,

Zehra.

Ayla read the letter twice.

The first time, she felt as though she was reading about a stranger.

The second time, she began to understand why Nani had kept it.

She had spent the last eighteen months measuring her life by everything she could no longer have.

Zain would not call.

He would not walk through the front door, complain about the food, or tease her about the books she bought and never finished. She could not return to the last

ordinary afternoon they had shared and chose different words.

But Hamza's letter was about a different kind of loss.

A loss could happen while a person was still breathing.

Ayla thought of the man in the photograph, the bookseller's-tired eyes, and her grandmother's words about the lives people might have had.

Then she noticed something at the bottom of the envelope.

A small note.

He will tell you that he is doing well. Do not believe him too quickly.

Ayla almost smiled.

“Nani, you really didn't make anything easy, did you?”

She placed the letter in her notebook.

Then she opened a fresh page and wrote:

Hamza — find him.

Underneath, she added:

Not to save him. Just listen.

She stared at the words for a moment.

It was the first time she had written down a plan that did not involve avoiding something.

It frightened her a little.

She decided that was probably a good sign.

The address she had copied from the bookseller led her to a modest apartment building on a busy road.

She went there two days later.

Not because she had become brave overnight, but because she had spent the previous evening finding reasons not to go, and by morning she had grown tired of listening to them.

She almost turned back twice on the way.

The first time was when a rickshaw driver dropped her at the wrong entrance.

The second was when she reached the building and realized she had no idea what she would say.

Assalam-o-alaikum, I am the granddaughter of a woman you may have forgotten, and she left me a letter explaining that you have forgotten yourself.

No.

Definitely not.

She stood beside the staircase, clutching the notebook against her chest.

“Ya Allah,” she whispered. “Please let me not embarrass myself.”

A woman carrying grocery bags passed her on the stairs.

“Beta, are you looking for someone?”

Ayla straightened.

“Yes. Hamza. I think he lives here.”

“Third floor. Flat seven.”

“Thank you.”

The woman smiled.

“Go on, then. He won't bite.”

Ayla hoped the woman was right.

She climbed the stairs slowly, stopping once to pretend she was checking her phone.

On the third floor, she found flat seven.

She stood outside the door.

Raised her hand.

Lowered it.

Raised it again.

Then she knocked.

Footsteps sounded from inside.

The lock turned.

The door opened.

The man standing in front of her was not the boy in the photograph.

Of course he wasn't.

He was older, his face leaner, his hair beginning to grey at the temples. He wore a pale blue shirt with its sleeves rolled up, and there was a tiredness in his eyes that made Ayla think of people who had learned to sleep without ever quite resting.

He looked at her with polite confusion.

“Yes?”

For one terrible second, Ayla forgot every sentence she had prepared.

“Are you Hamza?”

“Yes.”

“My name is Ayla.”

He waited.

She swallowed.

“My grandmother was Zehra Begum.”

The change in his face was immediate.

Not dramatic. Not the sort of expression one would notice from across a room.

But his eyes sharpened, and his hand tightened on the door.

“Zehra?”

Ayla nodded.

“She passed away last year.”

Hamza looked down.

For a moment, he seemed to have forgotten that she was standing there.

“I'm sorry,” he said at last.

The words were quiet, and something about them sounded painfully sincere.

“She was a good woman.”

Ayla had heard those words before, from Farah and the bookseller. Yet each time, they made her feel as though she were discovering another room in a house she had thought she knew.

“You knew her?”

Hamza gave a short, humorless laugh.

“I did, once.”

He stepped back from the doorway.

“Please. Come in.”

The apartment was small and carefully arranged.

There were two chairs in the sitting room, a low table, a television, and a shelf containing several neatly stacked folders. A school timetable had been pinned to the refrigerator, along with a handwritten shopping list.

Everything appeared to have a place.

Everything except the books.

They were stacked in uneven piles beside the sofa, under the table, and along one wall. Some were old novels with cracked spines. Others were collections of poetry; their pages marked with slips of paper.

Ayla noticed them immediately.

Hamza followed her gaze.

“I keep meaning to organize those.”

“They look organized enough.”

“They are not.”

“Maybe they prefer it that way.”

He looked at her, surprised.

For the first time, something like amusement appeared in his expression.

“Do you always have an answer?”

“No,” Ayla said. “Usually, I think of the right one about three hours after the conversation ends.”

Hamza laughed.

It was brief, but it changed his face.

Ayla felt a small, unexpected warmth at having caused it.

Then he gestured toward the sofa.

“Would you like tea?”

“No, thank you.”

He raised an eyebrow.

“You came all this way and you're refusing tea?”

“I didn't want to trouble you.”

“Making tea is not a tragedy, Ayla.”

She looked at him.

He seemed to realize what he had said.

“Sorry,” he added. “That sounded rather severe.”

“No. It's fine.”

He went to the kitchen.

Ayla sat on the sofa and looked around the room.

A framed photograph stood on the shelf. Hamza was much younger in it, standing beside an older man in front of a modest house. His smile was open and unguarded.

She wondered how many years had passed between that photograph and the man who had opened the door.

When Hamza returned with two cups of tea, she was still looking at it.

“My father,” he said.

“He looks kind.”

“He was.”

Hamza sat opposite her.

“He was also very good at making people believe he could fix anything.”

Ayla wrapped her hands around the cup.

“What happened?”

“He died when I was twenty-two.”

There was no bitterness in the way he said it. Only a fact he had repeated enough times that it no longer required explanation.

“I'm sorry.”

Hamza nodded.

“After that, things changed. My mother needed help. My sister was still in school. I had to work.”

“You were studying?”

“Literature.”

Ayla glanced toward the books.

“What did you want to do?”

Hamza looked at her over the rim of his cup.

“Why do you ask?”

“My grandmother's letter mentioned that you used to write.”

He went still.

Ayla reached into her bag and took out the letter.

“I hope you don't mind. She left it with the others.”

He did not reach for it.

Instead, he stared at the familiar handwriting.

For a long time, the only sound in the room was the ceiling fan.

“She kept that?” He asked.

“Yes.”

“After all these years?”

Ayla nodded.

Hamza let out a slow breath and looked away.

“I thought she'd forgotten.”

“She hadn't.”

“No,” he said softly. “I suppose she hadn't.”

He took the letter.

His fingers trembled slightly as he unfolded it.

Ayla looked toward the window, giving him the privacy of not being watched while he read.

She could hear the paper shifting in his hands.

Once, he stopped.

Then he continued.

When he finished, he folded the letter along its original creases and placed it on the table.

He did not speak.

Ayla waited.

She had begun to understand that silence did not always mean a conversation had failed. Sometimes it meant the words had finally reached the place they were meant to go.

At last, Hamza rubbed his eyes.

“Your grandmother was very unfair.”

Ayla blinked.

“What?”

“She waited until she was gone to tell me all the things I needed to hear.”

His voice cracked on the final word.

He cleared his throat.

“She always did that. She could make a person feel as though she understood them better than they understood themselves.”

Ayla smiled sadly.

“That sounds like her.”

Hamza looked down at the letter.

“I used to write stories for her.”

“Really?”

“She would correct my spelling and then tell me the story was beautiful. Even when it wasn't.”

“Maybe she liked the stories.”

“Perhaps.” He gave a faint smile. “Or perhaps she liked the boy who wrote them.”

Ayla thought of Nani's words.

You only have to stop treating that young man as someone you must apologize for.

“Maybe it was both,” she said.

Hamza looked at her.

For a moment, he seemed to see something in her face that he recognized.

“Your grandmother said you were quiet when you were upset,” he said.

Ayla's smile disappeared.

“She talked about me?”

“Sometimes. She worried about you.”

Ayla lowered her gaze to the tea.

“I wasn't very good at letting people help me.”

“Neither was I.”

They sat in silence.

Then Hamza asked, “How are you managing?”

The question caught her off guard.

It was so ordinary. So easy to answer with the expected words.

I'm fine.

I'm getting by.

It's been difficult, but I'm managing it.

Ayla had used those sentences so many times that they had become automatic.

She could feel one rising to her lips.

Instead, she looked at him and said, “I'm not sure I am.”

Hamza did not look away.

She took a breath.

“My brother died eighteen months ago. A road accident. I keep thinking about the last time he called me. We had argued, and I didn't answer.”

She stared at the cup in her hands.

“I know I didn't cause the accident. I know that. But some part of me keeps believing that if I'd answered, if I'd spoken to him, if I'd said something different, maybe I wouldn't feel like this.”

Her voice grew smaller.

“And sometimes I think that if I stop feeling guilty, it will mean I've stopped loving him.”

Hamza said nothing for a while.

Then he leaned forward and placed his cup on the table.

“I don't think love works that way.”

Ayla looked up.

“I know it doesn't make sense,” she said quickly. “I know that. People have told me.”

“Perhaps they are right about the facts,” Hamza replied. “But facts do not always know what to do with grief.”

She stared at him.

He continued carefully.

“When my father died, I became convinced that I had to keep everything together. I thought that if I worked hard enough, if I never complained, if I made sure my mother and sister had everything they needed, then his death would not have been for nothing.”

He looked toward the photograph on the shelf.

“I turned my entire life into an argument with something that could not answer me.”

Ayla felt her throat tightened.

“Did it help?”

“No.”

The honesty of the answer surprised her.

“Not at first. Not for a very long time.”

He leaned back.

“I still miss him. There are days when I want to call him about something ridiculous, like a leaking tap or a book I have just read. Then I remember.”

His mouth tightened.

“But I no longer believe that being miserable is the only way to prove he mattered.”

Ayla looked down.

She wished someone had told her that eighteen months ago.

She wished she had been able to believe it.

“I'm not sure how to stop,” she whispered.

Hamza nodded.

“Neither am I.”

It was not the answer she had expected.

It was also the first answer that made her feel less alone.

Before Ayla left, Hamza walked her to the door.

“Thank you for bringing the letter,” he said.

“I think Nani wanted you to have it.”

“She always did have a talent for getting the last word.”

Ayla smiled.

“Even when she wasn't in the room.”

“Especially then.”

He glanced at the letter in his hand.

“May I ask you something?”

“Of course.”

“Did she leave letters for other people?”

Ayla hesitated.

“Yes. Several.”

“Do you know who they are?”

“Some of them.”

Hamza nodded slowly.

“Then perhaps you should find them.”

She looked at him.

“Why?”

“Because your grandmother clearly spent a long time worrying about people who had forgotten how to ask for help.”

He paused.

“But, Ayla, do not turn her letters into another responsibility you must carry perfectly. If you cannot find someone, that does not mean you have failed her.”

She thought of the bookseller's warning.

Searching for the past is not the same as living in it.

“I'll try to remember that.”

“Good.”

He opened the door.

Ayla stepped into the corridor, then turned back.

“Hamza?”

“Yes?”

“Do you still write?”

His expression changed.

For a moment, he looked almost angry.

Then the anger softened into something more difficult to name.

“I used to.”

“That isn't what I asked.”

He stared at her.

Ayla immediately regretted the words.

“I'm sorry. That was rude.”

“No,” he said after a moment. “It was fair.”

He glanced toward the sitting room, where the old books stood in their untidy piles.

“I don't know.”

Ayla nodded.

“That's okay.”

She started down the stairs.

Behind her, Hamza called her name.

She turned.

“If I did,” he said, “I wouldn't know where to begin.”

Ayla held the railing.

“Maybe with one sentence.”

He looked at her for a long time.

Then, very slowly, he smiled.

“Your grandmother would have liked you saying that.”

“I think she would have corrected my spelling first.”

Hamza laughed.

This time, the sound lasted a little longer.

That evening, Hamza sat alone at his kitchen table.

His mother had gone to bed early, and his sister was studying in her room. The apartment was quiet except for the occasional sound of a vehicle passing outside.

Zehra's letter lay open in front of him.

He had read it four times.

On the fifth, he stopped at the sentence about the sea.

He could still remember the first time he had tried to describe it to her.

He had never seen the ocean. His knowledge came from books, photographs, and the stories told by people who had travelled farther than he had.

Yet he had been certain that the sea would make him feel small in the best possible way.

He had wanted to stand at the water's edge and watch the waves arrive, one after another, without needing to prove anything to anyone.

Zehra laughed when he told her.

Then she had said, “You speak about the sea as if it is waiting for you.”

“Maybe it is,” he replied.

At nineteen, he had believed that the world contained places where a person could begin again.

At thirty-eight, he was no longer certain that beginning again was something ordinary people were allowed to do.

He picked up his old notebook.

The cover was bent. Several pages had come loose from the binding. His handwriting on the first page belonged to someone he could almost remember.

He turned to a blank sheet.

Held the pen above it.

Waited.

Nothing came.

He put the pen down.

“Stupid,” he muttered.

Then he picked it up again.

The problem he realized was that he was trying to write something good.

Something worthy of the years he had lost.

Something that might justify all the stories he had never told.

He looked at the blank page.

For the first time in years, he allowed himself to write something that did not need to be good.

Today, a girl came to my door carrying a letter from a woman I thought had forgotten me.

He stopped.

Read the sentence.

Then I wrote another letter.

She looked as though she was carrying something much heavier than a letter.

His hand trembled.

He continued.

I wanted to tell her that grief changes the shape of a person's life. Sometimes you become so busy surviving that you forget you were allowed to want things, too.

He paused.

Outside, the city moved through another ordinary evening.

Someone laughed in the neighboring apartment. A motorbike started and drove away. His sister called out to ask whether he had seen her charger.

Hamza answered her.

Then he returned to the notebook.

He wrote until his tea went cold.

When he finally stopped, several pages were filled.

The words were uneven. Some sentences were awkward. One paragraph made him wince when he read it back.

But the pages existed.

He touched the ink with the side of his hand, careful not to smudge it.

A strange feeling rose inside him.

It was not happiness.

Not yet.

It was closer to recognition.

As though, somewhere beneath the years of responsibility and exhaustion, a part of him had quietly lifted its head.

Tum Abhi yahin ho, he thought.

You're still here.

He closed the notebook, but he did not put it away.

Instead, he placed it on the table beside Zehra's letter.

For once, he wanted to see it when he woke up.

Ayla returned to her grandmother's house the next morning.

She had slept badly, but she no longer felt the same heaviness she had carried before visiting Hamza.

Nothing had been solved.

Hamza was still a man with responsibilities, grief, and a life he did not know how to change. Ayla was still a girl who woke up some morning expecting to hear her brother's voice.

But she learned something.

People did not always need to be rescued.

Sometimes, they needed someone to notice that they were tired.

Sometimes, they needed a question that was not about whether they were managing.

Sometimes, they needed permission to admit that they wanted something more.

She went into the study and opened her notebook.

Beside Hamza's name, she wrote:

He is not fine.

Then, after a moment, she added:

But he wrote something today.

She smiled at the sentence.

It was a small thing.

A beginning, perhaps.

She turned to the remaining letters.

One envelope was marked with a name she recognized from the notes Nani had left.

Sana.

Underneath, in smaller handwriting, was a sentence:

For the woman who learned to make herself smaller so that everyone else could feel comfortable.

Ayla rested her hand on the envelope.

She thought of her mother, folding clothes that were already folded. Of Farah, who had spent years protecting herself from the pain of a friendship she still missed. Of Hamza, who had turned his dreams into something, he was too embarrassed to admit he remembered.

And of herself.

How often had she made herself smaller inside her own grief? How many times had she swallowed her words because she thought sadness was something other people should not have witnessed?

She opened the letter.

Outside, the little green shoot moved in the morning breeze.

Inside, the paper unfolded beneath her fingers.

And once again, her grandmother began to speak.

My dear Ayla,

If you are reading this, then you have met Hamza.

I hope he made you tea. He always believed that tea could solve most of the world's problems.

It cannot, of course.

But it gives people something warm to hold while they discover what can.

I have written to you about grief, regret, and the people we lose even when they are still alive.

Now I want to tell you about a woman who spent years believing that her own happiness was the least important thing in the room.

Her name is Sana.

And she is still learning that she matters.

Please be gentle with her.

Be gentle with yourself, too.

Love,

Nani.

Ayla looked at the name on the envelope.

Sana.

Somewhere in the city, a woman was waking up, making breakfast, answering messages, and moving through a life that might look perfectly ordinary to everyone around her.

Perhaps she was smiling when she wanted to cry.

Perhaps she was saying yes when every part of her wanted to say no.

Perhaps she had forgotten that wanting something for herself was not the same as taking something away from someone else.

Ayla slipped the letter into her bag.

Tomorrow, she will begin looking for Sana.

Today, she sat beside the open window and let the sunlight reach her hands.

She thought of Zain.

She still wished she had answered his call.

She suspected she would always wish for it.

But for the first time, she wondered whether she could carry that wish without letting it close every door in front of her.

Maybe healing was not a grand decision.

Maybe it was a collection of small ones.

A letter was delivered.

A question asked.

A sentence written after eleven years of silence.

My daughter is sitting next to her mother.

A girl choosing to knock on a stranger's door.

A man remembering the person he had once wanted to become.

Ayla looked down at her hands.

“Main koshish karungi,” she whispered.

I will try.

And somewhere, in a small apartment across the city, Hamza opened his notebook again.

He read the first sentence he had written the night before.

Then he turned to a clean page.

This time, he did not wait for the perfect words.

He simply began.

Chapter Six

The Woman Who Chose Herself

Some women are taught to be kind before they are taught to be honest.

They learn to notice the smallest changes in other people's moods. They can tell when a voice has grown impatient, when a silence means disappointment, when a smile is asking them to pretend that nothing is wrong.

They become experts at making rooms comfortable for everyone except themselves.

They apologize for asking questions. They explain their decisions before anyone challenges them. They learn to say *it's okay* when it isn't, and *I don't mind* when their hearts are quietly breaking.

And because they are so good at understanding everyone else, people rarely stop wondering whether anyone understands them.

Sana had spent most of her life being that woman.

She was thirty-four years old, married, and the mother of a seven-year-old daughter who believed her mother

could fix almost anything with a needle, a little patience, and the right amount of sugar.

Sana was good at many things.

She could stretch a meal when unexpected guests arrived. She remembered birthdays, school deadlines, and which relatives preferred their tea without cardamom. She could soothe a crying child while answering a phone call and stirring a pot on the stove.

She knew how to keep a household running.

What she no longer knew was how to answer the question:

What do you want?

Whenever someone asked, she offered an answer that would not inconvenience anyone.

Whatever you think is best.

I'm happy with everything.

It's not important.

She had been saying these things for so long even though she had begun to believe them.

Until one afternoon, an old letter arrived with her name written across the envelope.

And a woman who had spent years making herself invisible was asked, at last, to look at her own life.

Ayla found Sana's address inside the envelope.

It was written in faded blue ink, beneath a short note from her grandmother.

She lives in a house with the jasmine growing along the front wall. If you meet her, do not begin by asking whether she is happy. She has spent too long learning how to answer that question for other people.

Ayla read the note twice.

Then she looked at the address.

It was in an older neighborhood on the other side of the city, where the streets were narrow and the houses stood close together, their balconies filled with potted plants and drying clothes.

She could not remember the last time she had visited a stranger simply because someone she loved had asked her to.

The thought made her nervous.

Still, she placed the letter in her bag, told her mother where she was going, and stepped outside.

“Call me when you get there,” her mother said.

“I will.”

“And don't forget to eat something.”

“Ammi, I'm going to visit someone, not cross a desert.”

Her mother gave her a look.

Ayla smiled.

“Okay. I'll eat.”

As she walked away, she heard her mother call after her.

“And Ayla?”

She turned.

Her mother hesitated, then said, “I'm glad you're going.”

Ayla carried those words with her all the way to the bus stop.

The house was easy to recognize.

Jasmine climbed along the front wall with its small white flowers scattered among the green leaves. A pair of children's shoes stood beside the doorway, and a red bicycle leaned against the gate.

Ayla rang the bell.

A little girl answered.

She had two uneven braids, a pencil tucked behind one ear, and a serious expression that suggested she had been entrusted with an important responsibility.

“Who are you?”

Ayla smiled.

“My name is Ayla. Is your mother home?”

The girl examined her.

“Are you selling something?”

“No.”

“Then why are you here?”

Ayla almost laughed.

“That's a very good question.”

The girl seemed satisfied with this answer.

“Mama!”

She shouted into the house, then turned back to Ayla.

“She is making lunch. If you're hungry, you can wait.”

“Thank you.”

“My name is Hiba.”

“It's lovely to meet you, Hiba.”

Hiba nodded solemnly.

Then she leaned closer.

“Are you a friend of Mama's?”

“Not yet.”

Before Hiba could ask what that meant, a woman's voice came from inside.

“Hiba, who is at the door?”

A woman appeared in the hallway, wiping her hands on a kitchen towel.

She wore a pale green shalwar kameez, and a few strands of hair had escaped the scarf loosely draped over her head. Her face held the tired softness of someone who had spent the morning taking care of everyone else.

When she saw Ayla, she paused.

“Yes?”

“Are you Sana?”

The woman's expression grew cautious.

“Yes.”

Ayla reached into her bag.

“My name is Ayla. My grandmother was Zehra Begum.”

For a moment, Sana did not move.

Then her eyes dropped onto the envelope in Ayla's hand.

“Zehra Begum?”

Ayla nodded.

Sana reached for the doorframe.

“Oh,” she whispered.

It was not the response Ayla had expected.

Not surprising alone.

Something closer to grief.

“Please,” Sana said, stepping aside. “Come in.”

The house smelled of fried onions, fresh coriander, and something sweet baking in the kitchen.

Ayla sat on the sofa while Sana asked Hiba to bring water.

The little girl returned with a glass held in both hands and set it carefully on the table.

“Are you staying for lunch?” She asked.

“I don't want to trouble your mother.”

Hiba looked confused.

“It's only lunch.”

Sana laughed softly from the doorway.

“She has a point.”

Ayla accepted another glass of water when Sana offered it.

For a few minutes, they talked about ordinary things. Hiba's school. The weather. The jasmine that had grown so thick along the wall that the gardener had threatened to cut it back.

Then Sana looked at the envelope again.

“Where did you find this?”

“My grandmother left several letters in her studies. She wrote to people she knew when she was younger.”

Sana's fingers tightened around her cup.

“I haven't heard from her in years.”

“She mentioned you.”

Sana looked out the window.

“What did she say?”

Ayla thought of the note.

Do not begin by asking whether she is happy.

“She said she hoped you were well.”

It was not a lie.

It was simply not the whole truth.

Sana lowered her gaze.

“Your grandmother was a remarkable woman.”

“Everyone seems to say that.”

“Because she was.”

A small smile touched Sana's face.

“She once came to my house when I had a terrible fever. I was newly married, and my husband was away on a work trip. I had no idea how to look after myself, let alone manage a household. Your grandmother arrived with soup, medicine, and a list of instructions long enough to frighten a doctor.”

Ayla smiled.

“That sounds like Nani.”

“She stayed until I fell asleep. When I woke up, she had washed the dishes and folded the laundry.”

Sana's smile faded.

“She did all that without making me feel useless. Do you understand how rare that is? Most people help you and somehow leave you feeling that you have failed at being a person.”

Ayla thought of the bookseller, who had offered her the green book without asking her to earn it.

“Yes,” she said quietly. “I think I do.”

Sana studied with her for a moment.

“You miss her.”

It was not a question.

Ayla looked down at her hands.

“Every day.”

Sana nodded.

“I am sorry.”

“Thank you.”

The silence that followed was gentle.

Then Sana looked at the envelope.

“May I?”

Ayla handed it to her.

Sana held it for several seconds before opening it, as though she was afraid the paper might disappear.

Inside was a single folded sheet.

She recognized the handwriting immediately.

Her lips parted.

“Oh, Zehra.”

She began to read.

My dear Sana,

I wonder how many times you have said yes when your heart was begging you to say no.

I wonder how often you have called yourself selfish for wanting a little time that belonged only to you.

You once told me that a good woman should know how to keep everyone happy.

I remember asking you whether you believed you were included in the word everyone.

You laughed at me.

Then you changed the subject.

I should have returned to that question.

I should have asked you why you were so frightened of the disappointed people who loved you.

Perhaps you would have told me that you were not frightened at all. Perhaps you would have said that a woman's life is made of compromises, and that you had simply learned to make yours.

And perhaps you would have been right.

Life does ask things of us. Marriage asks things about us. Children ask us things. The people we love are not always easy to love, and sometimes the kindest thing we can do is set aside what we want for the sake of someone who needs us.

But there is a difference between choosing to give and believing you are not allowed to keep anything for yourself.

One is love.

The other is a slow disappearance.

I have watched you make yourself smaller, Sana.

You lower your voice when someone is impatient. You hide your disappointment so that no one feels guilty. You say you are tired, then get up to make tea for someone who has not noticed how long you have been standing.

You call this patience.

Sometimes it is.

But patience should not require you to become a stranger to yourself.

Do you remember the afternoon when you came to my house and told me you wanted to study again? You found a course in design. You spoke about colors and fabrics and the things you wanted to create.

Your eyes were bright.

Then your phone rang.

You answered it, and by the time the call ended, you had put the brochure away.

I never saw you mention the course again.

I do not know what happened that afternoon. I do not know whether someone discouraged you, whether

circumstances made it impossible, or whether you decided there were more important things to do.

I only know that, afterward, you stopped speaking about it.

And I have wondered for years whether you stopped wanting it, or whether you simply became very good at hiding the want.

My dear girl, you do not have to prove that you are a good wife, a good mother, or a good daughter by making yourself unhappy.

You are allowed to love your family and still have dreams.

You are allowed to care for others and still need care.

You are allowed to say no without writing an essay to explain why.

And you are allowed to change your mind.

If you have forgotten what you want, do not be ashamed. Begin with something small.

Ask yourself what you would do if no one were disappointed by your answer.

Then listen.

Not to the voice that tells you what is practical.

Not to the voice that reminds you of what everyone expects.

Listen to the quieter voice beneath them.

The one that has been waiting patiently for you to come home.

I cannot tell you what your answer should be.

I can only hope that, when you find it, you will not dismiss it simply because it belongs to you.

With all my love,

Zehra.

When Sana finished reading, she did not fold the letter.

She held it open on her lap and stared at the last line.

Ayla waited.

Outside, a vegetable seller called out his prices. Hiba could be heard humming in another room as she arranged her schoolbooks.

Ordinary life continued around the two women.

Sana pressed her lips together.

“I had forgotten about that course.”

Ayla spoke softly.

“Did you want to do it?”

Sana let out a small, unsteady laugh.

“More than anything.”

“What happened?”

Sana looked at the letter.

“My husband had been offered a job in another city. We were discussing whether we should move. I thought I could take the course later, once we were settled.”

“Did you move?”

“No. He decided to stay.”

“And the course?”

Sana shook her head.

“By then, Hiba was on the way. Then she was born. Then there were school fees and family obligations and a hundred other things.”

She paused.

“Nothing terrible happened, Ayla. That's the strange part. No one forbade me from studying. No one locked me inside the house. I simply kept putting it off until I stopped mentioning it.”

Ayla thought about her own life.

There had been no single moment when she decided to stop living. No morning when she had announced that she would never be happy again.

She had simply stopped doing things.

Stopped meeting friends. Stopped reading. Stopped making plans.

One small refusal at a time.

Until the world had grown very small around her.

“Do you still want to do it?” She asked.

Sana looked at her as though the question had startled her.

“I don't know.”

Ayla nodded.

“That's okay.”

Sana glanced at her.

“You sound very sure.”

“I'm not.” Ayla smiled faintly. “I'm learning that I don't have to know everything immediately.”

For the first time since Ayla had arrived, Sana laughed without trying to soften the sound.

“Your grandmother would have liked you.”

“I hope so.”

“She would have told you to eat more.”

“She already sent my mother after me with that instruction.”

Sana laughed again.

Then the laughter faded, leaving a more vulnerable expression behind.

“I think I'm afraid,” she admitted.

“Of the course?”

“Of wanting it.”

Ayla remained quiet.

Sana folded the letter carefully.

“Wanting something makes you vulnerable. If you never admit that you want it, then you never have to discover whether you can have it.”

Ayla thought of Hamza standing in his doorway, saying he no longer knew how to begin.

“Yes,” she said. “I think I understand that.”

Sana looked toward the kitchen.

“I should check the food.”

She stood but did not move.

Then she sat down again.

The gesture was so small that Ayla might have missed it if she had not spent the past months learning to notice the things people did not say.

Sana looked at her hands.

“Would it be terrible if I told you I don't want to check the food right now?”

Ayla smiled.

“No.”

Sana let out a breath.

“Good.”

She leaned back against the sofa.

“For once, I would like someone else to stir the pot.”

Hiba appeared in the doorway carrying a drawing.

“Mama, look.”

Sana's face changed at once.

“What have you made?”

“Our family.”

She placed the paper on the table.

There were four figures drawn in bright colors. One was tall, one was small, and one had a head so large that it occupied nearly half the page.

Ayla leaned forward.

“Who is this?”

“That's me.”

“And this one?”

“Mama.”

Sana pointed to the tallest figure.

“That's Baba.”

Ayla noticed the fourth figure.

“And who is that?”

Hiba frowned.

“That's our cat.”

There were no cats in the picture.

Or in the house.

Ayla looked at Sana.

Sana looked at Hiba.

“Beta, we don't have a cat.”

“I know.”

“Then why have you drawn one?”

Hiba considered the question.

“Because I want one.”

Sana opened her mouth, then closed it.

Ayla had to press her lips together to keep laughing.

Hiba picked up the picture.

“Can we get one?”

Sana looked as though she were about to begin listing every practical reason a cat would be inconvenient.

The food. The cleaning. The furniture. The responsibility.

Ayla watched the familiar machinery of obligation begin to turn behind Sana's eyes.

Then Sana stopped.

She looked at her daughter.

“I don't know, sweetheart. Let me think about it.”

Hiba's eyes widened.

“You will?”

“I said I'd think about it.”

“That's almost a yes.”

“It is absolutely not a yes.”

Hiba grinned and ran away before her mother could say anything else.

Sana shook her head.

“Children are dangerous.”

“They ask direct questions.”

“Exactly.”

Ayla smiled.

For a moment, she imagined what it might have been like to have Zain at seven years old, asking for a cat he had no intention of caring for.

The thought hurt.

But this time, the pain was not close to her throat.

It simply arrived, sat beside her, and stayed.

She could miss her brother and still laugh.

The two things were not enemies.

She wished she had learned that sooner.

After lunch, Sana took Ayla to the small room at the back of the house.

It was a narrow space with a sewing machine near the window, shelves filled with fabric, and several cardboard boxes stacked beneath a table.

The sunlight fell across a collection of colored pencils and sketchbooks.

Ayla stopped at the doorway.

“What is this room?”

Sana looked around as though, seeing it through someone else's eyes.

“Nothing important.”

Then she caught herself.

Her expression changed.

“No,” she said quietly. “That's not true.”

She walked to the table and lifted a piece of cloth.

It was a beautiful deep-blue fabric embroidered with small white flowers.

“I used to design clothes,” she explained. “Not professionally. Just for myself, and sometimes for friends. I would draw the patterns, choose the fabrics, and spend hours figuring out how to put everything together.”

She opened a cardboard box.

Inside were old notebooks filled with sketches.

Some were simple outlines. Others showed elaborate dresses, embroidered sleeves, and flowing scarves decorated with delicate patterns.

Ayla stared at them.

“Sana, these are beautiful.”

“Some of them are terrible.”

“They aren't.”

“You haven't seen the stitching on the second one.”

“I don't need to see it. I'm looking at the drawings.”

Sana smiled, but her eyes had grown bright.

“I used to think I might have opened a small studio one day. Nothing is grand. A place where women could bring fabric and ideas, and we could make something together.”

“What happened to it?”

“Life happened.”

Ayla looked at the sketches again.

“Maybe life hasn't finished happening.”

Sana turned toward her.

The words seemed to surprise them both.

Ayla felt a familiar uncertainty rise inside her. She was not an expert at hope. She had only recently begun to recognize it when it appeared.

“I mean,” she added, “you still have the drawings. And the sewing machine.”

Sana ran her fingers over the edge of the table.

“The machine hasn't been used in years.”

“Does it still work?”

“I think so.”

“Then perhaps that's where you begin.”

Sana was silent.

Ayla did not tell her to open the studio immediately. She did not promise that everything would be easy or that the world would make room for her dreams.

She had learned that promises could sometimes become another burden.

Instead, she picked up one of the sketchbooks and turned to a page filled with designs.

“Which one did you like best?”

Sana came to stand beside her.

“This one.”

She pointed to a drawing of a simple white dress with blue embroidery along the sleeves.

“I designed it for my younger sister's wedding. I never finished it.”

“Why not?”

“Too many things to do.”

Ayla studied drawing.

“Do you still have the fabric?”

Sana's eyes widened slightly.

“I might.”

They searched for the boxes together.

For several minutes, the room filled with the sounds of cardboard shifting and folded cloth being lifted and replaced. Sana found old measuring tape, a tin of buttons, a packet of needles, and a small pair of scissors.

Then, at the bottom of the box, she found a length of white fabric wrapped in the newspaper.

She unfolded it carefully.

The cloth had yellowed slightly with age, but it was intact.

Sana ran her palm over it.

“Oh,” she whispered.

Ayla watched her.

There was a look at Sana's face that had not been there before. Something almost like a wonder.

“I thought I'd thrown this away.”

“But you didn't.”

“No.”

Sana held the fabric against herself, imagining the dress she had once intended to make.

Then she laughed softly.

“I don't even know whether the measurements will fit anymore.”

“Then you'll measure again.”

“What if I make a mess of it?”

“Then you'll make another one.”

Sana looked at her.

Ayla shrugged.

“I don't know much about sewing.”

“You have made that very clear.”

They both laughed.

And for the first time in years, Sana did not fold the fabric away.

She left it on the table.

Ayla stayed until late afternoon.

Before she left, Sana placed a container of food in her hands.

“My mother would be offended if I let you go home without something.”

“My mother will be delighted.”

“And Ayla?”

She turned.

Sana held Zehra's letter against her chest.

“Thank you for bringing this to me.”

“You don't have to thank me.”

“I know.” Sana smiled gently. “I'm choosing to.”

Ayla thought about that.

There was a difference between kindness offered freely and kindness treated as an obligation.

Perhaps that was something she needed to learn, too.

At the gate, Hiba ran out with her drawing.

“You forgot to tell me whether you like the cat.”

“I think he's very handsome.”

“It's a girl.”

“Then she's very handsome.”

Hiba giggled.

“That's not how it works.”

“I'm still learning.”

Hiba gave her a solemn nod.

“It's okay. I'll teach you.”

Ayla waved goodbye and stepped into the street.

The evening light had turned golden, and the jasmine along the wall released its fragrance into the warm air.

She walked toward the main road with the empty weight of her bag against her shoulder.

She had arrived expecting to deliver a letter.

She was leaving with something more difficult to name.

A reminder that people could disappear from their own lives without anyone noticing.

And that finding themselves again did not always require a dramatic escape.

Sometimes, it began with a piece of fabric left unfolding on a table.

That evening, Sana stood in the back room long after Hiba had gone to bed.

The house was quiet.

Her husband, Kamran, had called to say he would be late. He had a meeting the following morning and needed to finish some work.

Sana had said she would keep dinner warm.

She had asked whether he wanted tea when he came home.

She had reminded him to bring the medicine he had forgotten at the office.

Then she ended the call and returned to the room.

The white fabric still lays on the table.

She switched on the sewing machine.

The light flickered.

She pressed the pedal.

The machine made a loud, uneven noise, then stopped.

Sana stared at it.

She pressed the pedal again.

The needle moved once.

Then twice.

A small laugh escaped from her.

“Of course,” she murmured. “Now you're going to be difficult.”

She opened the drawer and found the instruction booklet beneath a stack of old papers.

For the next twenty minutes, she tried to understand what had gone wrong.

She did not call anyone.

She did not abandon the task when the thread tangled.

She did not tell herself she was too tired, too old, or too inexperienced to try.

At last, the machine began to run smoothly.

Sana sat back.

The sound filled the little room.

It was not a grand sound.

It would not have meant anything to anyone standing outside the house.

But to Sana, it felt like a voice returning after years of silence.

She placed the fabric beneath the needle.

Then she began to sew.

The next morning, Ayla found a message from Sana on her phone.

I found another sketchbook.

A second message followed.

And I think the sewing machine works.

Then, after a pause:

I haven't told anyone yet. I don't know why I'm telling you.

Ayla sat on the edge of her bed and smiled.

She typed a reply.

Maybe because you wanted someone to know.

She sent it.

A moment later, Sana replied.

Maybe.

Ayla put down her phone.

The room was quiet, and sunlight lay across the floor.

She thought of the people she had met through her grandmother's letters.

Farah, who had learned that reconciliation could not return lost years but could stop them from losing more.

Hamza, who had written his first sentence in eleven years.

Sana, who had switched on a sewing machine she had once believed, belonged to another life.

Three people.

Three different kinds of silence.

None of them had been healed by a single conversation. None had been handed a perfect answer.

They had simply been reminded that their stories were not finished.

Ayla opened her notebook.

Under Sana's name, she wrote:

She has begun.

Then she paused and added:

Maybe that is what I am learning to do, too.

Two days later, Sana came to Zehra Begum's house.

She arrived carrying a cloth bag and wearing an expression of nervous determination.

“I hope I'm not disturbing you,” she said.

Ayla welcomed her inside.

“Not at all.”

Sana looked around the old house.

“I haven't been here since your grandmother became ill.”

“She would have liked you to visit.”

Sana lowered her eyes.

“I know.”

There was regret in the answer, but not the kind that demanded to be comforted.

It was simply there.

Ayla led her to study.

Sana stood beside the desk, looking at the letters tied with a ribbon.

“She kept so many things,” she murmured.

“She wanted people to remember something, I think.”

“What?”

Ayla considered the question.

“That they were still here.”

Sana turned toward her.

Ayla felt the words rise from somewhere deeper than she thought.

“That they could still change. That they could still want things. That they could still begin again, even if they weren't the person they thought they would be.”

Sana's eyes softened.

“Your grandmother would have been proud of you.”

Ayla looked away.

She was still learning how to receive words like that without immediately searching for a reason they could not be true.

Sana placed her cloth bag on the desk and opened it.

Inside was the white fabric.

The dress was not finished. One sleeve remained unstitched, and the embroidery was only half complete.

But the shape of it had begun to emerge.

Ayla touched the fabric gently.

“You brought it.”

“I did.”

“Why?”

Sana smiled, nervous, and a little embarrassed.

“Because I wanted someone to see it.”

Ayla looked up.

Sana took a breath.

“I have been thinking about what Zehra wrote. About the difference between giving something because you want

to and giving because you believe you aren't allowed to keep it.”

She smoothed the fabric on the desk.

“I don't know what will happen next. I don't know whether I will ever open a studio. I don't even know whether I can finish this dress.”

She looked at Ayla.

“But I want to try.”

Ayla smiled.

“Then try.”

Sana laughed softly.

“You make it sound so easy.”

“It isn't.”

The answer surprised them both.

Ayla thought of Zain, of the unanswered call, of the long months she had spent believing that pain was the only honest response to loss.

“I think trying is one of the hardest things,” she said. “Especially when you don't know whether it will work.”

Sana reached across the desk and squeezed her hand.

“Then perhaps we can learn together.”

For a moment, Ayla could not speak.

She had come to deliver a letter.

She had not expected to find someone who wanted to stand beside her while she figured out how to live.

That afternoon, they sat in the garden.

Sana brought tea. Ayla had found two cups in the kitchen, and together they carried them outside.

The little green shoot had grown taller. Its leaves were small, but they were no longer tightly folded.

Sana crouched beside it.

“What is this?”

“I don't know.”

“You don't know what plant it is?”

Ayla shook her head.

“I found it here. I've just been watching it grow.”

Sana studied the leaves.

“It looks healthy.”

“I suppose.”

“Do you water it?”

“Every morning.”

Sana smiled.

“Then perhaps you are doing more than watching.”

Ayla looked at the shoot.

The thought stayed with her.

She had spent so long believing that healing meant something dramatic: a morning when she woke without grief, an afternoon when she could remember Zain without pain, a day when she finally forgave herself and never looked back.

But perhaps healing was less like a door swinging open and more like a garden.

Something had to tend to be.

Not forced.

Not rushed.

Not blamed for growing slowly.

Sana settled in the chair beside her.

“May I tell you something?”

“Of course.”

“I used to think that choosing myself meant choosing against my family.”

Ayla turned toward her.

“I thought that if I wanted time for my own work, I was being unfair to my husband and daughter. If I said no to someone, I was being unkind. If I admitted I was tired, I was failing.”

She wrapped both hands around her cup.

“I still love my family. That hasn't changed.”

“But something else has?”

Sana nodded.

“I am beginning to understand that I am part of my family, too.”

Ayla felt a strange ache behind her ribs.

How many times had she treated herself as though she were no longer part of the life she was trying to preserve?

She had believed that to love Zain, she must remain trapped in the moment he died.

But she was still here.

Still part of the world.

Still, someone who deserves kindness.

She looked at Sana.

“Do you think it's selfish to be happy after someone you love has died?”

Sana did not answer immediately.

She looked toward the house, where the late afternoon sunlight rested against the windows.

“No,” she said at last. “I think it is frightening.”

Ayla waited.

“Because happiness asks us to step into a moment, we cannot control it. It asks us to enjoy something without knowing how long it will last.”

Sana glanced at her.

“And when you have lost someone, you know exactly how much can be taken away.”

Ayla's eyes filled.

“Yes.”

“But, Ayla, the fact that something can end does not mean it was wrong to love it while it was here.”

The words were simple.

They did not erase anything.

They did not change the past.

Yet Ayla felt them settle somewhere she had not known was waiting.

She looked down at her hands.

“I don't know how to stop missing him.”

Sana reached for her hand.

“Maybe you don't have to stop.”

Ayla looked at her.

“Maybe you only have to make room for the rest of your life beside the missing.”

For a long time, Ayla said nothing.

Then she nodded.

The tears came quietly.

Sana did not tell her to be strong.

She did not offer a reason for Zain's death or promise that the pain would disappear.

She simply stayed.

And Ayla, who had spent so long believing she had to carry everything alone, let someone sit beside her grief.

That night, Ayla opened her notebook and wrote three sentences.

Hamza wrote again.

Sana began sewing again.

I am still learning how to live.

She read the last sentence several times.

Then she crossed the word *again*.

She did not know whether she was returning to an earlier version of herself. Perhaps that girl was gone, too.

She wrote instead:

I am still learning how to live.

The sentence felt quieter.

More honestly.

She closed the notebook and walked through the window.

Across the garden, the green shoot stood beneath the porch light.

The night was dark, but the little plant did not look frightened of it.

Ayla thought of Nani's letters, and the people whose names were still waiting to be discovered.

She thought of all the things love had asked of her.

And all the things she had wrongly believed in love required.

Maybe love did not ask her to remain broken.

Maybe it did not demand that she spend the rest of her life apologizing for the phone call she had not answered.

Maybe love could survive a day when she laughed.

A day when she made plans.

A day when she chose to live.

She rested her forehead against the cool window.

“Zain,” she whispered, her voice barely audible. “I still miss you.”

The words came easily.

For once, she did not follow them with an apology.

She let them be what they were.

A sister is missing her brother.

A girl remembering someone she loved.

A heart learning that grief and life could occupy the same space without destroying one another.

Then she whispered, “Aur main koshish kar rahi hoon.”

And I am trying.

Outside, a breeze moved through the garden.

The small leaves trembled, then settled.

They did not stop growing because the night had arrived.

And Ayla, watching them, began to understand that she did not have to wait for all the darkness to disappear before she could take her next step.

Chapter Seven

The Things We Never Say

There are words that become heavier the longer we carry them.

An apology that waits years to be spoken.

A confession hidden behind a smile.

A simple thing *I miss about you* is that it never finds its way past the throat.

At first, we keep these words because we are afraid of what might happen if we say them. We worry that someone will misunderstand, become angry, or look at us differently.

Then time passes.

The moment we were waiting for disappears. The person we wanted to speak to changes. Sometimes, they leave.

And the words remain.

We begin to tell ourselves that silence is easier.

Eventually, we forget that silence was ever a choice.

Ayla had become an expert at it.

She had learned to swallow her questions, hide her anger, and turn her sadness into a quietness that people mistook for strength.

But lately, her grandmother's letters had been asking questions she could no longer ignore.

What had she left unsaid for Zain?

What had her mother left unsaid to her?

And how many years could two people love each other while standing on opposite sides of a silence neither knew how to cross?

On a Thursday morning, Ayla discovered that the answer could be found in something as ordinary as a cup of tea.

Her mother was sitting at the kitchen table when Ayla came downstairs.

Two cups stood between them; one filled and the other untouched.

Ayla recognized the second cup.

It was Zain's.

Not literally, perhaps. They had owned several identical cups, white ceramic with a thin blue line around the rim. But this was the one he had always chosen because he claimed the handle was more comfortable.

After he died, her mother had moved it to the back of the cupboard.

Ayla had not seen it in months.

Now it sat on the table, filled with tea that had already gone cold.

“Ammi?”

Her mother looked up.

“Oh. You're awake.”

Ayla glanced at the cup.

“Why is that there?”

Her mother's eyes followed her.

For a moment, she seemed not to understand the question.

Then she looked away.

“I was making tea.”

“You made two cups.”

“Yes.”

Ayla waited.

Her mother picked up her own cup, took a sip, and set it down again.

“I suppose I wasn't paying attention.”

It was an ordinary explanation.

A reasonable one.

Ayla might have accepted it and moved on.

Instead, she pulled out the chair opposite her mother and sat down.

“Do you still take out his things sometimes?”

Her mother's fingers tightened around the cup.

“Sometimes.”

“Why don't you tell me?”

Her mother looked up sharply.

“What would you like me to tell you, Ayla? That I miss my son? That I still look toward the door when I hear someone coming home? That sometimes I wake up in the middle of the night and forget, for one beautiful second, that he is gone?”

Ayla flinched.

Her mother immediately looked stricken.

“I'm sorry.”

“No,” Ayla whispered. “Don't be.”

But the words had already opened something.

Her mother pressed her palms against the table.

“I don't know how to talk to you about him,” she admitted. “Every time I mention Zain, you become so quiet that I feel as though I've hurt you. So, I stop.”

Ayla stared at the cup.

“I thought you stopped because you wanted me to move on.”

“I never wanted you to forget him.”

“You always told me to eat, sleep, go outside, and meet people. You kept asking whether I was getting better.”

“Because I was frightened.”

The answer came so quickly that Ayla looked up.

Her mother swallowed her.

“I was frightened that I was losing you, too.”

The kitchen seemed to grow very still.

“I had already lost one child,” her mother continued. “And then I watched the other one disappear into a grief I could not reach. You stopped talking to your friends. You stopped going out. You stopped telling me what you were thinking.”

She wiped her eyes.

“I didn't know whether to leave you alone or hold on to you more tightly. Every choice felt wrong.”

Ayla felt her own eyes begin to burn.

“Why didn't you tell me that?”

Her mother gave a small, broken laugh.

“Because I am your mother. I thought I was supposed to know what to do.”

Ayla looked at the woman sitting across from her.

For months, she had seen only a mother who was always busy, always asking practical questions, always trying to return the household to some version of normal.

She had mistaken her mother's efforts for distance.

She had never considered that they might be fear.

“I thought you were strong,” Ayla said.

“I was trying to be.”

“Were you?”

Her mother looked at the untouched cup.

“No, beta. Not always.”

The endearment broke something open in Ayla.

She reached across the table.

Her mother took her hand.

For several seconds, neither spoke.

Then Ayla asked the question she had been carrying since the morning of Zain's funeral.

“Ammi, do you ever get angry with him?”

Her mother's face changed.

It was a question no one had asked aloud.

“Angry?” She repeatedly.

Ayla nodded, frightened now that she had begun.

“Sometimes I get angry that he left. Then I feel terrible because I know he didn't choose to die. I know that. But sometimes I just want to be angry with someone, and he is the person I miss most.”

Her voice shook.

“Does that make me a bad sister?”

Her mother stood abruptly, walked around the table, and pulled Ayla into her arms.

“Oh, my child.”

Ayla buried her face against her mother's shoulder.

“No, no,” her mother whispered. “It doesn't.”

“But I loved him.”

“I know.”

“I still love him.”

“I know, Jaan.”

Her mother's arms tightened around her.

“You can love someone and be angry that they are gone. You can miss them and be tired of missing them. You can wish things had happened differently without wishing that you had loved them less.”

Ayla began to cry.

Not the silent crying she had grown accustomed to, with her face turned toward a pillow and her breathing carefully controlled.

She cried with the helplessness of someone who had finally stopped trying to make grief look respectable.

Her mother held her.

And for once, neither of them tried to make the crying end.

That afternoon, Ayla returned to Zehra Begum's house.

She had brought the cup from the kitchen.

Her mother had insisted she would take it.

“Keep it in the study for now,” she had said. “I don't know why, but I think it belongs there.”

Ayla carried it carefully through the front door.

The house was quiet.

She placed the cup on the writing desk, beside the letters and her notebook.

Then she opened the drawer where her grandmother had kept her pens.

There were several ordinary things inside: a small ruler, a packet of paper clips, two dried-out markers, and a photograph of Zehra sitting in the garden.

On the back of the photograph was a line written in pencil.

Some conversations begin long after the people who needed them have gone.

Ayla sat down.

She had begun to understand why her grandmother had left so many letters.

Zehra had not simply wanted people to know they were remembered.

She had wanted them to speak.

To say the things, they had been carrying before; those things grew too heavy to lift.

Ayla opened her notebook and wrote:

What do I still need to say to Zain?

She stared at the question.

Then she began.

I'm sorry I didn't answer your call.

She stopped.

Her throat tightened.

She wrote another sentence.

I was angry with you, and I wanted you to know it.

She put down the pen.

The words looked terrible on the page.

They seemed disloyal, almost cruel.

She imagined Zain reading them, his familiar eyebrows drawing together as he tried to understand why she would say something like that.

Then she remembered the last argument.

It had been about something so small that she could barely recall how it began. Zain had borrowed a book from her without asking and returned it with a folded page. She had accused him of never respecting her things. He laughed, which made her angry.

“You always do this,” she told him.

“Do what?”

“Act like nothing matters.”

He stopped laughing.

“I never said nothing matters, Ayla.”

“Then why do you behave like it?”

He had looked at her for a long time.

Then his phone rang.

He had glanced at the screen, told her they would talk later, and left.

That evening, he called.

Ayla saw his name.

She remembered looking at the screen and thinking, *'Let him wait.'*

She had wanted him to feel the small sting of being ignored.

She had planned to call him back the next morning.

There had been no next morning for him.

Ayla pressed her hands against her face.

“Kaash,” she whispered.

If only.

She had spent eighteen months trying to find a punishment large enough to match the regret.

She had not realized how often she was punishing herself for being an ordinary sister in an ordinary moment: angry, impatient, convinced there would be another chance to make things right.

She picked up her pen again.

I'm sorry I thought we had more time.

The sentence blurred.

She blinked, wiped her eyes, and continued.

I'm sorry I keep remembering the last conversation as though it was the only one we ever had.

She paused.

Then, slowly, she wrote:

I remember you teaching me how to ride a bicycle.

I remember you giving me the bigger half of every chocolate and pretending you hadn't wanted it.

I remember you waiting outside my school when it rained because you knew I hated getting my shoes wet.

I remember how you used to knock on my bedroom door and leave snacks outside it when I was upset, because you knew I would tell you to go away if you came inside.

Ayla smiled through her tears.

She could see him clearly.

His crooked grin.

His untidy hair.

The way he would call her *madam* when he wanted to annoy her.

She wrote until her hand began to ache.

When she finally stopped, the page was full.

For the first time, the last conversation was not the only thing she could see.

There were other memories around it.

Small ones. Ordinary ones.

A life made of thousands of moments, not one unanswered call.

She closed the notebook.

Then she looked at the white cup on the desk.

“I'm trying, Bhai,” she whispered.

“I really am.”

The next letter was smaller than the others.

It had been folded into a neat square and tucked inside a book of poetry. On the front, Zehra had written:

For the one who never learned to apologize.

Ayla almost smiled.

She thought of Hamza, who had apologized for the way he spoke, and Sana, who had apologized for taking up space in her own home.

She wondered who this letter was for.

Inside, her grandmother had written only a few lines.

My dear child,

Some people think an apology makes them weak.

They believe that if they admit they were wrong, the world will take something from them.

They do not understand that pride can become a room with no doors.

If you have hurt someone, say so.

If you miss someone, tell them.

If you are frightened, stop pretending that you are not.

You may not be forgiven.

You may not receive the answer you hoped for.

But at least your heart will no longer have to carry the burden of words you were too afraid to speak.

And if the person you need to speak to is no longer here, do not believe that every word you have left inside you must remain there forever.

Tell someone who can listen to me.

Write it down.

Let the truth leave your body in whatever way you can.

Silence is sometimes necessary.

But it should not become the only language you know.

With love,

Zehra.

Ayla read the letter slowly.

Then she turned to a clean page in her notebook.

She began a new letter.

Not to her grandmother.

Not to Hamza or Sana.

To Zain.

She did not know whether she would ever show it to anyone.

She did not know whether writing to someone who had died was foolish.

But Nani had told her to let the words leave her body.

So, she began.

Dear Bhai,

I don't know how to write to someone who cannot answer.

I keep thinking I should be able to do this by now. It's been eighteen months. People say time helps, but no one explains what you're supposed to do while it passes.

Some days, I am almost normal.

I go outside. I laugh at something stupid. I forgot to be sad for a few minutes.

Then I remember you are not here, and I feel guilty for having forgotten.

I don't know why I keep doing that.

Maybe I'm afraid that if I stop hurting, I will lose you a second time.

I miss you.

I miss you when something funny happens and I turn to tell you.

I miss you when Ammi makes your favorite food and pretends she didn't.

I miss you when I hear someone laughing in the street and, for one ridiculous second, I think it might be you.

I miss arguing with you.

I even miss being annoyed by you.

I wish I had answered your call.

I wish I had told you that I was angry because I knew you would understand, and because I trusted that we would always have another chance to talk.

I am sorry I let one ordinary argument become the last thing between us.

But I am beginning to remember other things, too.

You were not the only person I was angry with that day.

You are my brother.

You were the boy who taught me how to ride a bicycle and then laughed when I fell into a hedge.

You were the person who knew when I was lying about being fine.

You were the one who told me that I did not have to be good at everything to be worth loving.

I wish I had listened to you.

I wish I had been kinder to myself.

I wish I could tell you all this and hear you say something annoying, like, "Finally, madam, you've understood something."

A part of me still expects you to come home.

I don't know when that part will stop.

Perhaps it never will.

But I am trying to learn that missing you does not mean I have to disappear, too.

I am trying to understand that I can love you without spending every day punishing myself.

I don't know whether I will ever forgive myself completely.

But today, for the first time, I am willing to consider the possibility.

I love you, Bhai.

I always did it.

Even when I was angry.

Even when I didn't answer.

Even now.

Your annoying little sister,

Ayla.

She put down the pen.

The room seemed strangely quiet.

Ayla looked at the letter and waited for something to happen.

A sign.

A feeling of relief.

Some sudden certainty that the words had reached wherever Zain had gone.

Nothing happened.

The sunlight continued to fall across the desk.

The clock continued to lose its minutes.

The house remained in the house.

And Zain remained gone.

Ayla felt disappointed in her chest.

Then she understood.

The letter was not going to bring him back.

It was not meant to be.

It was meant to let her speak.

She folded the pages and placed them inside her notebook.

For the first time, she did not feel the need to hide what she had written.

She simply wanted to keep it safe.

That evening, her mother found her in the garden.

Ayla was sitting beside the small green shoot, reading the letter to Zain again.

“Can I sit with you?” Her mother asked.

Ayla moved aside.

Her mother lowered herself onto the chair beside her.

For a while, they watched the light fade from the sky.

Then Ayla held out the notebook.

“I wrote to him.”

Her mother took it carefully.

“Would you like me to read it?”

Ayla hesitated.

A month ago, the thought would have terrified her.

She would have worried that her mother might misunderstand, that she might judge the anger in the letter or try to reassure her before she had finished speaking.

Now, she nodded.

“If you want to.”

Her mother read the pages slowly.

Once, she stopped and pressed her fingers against her lips.

When she finished, she held the notebook against her chest.

“Oh, Ayla.”

Ayla looked away.

“It's probably silly.”

“No.”

“I know he can't read it.”

Her mother reached for her hand.

“Perhaps writing it was not about whether he could read it.”

Ayla's eyes filled.

“I just wanted to tell him I was sorry.”

“I know.”

“And I wanted him to know I was angry. I hated admitting that. I thought it meant I didn't love him enough.”

Her mother shook her head.

“Your brother knew you loved him.”

“How can, you be sure?”

“Because he was your brother.” Her mother's voice trembled. “He knew you. He knew how you were when you were happy, how you were when you were angry, and how you were when you wanted everyone to leave you alone.”

Ayla gave a small laugh.

“He used to say I had the temperament of a very small dictator.”

Her mother laughed through her tears.

“He said you got it from me.”

“He was wrong.”

“Of course he was.”

For a moment, they smiled together.

Then her mother looked toward the house.

“There is something I need to tell you.”

Ayla waited.

“On the day Zain died, I had a missed call from him, too.”

Ayla turned sharply.

“What?”

Her mother nodded, looking down at their joined hands.

“He called me in the afternoon. I was in the kitchen, and my hands were wet. I saw his name on the screen, but I thought I would call him back when I finished.”

She swallowed.

“I never called him back.”

Ayla could not speak.

“I have carried that with me,” her mother continued. “I kept thinking that perhaps he wanted something. Perhaps he wanted to tell me something important. Perhaps he needed to hear my voice.”

She closed her eyes.

“I don't know. I will never know.”

“Ammi…”

“I didn't tell you because I thought you were already carrying enough. I didn't want you to believe you had to comfort me.”

Ayla felt tears slide down her cheeks.

“I wish you had told me.”

Her mother nodded.

“I know.”

“Not because I wanted you to feel bad. I just…” Ayla struggled for words. “I thought I was the only one who had done something wrong.”

Her mother turned toward her.

“We both have moments we wish we could change. That does not mean we caused what happened.”

Ayla looked at the garden.

The little shoot moved gently in the evening breeze.

“Do you think he was angry with us?” She whispered.

Her mother was quiet for a long time.

“I don't know what he was thinking that day,” she said honestly. “But I know your brother loved us. I know that when he left this house, he did not leave his love behind.”

Ayla pressed her lips together.

Her mother continued.

“We cannot build a whole life around the last thing we did not do. We have to remember the things we did.”

Ayla leaned against her shoulder.

For a long time, they sat together without speaking.

The silence between them was no longer filled with questions or dared to ask.

It was filled with everything they had finally said.

The following morning, Ayla returned to studying.

She slept better than she expected.

Not because she was no longer grieving, but because she had spent the previous evening sharing some of the weight.

She opened her notebook and read the letter to Zain once more.

Then she placed it in a new envelope.

On the front, she wrote his name.

Zain.

She did not put it away with Nani's letters.

Instead, she placed it in the drawer of the writing desk, where she could find it whenever she needed to.

Then she turned to the remaining envelopes.

Only a few were left.

One was addressed to a woman named Mariam. Another bore no name at all. The last had a small mark in the corner that Ayla recognized from the letters to Farah and Hamza.

She reached for it.

But before she opened it, she noticed a thin sheet of paper tucked beneath the ribbon.

It was not a letter.

It was a list.

A list of names, each followed by a short phrase.

Farah — *the years we can still save.*

Hamza — *the dream he has not been buried completely.*

Sana — *the life she is allowed to want.*

And beneath them, written in darker ink:

Ayla — the truth she must learn to carry.

Her fingers got cold.

She read the line again.

Then again.

For several seconds, she could not breathe properly.

What truth?

What did Nani know?

Was there something about Zain's death she had never been told?

Had her grandmother discovered something about the last phone call?

Ayla stared at the words until they seemed to blur.

She wanted to tear the paper in half.

She wanted to put it away and pretend she had never seen it.

She wanted, more than anything, to call her mother and demand an explanation.

But there was no explanation on the page.

Only a name.

Hers.

Ayla placed the list on the desk and reached for the final letter.

The envelope was sealed.

On the front, in Zehra Begum's familiar handwriting, were the words:

For Ayla, when she is ready to hear the truth.

Ayla sat very still.

Outside, a bird landed on the garden wall.

Somewhere in the house, a clock ticked.

She could hear her own breathing.

For months, she had wanted answers.

She had believed that knowing more about the past might help her understand the present. She had followed the letters from one person to another, learning that grief could hide behind responsibility, that loneliness could disguise itself as strength, and that love did not always disappear when a person was gone.

Now the next door stood in front of her.

And she was afraid to open it.

Because what if the truth hurts more than the questions?

What if there were things about her grandmother she did not understand?

What if there were things about Zain?

Ayla pressed her palm against the envelope.

“Nani,” she whispered, “what did you know?”

The house offered no answer.

She slipped the letter into her bag.

Not because she had decided to open it.

Not yet.

But because she had begun to understand that being afraid of the truth did not mean she had to spend the rest of her life avoiding it.

That night, Ayla sat at her bedroom window with her notebook open on her lap.

She wrote one final sentence before turning off the light.

Some words cannot change what happened.

She paused.

Then she continued.

But they can change what we carry away from it.

She closed the notebook.

For the first time, she understood that the things we never say do not always vanish.

Sometimes, they wait in old letters.

Sometimes, they live in spaces between a mother and a daughter.

Sometimes, they remain in a heart that has mistaken silence for loyalty.

And sometimes, when we finally find the courage to speak, the words do not make the pain disappear.

They simply make room for something else.

Understanding.

Forgiveness.

A little tenderness toward the person we used to be.

Ayla turned off the lamp.

In the darkness, she thought of Zain's laughter, her mother's missed call, and the letter waiting inside her bag.

There were still things she did not know.

There were still apologies she could never deliver in person.

But tomorrow, she will open the envelope.

Not because she was no longer afraid.

Because she was beginning to understand that courage was not the absence of fear.

Sometimes, it was simply the decision to stop letting fear speak for you.

And somewhere beyond the dark, a new truth was waiting.

Chapter Eight

The Letter With Her Name on It

Ayla did not sleep much that night.

The envelope lay on her bedside table, its cream-colored paper catching the thin silver light that slipped through the curtains. Her name was written across the front in Nani's familiar handwriting.

For Ayla, when she is ready to hear the truth.

Not *when she is ready to heal.*

Not *when she stopped crying.*

When she is ready to hear the truth.

Somehow, that frightened her more.

At half past six, she gave up pretending she would fall asleep. She washed her face, wrapped herself in a shawl, and carried the envelope downstairs.

The house was still quiet. In the kitchen, the kettle had not yet begun to sing. Outside, the garden was damp with morning dew, and the little green shoot she had

noticed days ago was still there, stubbornly alive in the cracked earth.

Ayla sat at the dining table.

For a long time, she only looked at the envelope.

“Bas,” she whispered to herself. “Open it.”

Her fingers trembled as she broke the seal.

Inside was a single folded letter, along with a small photograph.

The photograph was old; its edges softened by time. It showed Nani sitting on the veranda, her silver hair lost around her shoulders. Beside her sat a younger version of Ayla, perhaps ten years old, with untidy braids and a gap between her front teeth.

Ayla remembered that afternoon.

She had been crying because Zain had gone to the city with their father and had promised to bring her a particular storybook. He had returned without it. She had declared that she would never speak to him again.

By evening, he had found the book in a shop near the bus station, bought it with his pocket money, and placed it under her pillow.

The memory arrived so suddenly that Ayla almost smiled.

Then she turned the photograph over.

In Nani's handwriting, there were seven words.

You were always easier to love than you believed.

Ayla pressed the photograph against her chest.

Then she unfolded the letter.

My dearest Ayla,

If you are reading this, then you have finally reached the letter I was most afraid to write.

I have written it many times in my mind. I have imagined you reading it in anger, in tears, or with that stubborn little crease between your eyebrows that appears whenever you are trying not to feel something.

I have never been able to decide which possibility frightens me most.

So let me begin with the truth I should have told you while I was alive.

On the night before Zain died, he came to see me.

Ayla stopped reading.

The room seemed to be tilted.

She read the sentence again.

Then the third time.

Zain had visited Nani the night before the accident? Why had no one told her? Why had her mother never mentioned it?

She gripped the paper so tightly that it crumpled beneath her fingers.

Her first thought was that there must have been something important. Something Zain had said. Something Nani had known.

Something that could change in the last eighteen months.

She forced herself to continue.

He came late, after everyone else had gone to bed. He sat in the chair beside my window and told me he was worried about you.

Not because you were cruel to him. Not because you were difficult to love.

Because you had begun to believe that being strong meant never admitting when something hurts.

He said you had been carrying more than you let anyone see. He said you had become very good at laughing at the right moments and changing the subject whenever someone asked if you were all right.

He asked me how he could help you.

I told him what grandmothers have been telling their grandchildren for generations: that love cannot force open a door someone is determined to keep closed.

He laughed at me.

He said, “Nani, you make everything sound like a lesson from a book.”

I told him that was because he never listened to it the first time.

He kissed my forehead before he left.

At the door, he turned back and said, “I’ll try again tomorrow.”

Ayla lowered the letter.

The kitchen clock ticked above her head.

She could almost hear Zain's laugh, the one that always came before he said something ridiculous. She could picture him leaning against Nani's doorway, one hand in his pocket, pretending he was not worried about anything in the world.

I'll try again tomorrow.

But tomorrow had never come.

Her throat tightened.

She wanted to be angry with Nani for keeping this from her. She wanted to be angry with Zain for having worried about her when she had spent so much time convincing herself she had failed him.

Most of all, she wanted to know what Nani had been about to tell her.

She returned to the page.

There is something else.

You have spent these months believing that your last unanswered call to Zain was the most important thing that ever passed between you.

It was not.

I know about the call, Ayla. Your mother told me about the funeral. She was afraid for you, and she was afraid that if she tried to take the guilt from you, you would only hold on to it more tightly.

I wanted to speak to you myself.

I wanted to sit down, hold your hands, and tell you that a relationship is not a single moment. It is a thousand ordinary moments gathered over years. It is shared food and borrowed clothes, ridiculous arguments, secrets whispered after midnight, and the familiar sound of someone calling your name from another room.

It is all the time you answer.

All the times he answered you.

All the time neither of you needed to ask, because you already knew the other was there.

You and Zain were not defined by one missed call.

You were defined by a lifetime of answering one another in ways that had nothing to do with a telephone.

But I did not tell you this.

And now I must confess why.

For most of my life, I believed that if I loved someone enough, I could protect them from everything.

When I was twenty-three, my younger sister, Mariam, died during a sudden illness. I argued with her that morning. I was impatient. She wanted me to sit with her, and I told her I had work to do.

She died before I could return.

For years, I replayed that morning as if memory were a door I could unlock if I turned the handle the right way.

If I had stayed.

If I had been kinder.

If I had noticed how unwell she was.

If I had loved her better.

I thought that if I blamed myself enough, I could somehow make the world confess that her death had been a mistake.

But the world did not confess.

It simply kept moving.

And I grew older, carrying a punishment no one had asked me to carry.

It took me decades to understand what I am telling you now.

Guilt can make us feel responsible for the things we were powerless to control.

It gives us an illusion of power. It tells us that if we caused a terrible thing, then perhaps we could have prevented it. And if we could have prevented it, perhaps the world is still a place where love can guarantee safety.

But love cannot guarantee safety, my darling.

Love can make us careful. It can make us brave. It can teach us to apologize, to return, and to pay attention.

But it cannot make us all know.

It cannot be given to us tomorrow before tomorrow arrives.

And it cannot turn an ordinary, imperfect human being into the guardian of every person they love.

You were angry with Zain that day.

That is true.

You did not answer his call.

That is true, too.

But those truths do not mean you caused his death.

They do not mean you loved him less.

They do not erase the years when he was your brother in every way a brother could be.

Please, Ayla. Do not turn your regret into a verdict against yourself.

You are allowed to wish you had answered.

You are allowed to miss the sound of his voice so much that an ordinary afternoon feels unbearable.

You are allowed to cry when you see someone wearing his favorite color.

You are allowed to laugh at something he would have found funny.

You are allowed to have a future.

None of these things betray him.

And none of them require you to stop loving him.

Ayla paused, tears falling onto the page.

Outside, a bird called from the garden wall. Somewhere upstairs, a door creaked as her mother moved through the house.

The ordinary world continued, indifferent to the fact that Ayla's heart was breaking open around a truth she had needed for eighteen months.

She wiped her cheeks and read them on.

There is one final thing I need you to understand.

When you were little, you once asked me why Allah allows people to leave us when we still have so much to say to them.

I told you that some answers take a lifetime to understand.

You were dissatisfied with that answer. You told me it was a terrible answer and that I should try again.

You were right.

It was a terrible answer.

I do not know why some people leave before we are ready. I do not know why certain prayers seem to return to us unanswered. I do not know how to explain a world

in which good people suffer and loving families must learn to live with empty chairs.

I will not insult your pain by pretending I know.

What I do know is this:

We are not asked to understand every loss before we are allowed to continue living.

Sometimes we must live with the question.

Sometimes we must let the question sit beside us at the table while we eat, walk with us through the garden, and follow us into the quiet hours of the night.

And sometimes, after a long time, the question becomes less sharp.

Not because we have found an answer.

Because we have learned how to carry it.

I wish I could sit beside you now. I wish I could touch your cheek and tell you that the worst thing that happened to you is not the only thing that will ever happen to you.

But I cannot promise you an easy life, Ayla.

I can only ask you not to abandon the life you still have.

There are people you have not met yet who will need the kindness you are learning through this pain. There are mornings that will surprise you by being beautiful. There are books you have not read, meals you have not shared, and moments of laughter you cannot imagine yet.

You do not have to chase them.

You do not have to force yourself to be hopeful.

Just do not close the door before they arrive.

And if you forget everything else I have written, remember this:

You do not owe the dead for the rest of your life.

You owe them the truth of what they meant to you.

You owe them remembrance, if remembrance is what your heart needs.

You may owe yourself an apology for the ways you have been unkind to your own heart.

But you do not owe anyone you're suffering as proof of love.

Zain was loved.

He knew he was loved.

And you, my dear girl, were loved by him in all the ordinary, imperfect, beautiful ways that matter.

Please begin to believe that you can be loved by living, too.

I am sorry I could not tell you this while I was there to hold you.

I hope, somehow, these words will sit beside you until you are ready to stand again.

And when that day comes, do not think you have left me behind.

Ayla, meri Jaan, light does not ask the darkness for permission to enter.

It comes through the smallest opening.

Let there be an opening.

With all the love I had, all the love I have, and all the love I never learned how to say properly,

Your Nani,

Zehra

Ayla reached the end and could not move.

The letter lay open on the table.

For eighteen months, she had treated her regret as if it were a sacred object. She had guarded it. Fed it. Returned to it every night, convinced that setting it down would mean she had forgotten the person who had given her so much to remember.

She had made a home for her guilt because she did not know where else to put her love.

And now Nani was telling her that the two were not the same.

A sob rose from somewhere deep in her chest.

It was not quiet or graceful. It frightened her with its force. She bent forward, covering her face, and cried for the phone call she could never answer, for the brother who would never come through the door, for the grandmother whose hands she would never hold again.

She cried because Zain was worried about her.

Because he had planned to try again.

Because Nani had carried her own guilt for decades and still found enough tenderness to leave Ayla a way out.

And because, beneath all the grief, a small and unfamiliar thought had begun to form.

What if I am allowed to live?

Not today, perhaps.

Not without pain.

But someday.

A chair scraped behind her.

“Ayla?”

Her mother stood at the kitchen entrance, changing the moment she saw the letter and tears on her daughter's face.

“Oh, beta.”

She crossed the room and sat beside her.

Ayla turned the letter toward her.

“Nani knew,” she whispered. “She knew I was blaming myself.”

Her mother nodded slowly. “She knew you were hurting. I think she understood more than either of us realized.”

“She never told me about Mariam Khala.”

“She probably thought she would have more time to explain.”

Ayla looked down at the photograph.

“Zain went to see her the night before he died.”

Her mother's face softened with grief. “Yes. He did.”

“You knew?”

“I knew he had visited her. I didn't know what they talked about until much later.” She paused. “Your Nani told me he was worried about you. She said he wanted to find a way to reach you without making you feel cornered.”

Ayla pressed her lips together.

“He was always doing that.”

“Doing what?”

“Trying again.” Her voice cracked. “Even when I was difficult.”

Her mother reached for her hand. “Especially then.”

Ayla let out a broken little laugh that turned into another sob.

“I keep thinking about that last call.”

“I know.”

“What if I'd answered?”

Her mother did not rush to silence her. She did not tell her not to think about it or insist that everything happened for a reason.

Instead, she held Ayla's hand between both of hers.

“Then you might have spoken for a few minutes,” she said gently. “You might have argued again. You might have made up. We cannot know, Jaan. And I wish with everything in me that we had more time with him.”

She took a breath.

“But we cannot turn an unanswered call into the whole story of his life.”

Ayla looked at her mother.

For a moment, she saw not the woman who had always seemed to carry her grief so quietly, but another person who had been trying to survive the same absence.

“Ammi,” she whispered, “I don't know how to stop feeling guilty.”

“Then don't try to stop all at once.”

Her mother brushed a strand of hair away from Ayla's face.

“Just don't punish yourself every time you miss him. Missing him is already hard enough.”

Ayla leaned into her mother's shoulder.

They stayed that way until the tea in the kettle had gone cold, and the morning sun had crept across the kitchen floor.

Eventually, her mother rose to make another pot.

Ayla folded Nani's letter carefully, smoothing the creases with her fingertips. She placed it back in its envelope beside the photograph.

Then she took out her notebook.

For a long time, she stared at the blank page.

She did not know how to forgive herself. She did not suddenly feel lighter. The absence of Zain remained

exactly where it had always been, a room inside her that no letter could fill.

But for the first time, she wondered whether she could enter that room without locking herself inside it.

She wrote one sentence.

I can regret the call I missed without making it the reason I deserve to suffer.

She read it once.

Then again.

It did not feel entirely true yet.

But it felt possible that, one day, it might have been.

Outside, the little green shoot trembled in the morning breeze.

Ayla watched it through the window.

“Nani,” she whispered, her voice still raw, “I don't know if I can do this.”

The house offered no answer.

She took a breath.

“Lekin main koshish karungi.”

But I will try.

And for that morning, trying was enough.

Chapter Nine

The Truth Beneath the Dust

The next morning, Ayla returned to Nani's study.

Not because she expected another letter to change her life.

She had begun to understand that life did not change in a single moment, no matter how beautifully someone arranged the words. Sometimes a truth entered quietly and sat beside you for days before you understood what it had come to do.

She returned because Nani's letter had left her with a question.

How many things had the woman kept hidden behind her kindness?

The study smelled of old paper, rosewater, and the faint trace of sandalwood that had lingered in the curtains long after Nani's funeral. Sunlight fell across the desk in narrow golden stripes. Dust floated through it, unhurried and almost beautiful.

Ayla stood in the doorway.

For months, she had thought of this room as a place where her grandmother had left pieces of herself behind.

Now she wondered whether she had ever truly known how much of herself Nani had spent trying to save other people.

She crossed the desk and opened the bottom drawer.

Inside lay the list she had found two nights earlier.

Farah — the years we can still save.

Hamza — the dream he has not been buried completely.

Sana — the life she is allowed to want.

Ayla — the truth she must learn to carry.

Beneath it, she discovered a smaller notebook; its brown cover softened the corners. A strip of faded blue ribbon held the pages together.

She untied it.

The first few pages contained grocery lists, reminders about medicines, and notes about the garden. Then, halfway through, Nani’s handwriting changed. The letters grew smaller; the lines more crowded, as if the thoughts had been too urgent to wait for neatness.

Ayla began to read.

March 14.

Farah came today. She sat in the garden for forty minutes before telling me why she had stayed away for so long. I had thought she had left because she stopped loving me.

I was wrong.

Sometimes people leave because they do not know how to stay without being hurt.

Ayla turned the page.

June 2.

Hamza says he has forgotten how to draw. I told him that forgetting is not always the same as losing. Sometimes a thing remains inside us, waiting for us to stop being afraid of what it might ask.

Another page.

Sana cried today. She apologized for crying, which made me want to cry as well. How strange that we teach women to apologize for the very things that prove they are still alive.

Ayla smiled faintly.

She could almost hear Nani saying it aloud, her voice full of disapproval at the world's foolishness.

Then she reached an entry dated nearly two years earlier.

The date made her hand still.

It was written a few months before Zain’s accident.

November 19.

I spoke to Ayla today.

She was sitting on the floor of my room, pretending to read. She thinks I do not notice when she is unhappy. She has always believed that hiding a wound makes it easier for the people who love her.

I asked her what she was afraid of.

She said she was afraid of becoming someone who needed too much from others.

My poor child.

Ayla swallowed me.

She remembered that afternoon. Nani had been sorting through a basket of unfinished embroidery. Ayla had

gone to her room after a difficult week at university, irritated with everyone and ashamed of how little she seemed able to manage.

She had forgotten the conversation.

Or perhaps she had buried it beneath everything that came afterward.

She kept reading.

I told her that needing people is not a weakness. It is how we are made.

She laughed and said I was old-fashioned.

Perhaps I am.

But I have lived long enough to know that loneliness is not a proof of strength.

Ayla rested her fingertips against the page.

She had spent so much time believing that Nani had understood her pain only after Zain died.

But Nani had seen her before the accident. She had seen the cracks Ayla had hidden beneath her ordinary days.

The notebook continued.

I wanted to tell her about Mariam today. I wanted her to understand that I had once mistaken guilt for love, too.

But the words would not come.

I told myself there would be another afternoon.

Ayla shut her eyes.

Another afternoon.

The phrase hurts in a different way now.

She had spent eighteen months trapped in the last conversation she had failed to have with Zain. Nani had spent decades carrying out the conversations she had postponed with the people she loved.

And even with all her wisdom, even with all her letters and careful words, Nani was still human.

She was still afraid.

Ayla turned to another page.

This entry was dated six weeks after Zain's death.

I went to see Ayla today.

She opened the door, saw me, and began to cry before I could speak.

She said she was sorry.

She did not tell me what she was sorry for, and I did not ask.

I held her while she cried.

I should have told her then. I should have told her about the call, about Mariam, about the many years I spent believing that sorrow was a debt I had to repay.

Instead, I told her to eat something.

She obeyed because she was tired.

I watched her leave the room and understood that love can be full of good intentions and still be afraid of the truth.

Ayla pressed the notebook against her chest.

She remembered that visit.

Nani had brought her lentil soup in a metal container and sat beside her bed. Ayla had cried into her grandmother’s shoulder and apologized for something she could not explain.

Nani had stroked her hair and said, “Bas, beta. You don't have to talk.”

At the time, Ayla had thought those words meant she could remain silent forever.

Now she wondered if Nani had been waiting for her to find her own way back to the conversation.

A sound came from the hallway.

“Ayla?”

Her mother stood at the open door, holding two cups of tea.

“I thought I might find you here.”

Ayla wiped her cheeks with the heel of her hand.

“Ammi, did Nani ever tell you about her sister?”

Her mother placed the cups on the desk.

“A little. Not everything.”

“Why didn't she tell me?”

Her mother was quiet for a moment.

“Perhaps because she knew what grief had done to her. Perhaps she was afraid that telling you her story would make your pain feel smaller, when she wanted you to know it mattered.”

Ayla looked down at the notebook.

“She wrote that she should have told me things.”

“Yes,” her mother said softly. “Your Nani had her regrets, too.”

It was strange how difficult that was to accept.

Ayla had imagined Nani as someone who had emerged from suffering with all the answers. Someone knew how to survive because she had already learned every lesson there was to learn.

But perhaps wisdom was not the absence of mistakes.

Perhaps it was willing to look at them honestly, even when they could no longer be undone.

Ayla turned the notebook toward her mother.

“Look at this.”

Her mother read the entry in silence.

When she finished, she touched the page gently.

“She loved you so much.”

“I know.”

But the words came out as a question.

Her mother sat beside her.

“Do you remember how she used to call every Sunday, even when you were busy?”

Ayla nodded.

“And how you would tell her you were studying, and she would ask whether you had eaten?”

Ayla laughed through her tears. “She never believed me when I said yes.”

“Because you were usually lying.”

“Sometimes.”

“Most of the time.”

For a moment, they smiled at each other.

Then her mother continued.

“She didn't need you to be perfect, Ayla. She never did it. She just wanted you to know that you could come to her when you weren't.”

Ayla looked at the open notebook.

“I wish I'd understood that earlier.”

“So do I,” her mother replied.

There was no accusation in her voice. Only the familiar ache of wishing time had been kinder.

Ayla traced the edge of the page.

“Do you think we spend too much time waiting to become better before we let people love us?”

Her mother looked at her thoughtfully.

“I think we spend too much time believing that love is something we earn by being easy to love.”

The words settled between them.

Ayla thought of Zain, who had argued with her over the smallest things and still brought her the storybook she wanted. Of Nani, who had watched her pretend to be fine and offered soup instead of questions. Of her mother, who had carried her own sorrow while trying to make room for Ayla’s.

None of them were perfect.

None of them needed to be.

And still, they loved her.

For the first time, Ayla wondered why she had demanded a kind of perfection from herself that she had never demanded from anyone else.

She closed the notebook carefully.

“What will you do with all of this?” Her mother asked.

Ayla looked around the study.

The shelves were crowded with books. The desk was marked with years of use. A small vase stood empty beside the window. On the far wall, a framed photograph showed Nani in the garden, laughing at something outside the frame.

“I don't know yet.”

“You don't have to decide today.”

Ayla nodded.

Her mother picked up one of the cups and handed it to her.

“Chai?”

Ayla accepted it.

“Always.”

They drank in silence, watching the dust drift through the sunlight.

After a while, her mother returned to the kitchen, leaving Ayla alone with the notebook.

Ayla opened it once more and turned to the final written page.

There was a paragraph she had not noticed before, tucked near the bottom.

If Ayla ever reads these pages, I hope she understands that I was not collecting broken people.

I was collecting reminders.

Reminders that people can be hurt and still be kind. That they can make mistakes and still be worthy of love. That they can lose something precious and still find reasons to wake up in the morning.

I did not save anyone.

They saved themselves, in small ways, when they were ready.

I only tried to leave the door open.

Ayla read the paragraph twice.

Then she turned to the inside back cover.

A small envelope had been tucked into the paper lining.

Her hands trembled as she eased it freely.

It was not addressed to anyone. There was no ribbon around it, no careful label, no instruction telling her when she should open it.

Inside was a single sheet of paper.

At the top, Nani had written:

What I wish I had understood sooner.

Below are five short lines.

You cannot love someone into never hurting.

You cannot protect someone from every consequence.

You cannot go back and become the person you wish you had been.

But you can choose what kind of person you become next to.

And you can begin before you feel ready.

Ayla sat very still.

The words did not promise that everything would be all right.

They did not explain why Zain had died, or why Nani had left her before Ayla was ready, or why so many ordinary days had turned into memories she would spend the rest of her life trying to hold.

They offered something smaller.

Something more difficult.

A choice.

Ayla looked toward the garden.

The little green shoot had grown since she first noticed it. Its stem was thin, its leaves still delicate, but it had pushed through a narrow crack in the earth and turned toward the light.

She stood and walked outside.

The air smelled of wet soil and old leaves. Somewhere beyond the wall, a child was laughing. A motorbike passed on the street. The world was full of sounds that had continued while Ayla had been trying to decide whether she was allowed to belong to it.

She knelt beside the shoot.

“I don't know how to do this,” she whispered.

She thought of Hamza, sitting with a blank page after eleven years of silence.

She thought of Sana, unfolding her old sketches and allowing herself to want something again.

She thought of Farah, who had discovered that love could survive years of misunderstanding.

And she thought of Nani, who had spent her life opening doors she could not walk through for other people.

Perhaps that was what the letters had been all along.

No answers.

Openings.

Ayla returned to the study and pulled a fresh sheet of paper from the drawer.

She wrote three names.

Farah. Hamza. Sana.

Underneath, she added a fourth.

Me.

She stared at the list.

Then she wrote a sentence beside each name.

Ask Farah what she still wishes she had said.

Ask Hamza what he wants to draw first.

Ask Sana how the studio is coming along.

Besides her own name, she hesitated.

For a long time, she could not think of anything.

Finally, she wrote:

Learn to remember Zain without putting yourself on trial.

She placed the page beside Nani's notebook.

It was not forgiveness.

Not yet.

It was not even the beginning of happiness.

But it was the first time Ayla had written something about her future without immediately feeling that she was betraying her past.

She looked once more at the photograph on the wall.

“Nani,” she said quietly, “I think I understand a little.”

The room remained silent.

Ayla smiled sadly.

“Not everything. Bas, a little.”

She gathered the notebook, the letter, and the photograph. Before leaving, she opened the curtains fully and let the sunlight fall across the desk.

For eighteen months, she had kept the curtains closed because the room reminded her of everything she had lost.

Today, she let the light in.

It did not bring Zain back.

It did not make her grief disappear.

It simply illuminated the things that had been there all along: the books, the letters, the dust, the unfinished work of a woman who had loved imperfectly and tried, in the end, to leave something useful behind.

Ayla turned off the study lamp and stepped into the hallway.

She was not ready to call herself healed.

She was not sure she ever would.

But she was beginning to understand that healing might not be a destination she reached one day, after all the tears had been shed and all the questions answered.

Perhaps it was the decision to open a curtain.

To answer a message.

To make tea for her mother, please.

To remember her brother and still allow herself to smile.

Perhaps it was simply the quiet, stubborn act of staying.

And for the first time in a long while, the future did not feel like an empty room waiting to swallow her.

It felt like a door.

One she might, someday, be brave enough to open.

Chapter Ten

When the Past Knocks

The message arrived on Thursday afternoon.

Ayla was sitting beside the window in Nani’s study, sorting the old letters into neat piles, when her phone vibrated against the desk.

For a moment, she ignored it.

Then it vibrated again.

She picked it up.

Hamza:

Are you free this evening? There is something I think you should know.

Ayla read the message twice.

She had visited Hamza three days earlier, carrying the letter Nani had written for him. He had seemed quieter than usual that day, although she had assumed it was because he had finally begun sketching again after eleven years. He had shown her a page filled with rough

pencil outlines: a row of old houses, a narrow street, a tree growing through a broken wall.

He had called it practice.

Ayla called it beautiful.

He had looked away as though the compliment had hurt.

Now she typed a reply.

Is everything all right?

The answer came almost immediately.

I don't know.

She stared at the screen.

There were some words that asked for advice. Others asked for comfort.

And then there were words like these, which simply told the truth.

I'll come; she wrote.

After a moment, she added, *"You don't have to explain everything at once."*

Hamza replied with a single word.

Thank you.

Ayla put her phone down.

Outside, the afternoon light was beginning to fade. She gathered her coat, told her mother where she was going, and stepped into the cool evening air.

For the first time in months, she was going somewhere without knowing whether she would be able to help.

Strangely, she did not feel the same panic she once would have felt.

Perhaps Nani was right.

Perhaps love did not always require an answer.

Sometimes it only requires showing up.

Hamza lived above a small stationery shop on a quiet street.

When Ayla arrived, the shopkeeper was pulling down the shutters. He recognized her and nodded toward the narrow staircase beside the counter.

“Upar hain,” he said. “He came back early today.”

Upstairs, Hamza's apartment was dim except for a lamp near the sofa. Papers covered the coffee table. A sketchbook lay open on the floor; its pages scattered with drawings.

Ayla stopped at the doorway.

Hamza stood near the window, still wearing his work shirt; his sleeves rolled to his elbows. He looked as though he had been trying to decide whether to sit down or leave the room entirely.

"You came," he said.

"You asked."

He gave a faint, humorless smile. "Most people ask questions first."

"Do you want me to?"

He considered that.

"Not yet."

"All right."

Ayla took off her coat and sat on the couch. She did not ask about the papers. She did not ask why he looked as though he had not slept.

For several minutes, neither of them spoke.

Then Hamza walked to the coffee table and picked up a photograph.

“I found this in a box at my mother's house,” he said.

He handed it to her.

The photograph showed a younger Hamza standing outside a large building with tall windows. He wore a dark suit and held a rolled-up sheet of paper under one arm. His hair was longer; his face was thinner. But his expression was unmistakable.

He looked hopeful.

Ayla glanced at the back.

There was a date and a handwritten note.

Hamza's first architecture exhibition. He pretended not to be excited. He was excited.

She smiled despite herself.

“Your mother wrote this?”

“She writes notes on everything. Containers, photographs, and medicine boxes. Once she labeled a jar of sugar because she thought I might mistake it for salt.”

“Did you?”

“No.”

“Then she was preparing for the future.”

A small laugh escaped from him.

It disappeared quickly, but Ayla noticed.

She returned the photograph.

“What happened that day?”

Hamza sat opposite her.

“I was twenty-six. I had been offered a place in a design program abroad. It was the kind of opportunity people spend years trying to get.”

“What did you do?”

“I turned it down.”

“Why?”

“My father had become ill. My younger brother was still studying. My mother couldn't manage everything alone.” He rubbed his palms together. “I told myself it was temporary. A year, perhaps two. I would work, help at

home, and save some money. Then I would apply again."

"And did you?"

"No."

He looked at the photograph in his hands.

"After my father died, there were bills. Then my brother needed help finding work. My mother was afraid of being alone. There was always something that needed to be done."

Ayla listened.

"I don't regret helping my family," he continued. "I want you to understand that. I loved my father. I love my mother. I would make many of the same choices again."

"Then what hurts?"

Hamza was quiet for a long time.

"The person I became while making them."

Ayla felt the words settle somewhere inside her.

Hamza looked around his apartment, at the neat furniture and carefully arranged books.

“I became reliable. Everyone knew they could call me. If something broke, I fixed it. If someone needed money, I would find it. If there was a problem, I was the person who stayed calm.”

“Those aren't bad things.”

“No. They aren't.” He swallowed. “But somewhere along the way, people stopped asking what I wanted. And I stopped telling them.”

He set the photograph down.

“Eventually, I couldn't even look at a building without remembering what I had given up. So, I stopped drawing. I stopped talking about architecture. I told everyone I had grown out of it.”

“Had you?”

His eyes lifted hers.

“No.”

The answer was immediate.

Honest.

Almost angry.

“No,” he repeated. “I hadn't.”

Ayla glanced at the sketchbook on the floor.

“What happened today?”

Hamza looked out the window.

“My mother called.”

He rubbed a hand over his face.

“She told me my brother, and his wife are thinking of moving to another city. He has a job offer. A good one.”

“That sounds like good news.”

“It is.”

“Then why do you look frightened?”

“Because she asked me what we would do without them nearby.”

Ayla waited.

“She said I was the only person she could depend on. She didn't mean to hurt me. She was scared, and I understood that.” He paused. “But I heard myself say, ‘Don't worry, Ammi. I'll manage.’”

His voice became quieter.

“Those words have been my entire life.”

Ayla remembered Nani’s letter.

Sometimes a thing remains inside us, waiting for us to stop being afraid of what it might ask.

“What did you want to say?” She asked.

Hamza looked down.

“I wanted to say that I am tired.”

The confession seemed to surprise him.

He blinked, then laughed once, bitterly.

“God, that sounds selfish.”

“No,” Ayla said.

“You don't know what it's like.”

“You're right. I don't know exactly what it's like for you.” She leaned forward slightly. “But I know what it feels like to be afraid that if you stop carrying everything, something terrible will happen.”

Hamza looked at her.

Ayla thought of the unanswered call. The months she had spent believing that if she suffered enough, she could somehow make the past less final.

“I thought if I kept blaming myself for Zain's death, I was keeping him close,” she said. “As though putting down the guilt would mean putting him down, too.”

“And now?”

“Now I know that I was hurting myself in his name.” She glanced at the photograph on the table. “I still feel guilty sometimes. I don't think one letter can undo eighteen months. But I'm trying to understand that loving someone and punishing yourself aren't the same thing.”

Hamza studied her face.

“Your grandmother was very good at finding the right words.”

“She was also very good at keeping them to herself until it was almost too late.”

A quiet smile passed between them.

Then Hamza picked up the sketchbook.

“I drew this today.”

He opened it to a page showing a small house with an open courtyard. Sunlight fell across the floor through a pattern of wooden screens. There were plants along the walls and a narrow bench beside a window.

The drawing was unfinished, but the space felt alive.

Ayla leaned closer.

“It's lovely.”

“It's only an exercise.”

“Maybe.”

He gave her a warning look.

She raised her hands. “All right. It's a very ordinary exercise.”

“Thank you.”

“But it is lovely.”

Hamza shook his head, although the corner of his mouth lifted.

For the first time since she had arrived, he seemed less like a man waiting for something bad to happen.

He turned several pages.

“I started thinking about what I would design if I could begin again. Not a huge building or some famous project. Something small.”

“Like what?”

“A place where people could sit without feeling they have to explain themselves.” He hesitated. “A reading room, perhaps. A little courtyard. A place with light.”

Ayla thought of Nani’s house.

The study with its crowded shelves. The garden with its stubborn green shoot. The letters that had reached people who were quietly disappearing inside their own lives.

She did not speak immediately.

Hamza noticed.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“That isn't a convincing nothing.”

She smiled.

“I was thinking about Nani's house.”

“What about it?”

“It's full of books and empty rooms. The garden needs work. And there are still so many things she left behind.” Ayla glanced toward the window, although the house was miles away. “I've been wondering what to do with it.”

Hamza leaned back.

“And?”

“I don't know yet.”

“That's allowed, you know.”

She laughed softly. “I'm learning.”

He looked at his drawing again.

“Perhaps you should leave it alone for a while. Not every empty room needs to become something immediately.”

Ayla nodded.

She had been thinking of the house as a responsibility, a collection of memories she had to organize into something meaningful before she could move forward.

But perhaps she could let it be a house for now.

Perhaps she could sit in it without demanding that every corner explain why Nani had left.

Hamza closed the sketchbook.

“I have to tell you something else.”

Ayla waited.

“I called the design institute this afternoon.”

She stared at him.

“The one abroad?”

“No. A local program. Evening classes. It's not the same opportunity I had before.”

“But you called.”

“I asked whether someone my age could still apply.”

“And?”

“They said yes.”

Ayla felt a smile spread across her face.

“Hamza.”

“Don't.”

“I haven't said anything.”

“You're about to.”

“I was going to say congratulations.”

He looked away, visibly uncomfortable.

“They haven't accepted me. I haven't even applied.”

“Then congratulations on calling.”

He let out a long breath.

“It was terrifying.”

“I imagine.”

“I kept thinking that someone would laugh. That they would ask why I had waited so long.”

“What did they say?”

“They asked me to send my portfolio.”

Ayla glanced at the sketchbook.

“Then perhaps this is your portfolio beginning.”

Hamza looked down at the drawings.

For a moment, hope appeared on his face so plainly that Ayla almost looked away. It was the sort of expression people tried to hide when they had been disappointed too many times.

“I don't know if I'm good enough anymore,” he said.

“You don't have to decide that tonight.”

He was quiet.

“You only have to decide whether you want to try.”

Hamza turned the photograph of his younger self over in his hands.

“I do.”

The words were barely audible.

But they were there.

When Ayla left, the night had deepened.

Hamza walked her to the staircase and stood by the door while she put on her coat.

“Thank you for coming,” he said.

“You don't have to thank me.”

“I know.” He hesitated. “But I want to.”

She smiled.

“Then you're welcome.”

He looked as though he wanted to say something else, but instead he stepped back and let her go.

Halfway down the stairs, Ayla heard him call her name.

She turned.

“I might need help putting the portfolio together,” he said.

“You can ask.”

“I might ask.”

“I'll be here.”

He nodded, then closed the door.

Outside, the street was lined up with small shops and shuttered stalls. A vendor was packing his fruit. Two children ran past Ayla, arguing over a cricket ball. Somewhere, a radio player played an old song her mother used to sing while cooking.

Ayla walked slowly.

She had come expecting to help Hamza.

Instead, he had reminded her of something she was only beginning to understand that life did not have to be ruined to be changed. It did not have to be perfect to begin again.

And sometimes the past did not return to punishing us.

Sometimes it knocked because there was something inside it; we had left unfinished.

At home, Ayla found her mother in the sitting room, folding laundry.

“How was Hamza?” She asked.

“He's applying to a design program.”

Her mother looked up.

“Really?”

“Yes.”

“That's wonderful.”

“He's frightened.”

“Of course he is.”

Ayla sat beside her and began folding a shirt.

“Ammi, do you ever wonder what your life would have been like if things had happened differently?”

Her mother's hands stilled.

“Sometimes.”

“What do you do when you think about it?”

She considered the question.

“I let myself wonder for a while. Then I try to return to the life I have.”

“Is it that simple?”

“No.” Her mother gave her a tired smile. “It is that difficult.”

Ayla looked at the shirt in her hands.

“I think I've spent a lot of time living in the life that might have been.”

Her mother reached over and smoothed the shoulder of Ayla's shirt.

“We all visit that life sometimes, beta. The danger is when we begin believing it is the only life that matters.”

Ayla thought of Nani’s letter.

You do not owe the dead for the rest of your life.

“I don't want to forget Zain,” she said.

Her mother’s expression softened.

“You won't.”

“What if I stop thinking about him every day?”

“Then some days you will think about him without realizing you have gone hours without doing so. And perhaps that will hurt at first.”

Ayla nodded.

“And later?”

“Later, perhaps you'll be grateful that you can carry him without having to stop everything else.”

Her mother returned to the laundry.

Ayla sat quietly beside her.

After a while, she told her about Hamza’s drawings, the little courtyard he wanted to design, and the possibility of a reading room.

Her mother listened with interest.

When Ayla finished, she said, “That sounds like something your Nani would have loved.”

The words brought a familiar ache.

But this time, the ache was not close to Ayla's throat. It came and went, like a wave moving through a place it had visited many times before.

“I think she would have,” Ayla said.

Later that night, she went to her room and opened her notebook.

She wrote about Hamza’s call to the institute. About the way he had looked when he admitted he was tired. About the drawing of the courtyard and the light falling across its floor.

Then she wrote something about herself.

Today, I watched someone begin again, and I did not feel jealous of his hope.

She paused.

For months, other people's happiness had frightened her. It had seemed to expose something she had lost, something she might never have again.

But Hamza's hope had not diminished her grief.

His future had not taken anything from Zain.

His first small step had simply reminded her that a person could carry sorrow and still reach toward something.

She added another sentence.

Maybe there is room for more than one feeling in the heart.

She closed the notebook.

Before going to bed, she checked her phone.

There was a message from Hamza.

A photograph of his unfinished drawing.

Below it, he had written:

I think I'll call the institute again tomorrow and ask about the deadline.

Ayla smiled and replied:

Good. One thing at a time.

She set the phone aside.

For a moment, she thought about calling Zain.

The old instinct arrived so suddenly that she almost reached for his name, still saved in her contacts. Then she remembered that there would be no answer, and the familiar grief rose in her chest.

She let it stay.

She did not scold herself for missing him. She did not tell herself to be strong.

Instead, she opened her notebook once more and wrote a sentence she wished she could have told him.

I saw someone try again today. I think you would have liked him.

She placed the notebook on her bedside table.

Outside, the streetlights glowed against the dark. Somewhere in the neighborhood, a gate closed, a dog barked, and a family laughed behind a lit window.

Ordinary life.

Still happening.

Still waiting.

Ayla lay down and pulled the blanket over her shoulders.

Tomorrow, she will visit Sana. She would ask about the sketches, the sewing machine, and the dream that had once seemed too impractical to name aloud.

Tomorrow, she will try to answer the people who are still here.

Tonight, she allowed herself to miss the person who was not.

And somewhere beneath the familiar ache, another feeling began to grow.

Not happiness.

Not yet.

Something quieter.

The possibility that her heart had not reached the end of what it could hold.

Chapter Eleven

A Small, Brave Beginning

The sewing machine was making a terrible noise.

Ayla stood outside Sana’s front door, listening to the uneven clatter coming from inside.

For a moment, she wondered whether she should knock or call someone to investigate.

Then she heard Sana say, “Oh, come on. Please don't do this to me.”

Ayla smiled and knocked.

“Who is it?” Sana called.

“Someone who is beginning to worry about the safety of your sewing machine.”

There was a pause.

Then Sana laughed.

“Come in! Before this machine decides to end my career before it begins.”

Ayla stepped inside.

The living room looked different from her last visit. A pile of fabric lay across the sofa, colorful threads spilled from a small basket, and several sheets of paper covered by the dining table. A measuring tape hung around Sana’s neck like a necklace she had forgotten to remove.

In the middle of the room sat a sewing machine that sounded as though it had personally offended someone.

Sana switched it off.

“Don't judge me.”

“I haven't said anything.”

“You have a judgmental face.”

“I learned from Nani.”

Sana laughed again, then looked at the table.

“I suppose I should explain.”

Ayla removed her coat and sat down.

“Only if you want to.”

Sana's expression softened.

It was a small thing, the way Ayla had said it. No demand. There was no expectation that the story had to be interesting or complete.

Sana glanced at the papers.

“I made something.”

She lifted the garment from the back of the chair.

It was a deep blue kurta with delicate embroidery along the sleeves. The stitching was not perfect even, and one side of the hem sat slightly higher than the other, but the fabric fell beautifully. The design was simple, elegant, and unmistakably hers.

Ayla touched the embroidered sleeve.

“Sana, this is beautiful.”

“It's crooked.”

“A little.”

“Thank you for your honesty.”

“But it's beautiful.”

Sana examined the garment as if she were seeing it from a distance for the first time.

“I made it for myself,” she admitted.

The words came out almost apologetically.

Ayla looked up.

“For yourself?”

“Yes.” Sana smoothed the fabric. “Not for Hiba. Not for my husband. Not for a wedding or family gathering. I wanted something that looked exactly the way I imagined it.”

“And does it?”

Sana smiled.

“Almost.”

Ayla thought of Hamza’s drawing, the unfinished courtyard, and the light falling across its floor.

“Almost is a good place to start.”

Sana looked at her for a moment.

“You sound like your grandmother.”

“I think that might be the nicest thing anyone has said to me recently.”

They both laughed.

Then Sana folded the kurta carefully and placed it on the table.

“I've been thinking about what you told me last time,” she said. “About how your grandmother's letters were helping people.”

Ayla waited.

“I wondered whether I could do something with this.”

She gestured toward the fabrics and sketches.

“Not a big business. Not yet. Perhaps a few pieces. Custom designs for people who want something different. I could start with friends, then see where it goes.”

“Have you told your family?”

“My husband knows. He's supportive.” She hesitated. “My mother-in-law thinks I should be careful not to take on too much.”

“That sounds reasonable.”

“It is reasonable.” Sana sighed. “Which is terribly inconvenient when I want someone to tell me I can do everything.”

Ayla smiled.

“Perhaps you can do something without doing everything.”

Sana leaned against the table.

“Your Nani would have said that.”

“She probably did.”

For a moment, neither woman spoke.

Then Sana reached for a sketchbook and opened it to a page filled with designs. Some were elaborate, with flowing sleeves and intricate patterns. Others were simple, built around unusual necklines or delicate embroidery.

“I used to draw these when I was younger,” she said. “Before marriage. Before Hiba. Before I became so good at putting things away that I forgot where I had put them.”

She ran her finger along the page.

“I used to think that if I ever returned to this, I would have to do it properly. A studio. My name. A whole collection.”

“And now?”

“Now I think I might just make three more kurtas.”

Ayla nodded solemnly.

“A very ambitious business plan.”

“Extremely.”

“Will there be tea?”

“Tea is essential to the business model.”

Ayla laughed, and Sana’s face brightened.

From the hallway came the sound of small feet.

“Ammi?”

Hiba appeared at the doorway, holding a picture book against her chest. Her hair was tied in two uneven ponytails, and a pink clip hung precariously from one side.

She stopped when she saw Ayla.

“Khala Ayla!”

Ayla held out her arms, and Hiba ran toward her.

“You came!”

“I did.”

“Ammi says you're helping her.”

Ayla glanced at Sana.

“Am I?”

Sana folded her arms. “Apparently.”

Hiba climbed onto the chair beside them and studied the blue kurta.

“Did you make that?”

“Ammi did,” Ayla told her.

Hiba's eyes widened.

“For real?”

“For real,” Sana said.

“Can you make me something?”

Sana smiled. “What would you like?”

“A princess dress.”

“Of course you would.”

“With pockets.”

Ayla burst out laughing.

Sana looked at her daughter with exaggerated seriousness.

“Pockets?”

“For my stones.”

“What stones?”

“The important ones.”

“Ah,” Sana said. “I understand. We cannot have a princess without somewhere to keep her important stones.”

Hiba nodded, satisfied.

Then she climbed down and ran away, already calling for her colored pencils.

Sana watched her go.

“I used to think having a dream meant choosing between the person I was and the person I needed to be for my family.”

Ayla looked at the unfinished designs.

“Maybe it means finding a way for both to exist.”

Sana was quiet.

Then she said, “I'm going to try.”

Ayla smiled.

“Good.”

“Don't look so pleased. I haven't done anything yet.”

“You made a kurta.”

“One kurta.”

“You made one kurta.”

“And now I need to fix the sewing machine.”

“Every great beginning has its challenges.”

“Please stop sounding wise. It's unsettling.”

Ayla laughed.

For a little while, they worked together. Sana showed her how to sort the threads by color, and Ayla attempted to follow a pattern that looked simply until she realized she had been holding it upside down.

They drank tea. Hiba returned to announce that she had drawn a princess with twelve pockets. Sana promised to inspect the design later.

Nothing extraordinary happened.

And yet, when Ayla left that afternoon, she felt she had witnessed something precious.

A woman had made something with her own hands and allowed herself to be proud of it.

A small beginning.

A quiet refusal to disappear.

On the way home, Ayla stopped at a bookshop.

She had not planned to go inside. She was simply passing the familiar storefront when she noticed a display of notebooks near the window.

One of them was dark green, with thick cream-colored pages.

She picked it up.

For months, she had written in the same old notebook, filling its pages with memories of Zain, questions for Nani, and sentences she was not ready to say aloud.

The green notebook looked different.

Unmarked.

Unburdened.

She bought it.

Outside, she stood on the pavement with the paper bag in her hand, feeling strangely foolish.

It was only a notebook.

People buy notebooks every day without turning them into a personal milestone.

But for Ayla, it felt like a decision.

She was allowing herself to begin a new collection of words without first finishing all the old ones.

She could carry both.

She walked home slowly, stopping once to buy oranges from a roadside vendor and again to let an elderly man pass through the crowded pavement.

The world was not transformed.

The traffic still honked. The air still carried the dust of the city. Her heart still hurt when she thought of Zain.

But she noticed things she had not noticed in a long time.

A little boy shared his biscuit with a stray cat.

A woman adjusting her daughter's scarf before crossing the road.

Two friends laughed so hard that one had to stop walking.

Life, in all its ordinary carelessness and tenderness.

Ayla wondered how many moments she had missed while waiting for herself to become someone who no longer hurt.

That evening, she took the green notebook to Nani’s study.

The room had begun to feel different.

The letters still lay in their careful piles. The books were still crowded the shelves. The desk still bores the marks of years of use.

But Ayla no longer felt that she had to solve the room.

She could simply sit in it.

She opened the notebook to its first page.

For several minutes, she did not write.

Then she began.

I used to think that a new beginning had to feel happy.

I thought I would know I was getting better when I woke up one morning and Zain was no longer the first thought in my mind.

I thought I would know when Nani's absence stopped hurting, when the guilt disappeared, when the memories became gentle enough to touch without cutting me.

I am beginning to think I was wrong.

She paused and listened to the sounds of the house.

Her mother was in the kitchen, humming softly as she prepared dinner. A pressure cooker whistled. Somewhere outside, a motorcycle passed.

Ayla continued.

Today, Sana made a kurta for herself.

Hamza called an institute and asked whether it was too late to study architecture.

I bought a notebook.

None of these things have changed in the past.

But perhaps the beginning is not supposed to change the past.

Perhaps it is simply a way of telling the future that we have not given up on it.

She stopped.

The words looked unfamiliar on the page.

Not because they were untrue, but because they belonged to a part of her that she had barely allowed herself to imagine.

She turned to the next page.

At the top, she wrote:

Things I Want to Do, Even While I Am Still Grieving.

She stared at the head.

The list felt frighteningly ordinary.

- Visit Farah again.
- Help Hamza prepare his portfolio.
- Ask Sana if she needs fabric for her next design.
- Plant something in Nani's garden.
- Cook one of Zain's favorite meals with Ammi.
- Read a book without feeling guilty for enjoying it.
- Learn to sit with a memory without turning it into a punishment.

She read the list again.

It was not a promise that she would accomplish everything.

She might forget. She might have had difficult days. She might cross one thing off and leave the others untouched for weeks.

But the list was there.

Evidence that some part of her had begun looking forward to.

Ayla placed the pen down and leaned back in the chair.

For the first time, she wondered what might happen if she stopped asking for grief to give her permission for every small pleasure.

What if she could enjoy a cup of tea without first thinking of the people who were gone?

What if she could laugh and still miss Zain?

What if healing was not betrayal, but another way of carrying him?

She did not know.

But she was beginning to ask different questions.

And that, Nani might have said, was something.

The following Sunday, Ayla visited Farah.

She found her in the garden, trimming the yellow leaves from a potted jasmine plant. Farah looked up when Ayla entered the gate, then set down her scissors.

“You came back.”

“I said I would.”

Farah smiled.

“Yes, you did.”

They sat together on the veranda with tea and a plate of biscuits. For a while, they spoke about ordinary things: the weather, the neighbor's new puppy, and the price of groceries.

Then Ayla took a folded sheet of paper from her backpack.

“I wrote something.”

Farah accepted it but did not open it immediately.

“Would you like me to read it now?”

Ayla nodded.

Farah unfolded the page.

It was a short note about Nani’s letters, about the people she had tried to help, and about the way her kindness had continued after her death. Ayla had written that she did not know what to do with the house yet, but she had begun to wonder whether it could become a place where people could come to read, write, or simply sit without pretending to be all right.

At the end, she had added:

I don't want to turn Nani into someone who saved everyone. I think she was just a woman who knew what loneliness felt like and tried to make it less lonely for someone else.

Farah lowered the page.

For a moment, her eyes shone.

“That is exactly who she was.”

Ayla looked toward the garden.

“I've been thinking about keeping studying open. Maybe letting people use books. Perhaps setting up a table where they can write letters, they don't know how to send.”

Farah was quiet.

“You know,” she said eventually, “your grandmother once told me that a house is not a home because of the people who live in it. It is a home because of what people are allowed to feel inside it.”

Ayla looked at her.

“She said that?”

“She said many things. Most of them when I was trying very hard not to listen.”

Farah smiled sadly.

“I don't think you should rush to make the house into anything. But if you decide to open the doors, I would like to help.”

Ayla felt something warm move through her chest.

“Really?”

“Of course.”

Farah reached for her hand.

“But there is one thing I want you to understand first.”

Ayla waited.

“You do not have to continue your grandmother's work to prove that you loved her.”

The words caught Ayla off guard.

“I know.”

“Do you?”

Ayla looked down at their joined hands.

She had imagined doing something with the house because she wanted Nani's kindness to continue. But beneath that wish, there had been another feeling she had not admitted.

A fear that if she did not do something extraordinary with the life she had left, she would be wasting the time Zain and Nani no longer had.

Farah seemed to understand.

“You are not responsible for making every loss meaningful, Ayla. Some things hurt simply because they happened. You are allowed to build something beautiful afterward, but you do not have to.”

Ayla swallowed me.

“I don't want their lives to become only the way they died.”

“Then remember how they lived.”

Farah's voice was gentle.

“Remember Zain's laughter. Remember your grandmother's terrible habit of giving people second helping when they said they were full. Remember the things that made them themselves.”

Ayla laughed through the sudden tears in her eyes.

“She did that to everyone.”

“Especially to me. I told her once that I could not eat another bite, and she looked at me as though I had personally insulted her cooking.”

“She probably thought you were lying.”

“I was,” Farah admitted.

They laughed together.

The sound was small, but it filled the veranda.

And for a moment, Ayla did not feel guilty about it.

That night, she returned home with a cut from Farah’s jasmine plant wrapped in damp paper.

Her mother found her in the garden, kneeling beside the little green shoot.

“What are you doing, beta?”

“Trying to plant this.”

“Trying?”

“I've never planted anything before.”

Her mother sat on the low garden wall.

“Your Nani used to say that plants are forgiving.”

Ayla glanced at her.

“Did she?”

“She said people were not always patient enough to give them a chance.”

Ayla dug a small hole in the soil and placed the cutting inside.

Her hands grew dirty. The stem leaned to one side, and she had to adjust it twice.

When she finished, the plant looked almost comically fragile.

“Will it grow?” She asked.

Her mother shrugged.

“Allah Jane.”

Ayla laughed softly.

“That's reassuring.”

“It's honest.”

They sat together in the garden as the sky darkened.

After a while, her mother spoke.

“I was thinking about making Zain's favorite biryani tomorrow.”

Ayla's heart tightened.

For a moment, the old instinct returned. She wanted to tell her mother that she did not have to do that, that it might be too painful, that perhaps they should leave the memories alone.

Then she realized that her mother was not asking permission to grieve.

She was offering them both memories.

“I'd like that,” Ayla said.

Her mother nodded.

“We can argue about how much chili he would have wanted.”

“He always said you made it too mild.”

“He said that because he wanted me to add more and give him the whole pot.”

“He was very persuasive.”

“He was very annoying.”

Ayla smiled.

“Yes.”

Her mother looked toward the house.

“I miss him most in the kitchen,” she admitted. “He always came in when I was cooking, stole something from the pot, and then complained that I hadn't made enough.”

Ayla laughed.

“I remember.”

For a little while, they sat with the memory.

It hurts.

Of course it hurts.

But it was no longer a wound. It was also a story, a familiar scene they could hold together.

Ayla realized that this was what she wanted: not a life in which Zain never hurt to remember, but a life in which remembering him could mean more than pain.

She reached for her mother's hand.

“Let's make it tomorrow.”

Her mother squeezed her fingers.

“Together?”

“Together.”

Later, in her room, Ayla opened the green notebook one last time before bed.

She wrote:

Today, I laughed at Farah.

I planted jasmine cutting.

Ammi and I are going to make Zain's favorite biryani tomorrow.

I still miss him.

She paused, then added:

All of these things are true at the same time.

She read the sentence slowly.

For eighteen months, she had lived as though every moment of peace had to be paid for with guilt. She had believed that grief was a narrow room, and that stepping outside it meant abandoning the person she had lost.

But perhaps grief was not a room.

Perhaps it was something she carried out.

And perhaps, with time, she could learn to carry it into gardens, kitchens, conversations, and mornings that held something other than sorrow.

She closed the notebook.

From the window, she could see the faint outline of the garden beneath the night sky. The new jasmine cutting was too small to see clearly, but she knew where she had planted it.

Tomorrow, it might look no different.

The next day, either.

It might be a struggle. It might lose a leaf. It might need more water than she remembered to give it to her.

Still, she will try.

Not because she could guarantee it would grow.

Because it was worth giving it the chance.

Ayla switched off the light and lay down.

For the first time, she did not ask herself whether she had done enough to deserve rest.

She simply allowed herself to sleep.

And somewhere beyond the dark, the smallest beginnings were already taking root.

Chapter Twelve

Behind the Dark, There Is a Light

The biryani was too spicy.

Ayla knew it the moment her mother lifted the lid.

“Oh, no,” her mother murmured.

Ayla leaned over the pot. The fragrant steam rose between them, carrying the familiar scent of fried onions, cardamom, and the kind of chili that had always made Zain drink three glasses of water and insist that he was perfectly fine.

They stared at the biryani.

Then Ayla began to laugh.

Her mother looked at her in disbelief.

“What is so funny?”

“Zain would have loved this.”

“He would have complained.”

“He would have complained while taking a second serving.”

Her mother tried to look offended, but her mouth betrayed her.

“He had no respect for my cooking.”

“Ammi, he once ate half a pot of biryani before you came back from the neighbor’s house.”

“He was hungry.”

“He had eaten an hour earlier.”

“He was growing.”

Ayla laughed harder.

And then, unexpectedly, her mother laughed too.

They stood in the kitchen, laughing over a pot of excessively spicy biryani, and for a few seconds the house sounded like the way it used to.

Not exactly the same.

There was no running down the hallway, no exaggerated complaints from the dining room, no Zain stealing a piece of chicken before anyone had sat down.

But there was laughter.

There was a smell of food.

There was her mother wiping her eyes with the edge of her dupatta, and Ayla reaching for a spoon, and the quiet realization that remembering someone could sometimes bring warmth along with the ache.

When the laughter faded, neither of them rushed to fill the silence.

Her mother stirred the pot.

“I wish he were here,” she said.

Ayla nodded.

“Me too.”

And for once, the words did not feel like the beginning of an endless descent into grief.

They were simply true.

After lunch, Ayla went to Nani’s study.

The house was quiet. Her mother had gone upstairs to rest, and the afternoon sun lay across the garden like a warm shawl.

Ayla opened the green notebook and turned to a fresh page.

She had been writing in it for nearly two weeks now.

Some pages contained memories. Others held conversations she wished she could have had. There were lists of things she wanted to try, small observations about strangers, and occasional sentences that made no sense unless she remembered the day she had written them.

She had written about Hamza's first design class.

About Sana's decision to accept her first paid order.

About Farah sending her a photograph of the jasmine plant she had given her, with the message:

It is still alive. Unlike the last three plants, I tried to give you Nani.

Ayla had laughed so hard that she had nearly dropped her phone.

She turned to a blank page.

Then she wrote:

I used to believe that getting better meant reaching a day when I no longer needed to cry.

I thought healing would arrive like morning, all at once, turning everything bright.

But morning does not erase the night that came before it.

It simply gives us another way to see it.

She paused.

Outside, a breeze moved through the garden. The little jasmine cutting had begun to stand more upright, though its leaves remained small and delicate.

Ayla watched it for a moment before returning to the page.

I still miss Zain.

I still miss Nani.

Some days I wake up and forget, for one beautiful second, that they are gone. Then I remember, and the pain comes back.

But there are other moments now.

Moments when I remember Zain's terrible jokes and laugh before I can stop myself.

Moments when I make tea the way Nani liked it and feel grateful that I knew how.

Moments when I realize I have been living for an hour without measuring my happiness against my grief.

She set down the pen.

That last thought frightened her less than it once would have.

Perhaps because she had begun to understand that healing was not betrayal.

It was not an announcement that the people she loved mattered less.

It was the slow discovery that their love had become part of her, even when their hands were no longer there to hold hers.

Ayla closed the notebook.

Then she stood and began clearing the desk.

She did not know what she would do with Nani’s house. She had stopped trying to decide its entire future in a single afternoon.

For now, she wanted to keep studying open.

She wanted the books to be read rather than left, gathering dust. She wanted the garden to grow. She wanted the letters to remain safe, not as instructions for other people’s lives but as reminders that no one needed to be perfect before they deserved kindness.

Perhaps, eventually, she would invite people to come and write.

Perhaps she would place fresh paper on the desk and leave pens beside it.

Perhaps someone would sit in the room and discover that a feeling they had believed was theirs alone had been carried by another person, too.

For now, it was enough to open the curtains.

She did.

Sunlight spread across the shelves.

The first person to arrive that afternoon was Hamza.

He stood at the front door holding a large cardboard folder, looking more nervous than he had on the day he told Ayla about the design program.

“I hope I'm not disturbing you,” he said.

“You're standing at the door with a folder. That usually means you're either bringing good news or asking me to help you move something.”

“Possibly both.”

Ayla stepped aside.

“Come in.”

They went to study.

Hamza placed the folder on the desk and opened it carefully. Inside were drawings of courtyards, reading rooms, small houses, and narrow spaces transformed by windows and light.

Ayla moved through the pages slowly.

One drawing showed a room with long shelves and a table near the window. Another featured a small garden

enclosed by walls covered in climbing plants. The third was an open courtyard with a fountain at its center.

“You made all of these?”

“Over the last two weeks.”

“They're beautiful.”

He looked uncomfortable.

“Some are better than others.”

“That's true of almost everything.”

He gave her a brief smile.

“I submitted the application.”

Ayla looked up.

“You did?”

“Yesterday.”

“And?”

“I have an interview next week.”

For a moment, she could only stare at him.

Then she stood and hugged him.

Hamza froze.

Ayla immediately stepped back.

“Sorry. I should have asked.”

He blinked, then laughed softly.

“No. It's all right.”

She smiled.

“I'm happy for you.”

He looked down at his drawings.

“I'm terrified.”

“I know.”

“What if I get there and discover I've wasted all these years? What if everyone else is better? What if I have no idea what I'm doing?”

“Then you'll discover those things after you arrive, not before.”

He looked at her.

“That's not very comforting.”

“I'm not Nani.”

“No,” he said. “You're not.”

His voice was gentle.

“And I think she would have liked that.”

Ayla felt a small ache in her chest, but she let it remain.

Hamza gathered the drawings into a neat pile.

“I wanted to ask you something.”

“Go ahead.”

“If you do decide to do something with this house, would you consider making space for a small reading room? I could help you think about the layout.”

Ayla glanced around the study.

The room was full of books, letters, and the quiet presence of a woman who had spent years trying to make other people feel less alone.

“I'd like that,” she said.

“There's no rush.”

“I know.”

She looked out the window.

“But I think I'd like the idea of people coming here. Not because they need to be fixed. Just because they need somewhere to sit for a while.”

Hamza nodded.

“A place where they don't have to pretend.”

“Exactly.”

He studied in the room.

“We could keep most of it as it is. Add a few chairs. Move the desk closer to the light. Maybe put a table in the garden.”

Ayla smiled.

“Hamza, you're designing it already.”

He stopped.

Then, to her delight, he smiled too.

“I suppose I am.”

For the first time, the future of the house began to feel less like a burden she had inherited and more like a possibility she could choose.

Not an obligation.

A possibility.

There was a difference, and Ayla was learning to recognize it.

Sana came the following week with Hiba and a paper bag full of fabric samples.

“I've brought a proposal,” she announced.

Ayla looked up at the desk.

“Should I be worried?”

“Probably.”

Hiba ran into the garden before anyone could stop her, shouting that she needed to inspect the jasmine plant.

Sana placed the bag on the table.

“My first three orders are finished. One client wants another outfit, and two women have asked whether I would make something for them.”

Ayla smiled.

“That's wonderful.”

“It is. Also, I have discovered that people have extremely strong opinions about sleeves.”

“Of course they do.”

“One woman sent me seven photographs to explain the difference between a sleeve she liked and a sleeve she did not like.”

“Did you understand the difference?”

“No.”

Ayla burst out laughing.

Sana laughed at her.

Then her expression grew thoughtful.

“I've been thinking about what you said. About doing something without having to do everything.”

She took a deep breath.

“I don't want to rent a studio yet. I want to work from home for a while, save some money, and see how it goes. I want to enjoy it before I turn it into another thing I have to be good at.”

Ayla nodded.

“That sounds wise.”

“Don't look so surprised.”

“I'm not surprised.”

“You have the face again.”

“What face?”

“The face that says you're pleased with everyone's progress.”

Ayla tried to look neutral.

It did not work.

Sana shook her head.

“Anyway, I thought perhaps I could help with the house. If you want to put cushions in the reading room or curtains in the study, I could make them.”

Ayla looked at the fabric samples.

There were soft creams, muted greens, and a deep blue that reminded her of the kurta Sana had made for herself.

“I would love that.”

“Good. And before you ask, yes, I will charge you.”

“I wasn't going to ask.”

“You were absolutely going to ask.”

Ayla smiled.

“Fine. I will pay you.”

“Excellent. My business is flourishing.”

From the garden, Hiba shouted, “Ammi! The plant is growing!”

Sana closed her eyes.

“Please tell me she is not about to pull it out to check.”

Ayla stood quickly.

They hurried outside.

Hiba was crouched beside the jasmine cutting; her hands held carefully behind her back.

“I didn't touch it,” she announced.

“Good girl,” Sana said.

Hiba pointed to a tiny new leaf.

“Look!”

Ayla knelt beside her.

There it was.

A small, bright green leaf, unfurling at the tip of the stem.

She felt an unexpected rush of emotion.

It was such a little thing. A leaf is no bigger than the tip of her finger. It did not prove that the plant would thrive. It did not promise flowers or shade or years of growth.

But it had appeared.

Quietly.

Without anyone asking it to explain itself.

Ayla smiled.

“Yes,” she whispered. “I see it.”

That evening, Farah came to visit.

She arrived carrying a tin of biscuits and a small stack of books.

“Your Nani would be furious if I came empty-handed,” she said.

Ayla took the books from her.

“What are these?”

“Some of the books she lent me years ago. I thought they should come home.”

They carried everything into the study.

Farah moved slowly through the room, touching the spines of familiar books. She stopped near the window, where the light fell across the desk.

“She used to sit here in the afternoons,” she said. “She would read for ten minutes and spend the next hour looking out at the garden.”

“What was she thinking about?”

“Everything, probably.”

Farah smiled faintly.

“Sometimes she was thinking about me. Sometimes about her sister. Sometimes about the people she is worried about. And sometimes she was simply watching the birds.”

Ayla sat on the edge of the desk.

“I keep wishing I had asked her more questions.”

Farah turned toward her.

“What would you have asked?”

Ayla considered that.

“What she was afraid of. What she regretted. Whether she was ever lonely.”

Farah's expression softened.

“She was afraid of losing people. She regretted the years she spent apart from me. And yes, she was lonely sometimes.”

Ayla looked down.

“I think I wanted her to be someone who had figured everything out.”

“Because then you could have believed that one day you would figure everything out, too.”

Ayla looked up sharply.

Farah sat beside her.

“My dear, your grandmother was wise, but she was not finished. She was still learning when she died. We all are.”

Ayla swallowed me.

“Does it ever stop feeling as though there is something you should have done?”

Farah was quiet for a moment.

“Not always. But the feeling changes. You learn to recognize it for what it is: a thought, a regret, a wish. Not necessarily the truth about who you were or what you deserved.”

She reached for Ayla's hand.

“You may spend years wishing you had said something differently. But you must not spend those years refusing to say anything now.”

Ayla thought about all the people she had avoided since Zain died.

The friends whose messages she had left were unanswered. The relatives had turned away because she could not bear their sympathy. The invitations she had declined because happiness felt like a place she was no longer allowed to visit.

She had thought she was protecting herself.

Perhaps, sometimes, she had been protecting herself.

But sometimes she had been closing doors before anyone could knock.

“I want to do something with the house,” she said quietly.

Farah nodded.

“I know.”

“Not because I think it will make everything better. And not because I think I owe Nani something.”

“What, then?”

Ayla looked around the room.

“Because I want someone else to have a place where they can feel what they feel without being told to hurry up and get over it.”

Farah's eyes filled with tears.

“I think she would have liked that.”

Ayla smiled.

“I hope so.”

Farah squeezed her hand.

“And if you change your mind, she would have understood that, too.”

That mattered more than Ayla expected.

She did not want to turn Nani's kindness into another impossible standard she had to meet.

She wanted to remember her grandmother as a woman who had tried, failed, apologized, loved, and tried again.

A woman who had been human.

A woman who had left the door open.

The following Saturday, Ayla invited her mother into the study.

She had spent the morning moving a few chairs, clearing the table, and placing fresh paper beside a jar of pens. Hamza had helped her sketch a simple arrangement for the room. Sana had offered to sew cushion covers. Farah had promised to bring more books.

Nothing is finished.

The garden still needed work. Several shelves were crowded with boxes. The curtains were faded, and one chair wobbled whenever anyone sat on it.

But the room was beginning to look less like a place where time had stopped and more like a place where something might happen.

Her mother stood in the doorway.

“What are you planning?”

Ayla smiled nervously.

“I was thinking we could open the study one afternoon a week. For people who want to read, write, or sit quietly. We don't have to call it anything yet.”

Her mother looked around the room.

“Who would come?”

“I don't know.”

“What would you do if no one came?”

Ayla thought about it.

“I suppose we'd drink tea and read the books ourselves.”

Her mother smiled.

“That sounds like a reasonable plan.”

Ayla's shoulders relaxed.

“You don't think it's foolish?”

“No.”

Her mother crossed the room and picked up a sheet of paper.

“Your grandmother always wanted people to feel welcome here.”

Ayla nodded.

“I know.”

“But, beta, you must promise me one thing.”

Ayla looked at her.

“What's that?”

“Don't make yourself responsible for saving everyone who walks through that door.”

The words stopped her.

Her mother continued gently.

“You can listen. You can offer tea. You can sit with someone while they cry. But you cannot take their pain away for them, and you must not make their healing your duty.”

Ayla thought of Nani's notebook.

I did not save anyone. They saved themselves, in small ways, when they were ready.

She nodded.

“I promise.”

Her mother glanced toward the garden.

“And you must take care of yourself, too.”

“I'll try.”

“No.” Her mother smiled and touched her cheek. “You must allow yourself to be taken care of, too.”

Ayla felt tears gather in her eyes.

She leaned into her mother's embrace.

For a moment, she was a child again, standing in a kitchen after a bad day, certain that the world was too difficult and that she had to become someone stronger before she could ask for comfort.

Her mother held her.

“You don't have to be strong every day,” she whispered.

Ayla closed her eyes.

“I know.”

And this time, she almost believed it.

On the first afternoon they opened the study, only one person came.

A young woman from the neighborhood arrived shortly after four. She stood at the door for several minutes, twisting the strap of her handbag between her fingers.

“I'm sorry,” she said. “I saw the note outside and wondered if this was really open to everyone.”

“It is,” Ayla replied.

The woman looked uncertain.

“I don't actually know what I'm supposed to do here.”

“Nothing in particular.”

“Do I have to talk?”

“No.”

“Can I just sit?”

Ayla smiled.

“Of course.”

She showed the woman to a chair near the window and offered her tea.

The woman accepted.

For nearly half an hour, they sat without speaking. The visitor turned the pages of a book but did not seem to read it. Ayla sorted through some papers at the desk.

Eventually, the woman began to cry.

Ayla looked up.

She did not rush toward her. She did not ask what had happened or offered the usual promises that everything would be all right.

She simply set down her papers.

“Would you like some more tea?” She asked softly.

The woman shook her head.

Then, after a moment, she nodded.

Ayla poured another cup.

When she placed it on the small table beside the chair, the woman whispered, “My father died last month.”

Ayla sat down across from her.

“I'm sorry.”

“I thought I would be able to handle it. Everyone keeps telling me I need to be strong for my mother.” She wiped her face. “I don't know how to be strong for anyone. I can barely get out of bed.”

Ayla felt the familiar ache of recognition.

“You don't have to know how to do everything right now,” she said.

The woman stared into her tea.

“I don't know who I am without him.”

Ayla looked out the window.

She remembered the months when she had believed that the world had ended, and everyone else had simply failed to notice.

“I don't think you have to answer that question today,” she said. “Maybe today you only have to be someone who misses her father.”

The woman began to cry again.

Ayla stayed.

She did not try to turn the moment into a lesson. She did not tell the woman that time would heal everything or that there was a reason for her suffering.

She let the silence be silent.

Eventually, the woman finished her tea.

Before she left, she stood beside the door and looked back at the room.

“Can I come again?”

Ayla smiled.

“Whenever you need to.”

After the woman had gone, Ayla remained seated for a long time.

Her hands were cold.

She felt sad for the stranger, and the sadness had stirred her own grief. She wanted to go upstairs, close her bedroom door, and sleep until the feeling passed.

For a moment, she wondered whether she had made a mistake.

Then she remembered what her mother had said.

You cannot take their pain away from them.

She had not saved the woman.

She did not need to.

She had simply offered her a chair, a cup of tea, and a little time in which she did not have to pretend.

Perhaps that was enough for one afternoon.

Perhaps it was enough for both of us.

That night, Ayla sat alone in the morning.

The chairs were empty again. The cups had been washed and put away. A book lay open on the table; its pages marked with a paper bookmark.

The room was quiet, but it no longer felt abandoned.

Ayla took Nani's final letter from the drawer and read the last lines.

Light does not ask the darkness for permission to enter.

It comes through the smallest opening.

Let there be an opening.

She folded the letter and held it against her chest.

For months, she had imagined light as a day when she would wake up and feel whole again. On a day when she could remember Zain without crying, think of Nani without longing, and walk through the world without the sensation that something essential had been taken from her.

But that day had not arrived.

Perhaps it would not arrive exactly as she imagined.

Perhaps light was the moment she laughed over a pot of biryani.

Perhaps it was Hamza submitting an application after eleven years of silence.

Perhaps it was Sana making a dress for herself, or Farah bringing old books back to a house she had once been afraid to enter.

Perhaps it was a stranger sitting in a quiet room and discovering that she could cry without being asked to stop.

Perhaps it was Ayla herself, still grieving, still uncertain, choosing to open the door.

She looked around the study.

Nothing about the room was perfect.

The paint was peeling near the ceiling. Dust remained on the highest shelves. The garden needed attention, and the old curtains would eventually have to be replaced.

But there were books to read.

Paper to write on.

Chairs to sit in.

And a small green shoot outside the window, growing one leaf at a time.

Ayla opened her notebook.

She turned to the last page and began to write.

Dear Zain,

I made your biryani today.

It was too spicy.

You would have loved it.

She smiled through her tears.

I still wish I had answered your call. I think some parts of me will always wish for that.

But I am beginning to understand that I cannot change the last thing I did. I can only choose what I do next.

I am trying to live in Bhai.

Not because I miss you less.

Because I loved you then, and I love you now, and I am beginning to believe that love does not require me to disappear.

She stopped writing.

Her chest hurts. Her eyes burned. The empty chair across from her seemed impossibly familiar.

But beneath the grief, there was something else.

A quiet sense of having told the truth.

She continued.

I wish you could see the garden.

I wish Nani could see the study.

I wish for so many things.

And I am learning that wishing does not mean I have failed to accept what happened.

It means there are things I will always love, even when I can no longer reach them.

Ayla put down the pen.

She did not know whether she would ever stop crying over the unanswered call.

She did not know whether the study would become the place she imagined, or whether the woman who had visited that afternoon would return.

She did not know what next year would bring, or how many difficult mornings still lay ahead.

But she knew this:

Tomorrow, she will open the curtains again.

She would water the jasmine plant.

She would make tea for her mother.

And if someone came to the door, she would invite them in.

She would continue to miss the people she had lost.

She would continue to learn how to live among the people who remained.

She would make mistakes. She would have days when the darkness returned so completely that she could not remember what hope felt like.

On those days, she would try to remember that a dark day was not the same as a dark life.

And she would begin again.

Not perfect.

Not fearless.

Just honestly.

Ayla closed the notebook and placed it beside Nani's letter.

Then she stood and switched off the lamp.

At the doorway, she turned back for one last look.

The room was dim, but the moonlight had found its way through the window, falling across the desk where the letters lay.

A thin, silver line of light.

Small.

Quiet.

Real.

Ayla smiled.

For the first time, she understood that the light beyond the dark was not a place where sorrow could never reach her.

It was the possibility of a life in which sorrow would not be the only thing waiting.

She stepped into the hallway and closed the door gently behind her.

The house was still full of empty chairs.

It was still full of memories.

It was still full of people she would never stop missing.

But it was no longer a house of loss.

It was a place where someone had cried and been allowed to cry.

A place where a forgotten dream had found its first page.

A place where a woman had learned that wanting something for herself did not make her selfish.

A place where a girl who had mistaken guilt for love was slowly learning to be kinder to her own heart.

And perhaps that was how the light had always worked.

Not by erasing the darkness.

By giving people, a reason to keep going through it.

Years later, Ayla would remember that first afternoon in the study as the beginning of something she had not yet known how to name.

Not because everything changed that day.

Very little did.

The jasmine took months to flower. Hamza's studies were difficult, and there were nights when he wondered

whether he had made a terrible mistake. Sana's small business grew slowly, with quiet weeks and unexpected setbacks. Farah still spoke of the years she had lost, though she learned to speak of the years she had left, too.

And Ayla still missed Zain.

There were birthdays that hurt. There were songs she could not listen to without stopping what she was doing. There were moments when she saw a man with his walk or heard a laugh that sounded almost like his, and for one impossible second she forgot.

There were nights when she returned to Nani's final letter and read the same sentences over and over.

Healing was not a straight road.

It was not a staircase that carried her steadily upward.

It was a path that sometimes bent back toward the places she thought she had already passed.

But she learned to keep walking.

She learned that she could remember without reliving every moment. She learned that she could regret something without condemning herself. She learned that happiness did not arrive to replace the people she had

lost; it arrived beside their absence, asking only whether she might make room for it.

And slowly, the house changed.

The study became a small reading room. The old desk remained by the window, with paper and pens always available. Sana made cushions for the chairs. Hamza helped redesign the garden, adding a narrow stone path and a bench beneath the jasmine.

Farah brought books.

Ayla brought tea.

People came with grief, with uncertainty, with unfinished letters and dreams they were embarrassed to name. Some spoke. Some sat quietly. Some returned many times; others came once and were never seen again.

Ayla did not promise them that everything would be all right.

She had learned that love was not the same as certainty.

Instead, she offered them what Nani had offered her.

A place to begin.

On a warm evening in early spring, Ayla stood in the garden and watched the jasmine flowers open along the wall.

Their scent drifted through the air, delicate and unmistakable.

She closed her eyes.

For a moment, she imagined Nani beside her, adjusting the shawl around her shoulders. She imagined Zain standing near the gate, making some ridiculous comments about the garden and asking when dinner would be ready.

The memories came.

So did the tears.

Ayla let both arrive.

Then she opened her eyes.

The garden was full of light.

Not the blinding light of a world without pain.

The gentle light of an ordinary evening, falling on a place where people had been sad, where they had been loved, where they had tried again.

Ayla looked toward the open door of the house.

Someone had arrived.

She heard a hesitant voice from the hallway.

“Excuse me? Is this the place where people can come and sit for a while?”

Ayla wiped her cheeks, smiled, and walked toward the door.

“Yes,” she said. “It is.”

The stranger hesitated.

“I don't really know what to say.”

Ayla remembered the first time she had stood in Nani's study, frightened of the letter in her hands. She remembered believing that she had to become a different person before she could deserve a different life.

She stepped aside.

“You don't have to know yet,” she said. “Come in.”

The stranger crossed the threshold.

Behind them, the evening settled softly over the garden.

And the light stayed on.